Espresso Shots

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24557119.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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Fluff, Fluff and Angst, Implied Sexual Content, Mild Smut, Kissing, Drunk Adora (She-Ra), Probably a ton of fluff, and little angst, Alternate Universe - Coffee Shops & Cafés, Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Hurt/Comfort, Anxiety, Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Slice of Life, Trauma

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Part 2 of Coffee & Espresso

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Espresso Shots

by Alexsdttp

Summary

This is a series of connected one shots that skip through time in the AU I created in the previous work. You could read these without that but there is some plot stuff that might get confusing. There's a lot less directly from the show in this one as it focuses more on the resolving of previous events and character growth.

Adora is extremely clumsy and Catra is secretly a super sappy girlfriend.

Affogato

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Several months had passed and today was Adora's birthday. Catra had planned an entire day of things for them to do. But first. She had to wake her up. Adora was not a morning person and it could be really challenging to get her up.

"Hey Adora" Catra said carrying a tray full of food into her bedroom.

"Fffivvvee mroowrr minnuttzzz" the lump in the middle of the bed called back.

"Nope. Gotta get up."

Adora pulled the blanket off her head and peaked out through half shut eyes. "Is that coffee?"

"Yes, but if you don't sit up, I'm going to drink it."

She shuffled up to a sitting position before Catra placed the tray over her lap before sitting in the bed next to her. Catra wasn't much of a chef but with Bow and Glimmer's help they had managed to make a pretty nice breakfast complete with waffles, eggs and bacon. Catra had decided to make the breakfast extra special by making Adora affogato, technically a dessert drink but she knew Adora would love it. She loved every food she tried with a somewhat frightening appetite.

"Happy Birthday by the way" Catra said as she stole a piece of bacon.

"Aww you remembered?" Adora said with her big dumb eyes sparkling.

“Well obviously. I mean I am the best girlfriend ever.”

“I mean I guess you’re alright” Adora said with a wink. “What’s in this drink?”

“Just try it dork” Catra snorted. She liked seeing Adora tease her back. She’d been worried that she was too sweet but Adora had a real wild side and could pull some serious pranks.

“Catra….”

“Yes?”

“YOU CAN PUT ICECREAM IN ESPRESSO?” Adora shouted at her before shoving her face into the cup and making ridiculous slurping sounds.

“Yes, you can in fact combine things” Catra said teasingly. Adora never ceased to amaze her with how energetic she could be. How she could smile and everything just felt better inside Catra. And how she could be a totally cute idiot covered in ice cream.

“How have you never told me this before? Can you make this every day? Do you sell this at Horders?” Adora said with the sugar buzz energy of a five-year-old. She had of course managed to get ice cream on her face.

Catra gently grabbed the collar of Adora’s shirt and pulled her in for a kiss, tasting the sweet vanilla gelato and bitter espresso. She gently bit Adora’s lip causing her to draw a slight gasp. Adora grabbed her waist and tried to pull her on top, forgetting the tray was there and almost spilling everything. Catra chuckled and kept kissing her.

“HAPPY BIRTHDAY ADORA!” screamed Bow and Glimmer from the doorway. Glimmer’s face flew into panic as she noticed Catra mostly on top of Adora.

“Bow! Cover your eyes” Glimmer said trying to reach to cover his face.

Catra shifted to sit back down, a little annoyed that they had distracted them. She couldn't be too mad though since they did help her make breakfast. And she'd have plenty of time alone with Adora later.

"Hey guys! Sorry we were just….having breakfast" Adora didn't know what to say and started blushing. Catra just snorted at her.

"Right…well we got you presents!" Glimmer said as they both carried in a wrapped box for her.

Catra grabbed the tray off Adora's lap so she could get up and hug them. Everyone hopped onto the bed to watch her open the gifts.

Adora started very carefully removing the wrapping paper from Bow's present, trying not to rip it at all. All three of them shifted their eyes between Adora focusing intensely on the task and each other. None of them had been expecting her to be so meticulous. After she was halfway done unwrapping the first box Catra groaned.

"Please Adora….just…please you gotta go faster. This is torture and it's not even my gift" Catra pleaded.

"But I like the wrapping paper. It's got little horses on it" she said without even looking up.

Catra sighed and slapped her hand to her face.

"I'm just messing with you guys" Adora said smirking as she ripped through the rest of the paper.

"You're such an idiot" Catra said giving her a gentle shove and sigh of relief. She would have had to strongly consider breaking up with her if she was going to open every present like that.

Bow had gotten her a red varsity jacket with a heart on the back and a gift card to her favorite sporting equipment store. Adora let

out a little excited noise and immediately wrapped herself up in the jacket.

"I love it! Thank you Bow" Adora said giving him an awkward half-sitting hug.

"You're very welcome. The gift card is from both of us" Bow said hugging her aggressively.

"Open mine open mine!" Glimmer said practically forcing the present between the two.

Adora ripped the wrapping paper off quickly this time. She pulled out a photo frame with a picture of the four of them smiling and hugging from after Adora had won the ninja race. Adora smiled and wiped a tear from her eyes.

"Glimmer I love it. Thank you" she said giving her a hug.

Adora made a grabby hands motion to Catra to bring the food tray back and she went back to eating her breakfast while they hung out.

"Sthoo whaaa wee dooin thuudaayy?" Adora asked with most of a whole waffle in her mouth, a little syrup dribble on her chin.

"You'll have to finish your breakfast and find out. Are you two about ready to go?" Catra asked.

"Gotta change but almost ready….We'll uh catch y'all later" Bow said making finger guns and backing out of the door. Glimmer looked at him, looked back at them, gave a shrug and left the room. Catra groaned. This was going to be a long day. The best day. But a long day.

"So don't make a big thing about it but I need you to wear something today."

Adora raised an eyebrow and smirked. "Oh yeah? You want me to dress up for you? I've got my white and gold outfit in the closet if

that’s what you meant.”

“No, you idiot. I mean yes. But not right now. Here. Just put this on when you’re done being covered in syrup. I’m gonna go change and help clean up the kitchen” Catra said as she left a bag of clothes on the end of the bed for her.

Catra went to the bathroom and looked at the pile of clothes. She sighed. The things she did for love. She put on the western style red plaid shirt, jeans, a belt with a stupidly big buckle, black cowboy boots and black cowboy hat. She checked herself out in the mirror, whipping her tail back and forth out of annoyance. Adora better love this or she was going to throw a fit. She went out to the kitchen and found Bow and Glimmer in similar outfits. Glimmer had chosen a purple shirt with pink fringe, how she found that is a real mystery, and light tan cowboy boots. Bow was wearing a fringed suede leather vest unbuttoned with a white shirt underneath and matching fringed boots. He tipped his hat with one hand while the other stayed tucked into his jeans.

“Mornin’ ma’am” he said with a terrible fake accent.

Catra just stared at him. “Is he gonna be like this all day?” she asked Glimmer.

“Yessss” she responded, drawing out the sound while wrapping an arm around his waist.

The three of them were only waiting for a few moments before they heard some muffled excited screams from Adora’s room. There were some thuds and then stomping as Adora came flying out of the room in her outfit. Glimmer had helped Catra pick out a white western style tank top, dark jeans, red cowboy boots, and a palm leaf cowboy hat. Adora ran out, nearly falling, before leaning against the wall and shooting off imaginary finger guns. She blew the even more imaginary smoke from the barrels of both guns before smiling, jumping and grabbing all three of them in a big hug.

“I have no idea why we’re dressed like this, but I love it!” she said, her voice muffled as she squeezed them all.

“Oh we’re not doing anything. We just wanted to look stupid today” Catra said.

Adora let go and looked a little sad but still smiling.

“I’m just kidding you dummy. Are you ready to go?” she said as she put her hand out.

Adora did some happy wiggling motions and grabbed her hand.

“Yeehaw” Bow yelled.

Thaymor Ranch and Trail Ride was just a short bus ride out of Brightmoon proper. Catra had worked in secret, with the help of Bow and Glimmer, for several months to set everything up for today. The more she got to know Adora they more she realized she was a total horse girl. It was embarrassing for Catra to admit she liked a horse girl but at least Adora had many redeeming qualities.

As soon as they got there and Adora saw the horses she started losing her mind. She went from super excited to embarrassed and shy. Was she really fan girling over a horse? Seriously, so embarrassing for Catra.

The employees set them up each with their horse for the ride and helped them get up into the saddle. Catra laughed when she saw they had put Glimmer on the smallest horse they had, a tan hafinger. Catra was riding a black quarter horse, bow was on chestnut thoroughbred, and Adora was on a white quarter horse.

Catra could hear Bow whispering how much he loved his horse and gently stroking its neck. Adora was just sitting there with her hands on the reins, smiling with her mouth open. Catra rubbed her face and laughed. She had no idea why she liked this group of people so much.

The ride was pretty enjoyable and relaxing Catra had to admit. Her horse seemed to have a very lazy attitude and she was fine with that. They stopped after a couple of hours to have a lunch that was prepared by the ranch workers. There was a little time before they had to start riding again so Catra and Adora went and laid down to watch clouds. Adora rolled onto her side and pressed a kiss into Catra's cheek.

"Thank you. This has been so much fun and really sweet of you."

"Yeah well don't tell anyone but I'm actually kind of enjoying this" Catra said as she traced her fingers along Adora's arm.

"Your secret is safe with me… horse girl."

"Okay. Nope. Just cause it's your birthday doesn't mean I can't murder you." Catra pushed Adora over and sat straddling her. She tried to be angry, or at least fake being upset but Adora looked so incredibly happy and she couldn't stop herself from smiling. She gave her a quick peck on the lips before helping her up.

The last hour of the ride was uneventful other than Glimmer's horse stopping to poop. She looked horrified as the rest of them just laughed and kept going. They took a few photos of Adora on her horse, hugging her horse, brushing her horse, etc. before they headed to catch the bus back into the city. Everyone fell asleep on the ride back, Catra snuggled up into Adora's side.

Once they got back to the apartment, they all decided to take showers to get the dust off and change back into regular clothes. Bow decided to keep wearing his outfit because of course he did. Adora had just finished her shower and Catra was in her bedroom waiting for her.

"Hey while you were showering, I got a call from Scorpia that she needs me to stop by and fill out some paperwork. I'm really sorry but do you mind if we head over there before dinner tonight?" Catra asked.

“Yeah no big deal. I mean it’s not like I know what you have planned anyways.”

It took them a little bit longer than normal to get dressed because Catra got distracted by post-shower Adora, but they finally were leaving. Bow and Glimmer’s door was closed and Adora seemed confused when they didn’t say goodbye. Catra told her they’re probably taking a nap.

Catra let Adora walk into Horders first and watched her jump as everyone shouted.

“Happy Birthday!” came from everyone inside.

Catra had organized a big surprise party and had managed to get all of their friends to help. Perfuma had donated some flowers for decoration, Spinerella and Netossa had set up some games, Sea Hawk and Mermista brought food, and Scorpia and Lonnie had gotten decorations put up. Entrapta, Bow and Glimmer were there too. Catra being the manager had put up a notice that the store was closed for the day and bought a bunch of gelato to make affogato for everyone.

Adora started crying really hard and Catra looked concerned.

“Hey what’s wrong?” she asked turning Adora to face her.

“This is just the nicest thing anyone has ever done for me” Adora said through sobs. Catra hugged her and kissed her forehead. Once Adora got ahold of herself she went around hugging everyone in the room.

Everyone was having a great time at the party, enjoying the music and food. Catra watched Adora enjoying herself as she made coffee drinks for people. She cut off Adora after the second affogato for fear that she wouldn’t sleep for two days. Adora was sad until she handed her a cup full of whip cream and caramel sauce.

Catra leaned against a wall just enjoying a moment of peace to herself.

“Hey Wildcat. You did a great job with this party today” Scorpia said as she came to sit in a chair next to her.

“Thanks for all your help Scorpia. How’s everything with Perfuma?”

“Oh it’s great! She’s great and we’re thinking of moving in together when the lease ends.”

Catra didn’t respond. She hadn’t thought about her lease ending in a few months. And with Scorpia leaving that meant she’d have to find a new roommate.

“Hey. Maybe you should talk to Adora about living together” Scorpia said. She was too good at reading Catra’s thoughts.

“Yeah. Maybe.”

“Won’t know till you ask Wildcat” Scorpia said with a shrug and excused herself to go mingle.

Catra stayed there just thinking. Could she really picture herself living with Adora? Waking up every morning with her and not having to split her time between their apartments? She was nervous but smiled to herself picturing what their life could look like together. She was still lost in thought when Adora grabbed her arm and pulled her out to dance to a slow song. She pressed their foreheads together and put her arms up on Catra’s shoulders.

“Catra thank you so much. Seriously. This is the best day I’ve ever had” Adora said with her eyes closed and smiling. Catra leaned her head against Adora’s shoulder and hugged in tighter, their dance becoming just a slow rocking back and forth motion. She didn’t respond as she enjoyed the ephemeral beauty of the moment.

The night went on and eventually people started to leave. Catra worked on cleaning up the shop as Adora said her goodbyes. Scorpia and Lonnie stayed to help but she let them go pretty quickly since they had set up everything for her. She was just about finished with the dishes as Bow and Glimmer were the final people to leave. Adora waited outside for her as she locked up for the night. She grabbed a blanket she had left there and they started to walk back to the apartment hand in hand.

"Hey, I know it's late but I've got one more place to take you if you're up for it" Catra said.

"I had sooo much espresso. I'm ready for anything" Adora responded with a squeeze of her hand.

Catra led her over to Whispering Woods and into the forested area. It was almost pitch black but Catra's eyes easily adjusted as she led Adora through to a large grassy clearing. She put the blanket down and they laid down to look up at the stars. After a few minutes of laying there just holding hands and enjoying the night sky Catra sat up and pulled a jewelry box out of her pocket.

"This is for you too. Happy Birthday Adora" Catra said handing her the box. Adora sat up and opened it revealing a small gold heart necklace. Adora didn't respond and Catra got nervous that she didn't like it.

"Um I know you didn't wear jewelry a lot, but I thought you might like it. If you hate it I can return it and"

Adora stopped her mid word by pushing her over and kissing her. Adora's hand gently stroked her cheek.

"I love it. I love you" she whispered between kisses. Catra melted into it, feeling the weight of Adora on top of her.

She was still nervous about asking Adora to live with her but for tonight none of that mattered.

Chapter End Notes

If anyone has suggestions or feed back I would love to hear it :) Also taking prompts

Adora's Bad Day

Chapter Summary

Adora has a bad day but learns to open up.

Chapter Notes

What happens when I finally try and make an Adora POV chapter? I make her have a bad day!

Today had not been a good day for Adora. Her manager called first thing in the morning to tell her that the project she had been working on was scrapped. Six months. She had been working nonstop on the project for six whole months and they just decided to not go through with it. On top of that they were reassigning her to the computer systems management team. Sure, she knew how to do the job but she liked being in security analytics. The more she worked the more phone calls and emails from upset clients asking for immediate fixes. Asking for things she didn't even have control over.

Everything in the apartment was a mess and disorganized. Catra's clothes were everywhere. She went to get a cup of coffee and on the first sip spilled it all over her shirt. Seriously today could be done now. She went to her closet and grabbed a new shirt only to put it on and find a big hole in the armpit. She could feel the anger bubbling up in her core. The feelings that she worked so hard to control quickly flooding to the surface. She ripped the shirt in half and let out a frustrated scream. She tried to stop herself. Stop the overreaction. But the anger had boiled over to the surface and all she could do now was find somewhere to direct it. She quickly threw on another shirt, grabbed her keys, and slammed the front door on the way out.

She balled her hands into tight fists as she hastily walked to her destination. She could feel people moving out of her way, parting in fear, but her eyes were fixated on the sidewalk. She just had

another block. One more block and then she could let the anger explode. Someone didn't move out of her way quickly enough and she felt the impact of the shoulder on hers.

"Hey watch it" the voice called.

She stopped, her knuckles turning white from the force of squeezing her hands so hard. She let a breath out of her nose and turned to look at the stranger. Her eyes burned daggers, the muscles in her arms flexing from the strain of her clenched fists.

The stranger made eye contact, an instant look of fear, before quickly darting off. She slowly turned back around and kept walking.

Her hands hurt by the time she made it to The Crimson Waste. Her eyes scanned the gym searching for Huntara. She found her off to the side watching people running obstacles.

"Everything alright?" Huntara asked.

"I need to punch something. Now." Every word was sharp on her tongue. She was seconds away from having a meltdown.

"Come with me" Huntara said as she led her out into the back area behind the gym.

Huntara grabbed a sledgehammer and slammed it against a large old tire. She handed the hammer to Adora and stepped back to watch.

Adora slammed the tire. At first it was slow and calculated but soon her pace was rapid and nearly out of control. She felt the strain of every muscle in her arms and back as she swung. Her body broke out in a sweat and she kept swinging, kept lashing out. Her muscles were screaming for oxygen and she felt her vision fading but she was still swinging. The skin on her hands blistered and split. Hot tears streaked down her face, her eyes burning and almost too blurry to see. As she raised the hammer above her head to swing again, she felt a hand grab the hammer.

Huntara firmly grabbed the hammer with both hands and stood there. Adora's whole body was drained as she tried to catch her breath. The rage inside her receding and replaced by utter exhaustion. She let go of the hammer and sank to her knees. Huntara moved to sit on the edge of the tire.

"Thank you" Adora said, her voice barely audible between the sobs. Huntara clapped a big hand onto her shoulder.

"I like you kid. You're talented. You're stubborn. You swing a mean sledgehammer."

Adora let out a small breathy laugh and tried to dry her tears. She moved to sit next to Huntara on the tire, curling forward to lean her head on her knees.

"You wanna talk about it?"

"I just get this way sometimes. Out of control. And I know I'm overreacting, but I can't make it stop. It's just all the little things. They pile up and pile up and then all of the sudden I'm losing it." She took a ragged breath before continuing.

"It's gotten better. I've gotten better. I can usually feel it coming. Get out of the situation. Away from people. But today I couldn't." Tears started to slowly drip down her face.

Huntara wrapped an arm around her and pulled her in. Adora leaned her head against her meaty torso.

"I used to get that way sometimes. Used to punch holes in the walls just to keep myself from screaming."

"How'd you make it stop?"

"I didn't stop it. I learned to control it. To wield my anger as a weapon. Well that and I met my wife. She really mellowed me out" Huntara said with a chuckle.

Adora thought of Catra. Of how good she felt in her warm furry arms. How her tail would wrap around her leg when they laid down, a silent refusal to let go, to be apart. Catra wasn't weak but she had a fragility to her. She hid it deep within her but let Adora see it when she was feeling vulnerable.

"I don't know if I can tell Catra about this. She needs me to be strong. She's been through so much. I can't… cant burden her."

"If she loves you, and I can tell you she does just from the way she looks at you, then she can handle it.

They sat in silence for a moment. Adora knew Catra loved her. But this was a part of her she had tried her best to hide from everyone. A form of weakness she never let anyone know about.

"Well kid I gotta head back in. Feel free to beat up my tire some more but be careful. Your hands look pretty rough."

Adora sat there for a second. "Hey wait…Is that job offer still open?"

"When can you start?" Huntara said with a smile.

Adora put her hands up palms out to show the ripped skin. "Give me a couple days?"

"Deal. We'll talk about it later. Welcome to the team kid."

Adora sat for a while longer as she processed the day. Her body ached from the exertion and her hands stung. When she finally got up every muscle ached in protest. She had overdone it, but the pain and exhaustion were better than the anger. Better than being out of control. All she wanted to do was sleep and hopefully wake up back to her normal self.

She walked home slowly, the sun on her back doing little to warm her. She reached in her pocket to grab her phone to text Catra. In her haste to leave she had forgotten to grab it. She wasn't sure what time it was but Catra was probably still working. Adora

wanted to see her, to lay down and hold her, but she couldn't handle the energy required to talk to people at her work.

She unlocked the apartment, Bow and Glimmer were still out somewhere, and collapsed onto her bed. Her hands ached but she kept them from touching the bed and almost instantly fell asleep.

She awoke some time later to the sound of water running in the bathroom. Her room was dark except the light coming in from the open doorway. A figure walked in and sat down.

"Hey Adora" Catra said softly. She sounded worried.

"Catra…I…" Tears started to flow again.

"Hey it's okay. Let's get you cleaned up though" Catra said as she gently pulled her arm.

Catra led her to the bathroom where the she had drawn a bath for her. She helped Adora undress and get into the tub before pulling out some first aid supplies and sitting on the edge of the tub.

"I got home from work and you were passed out. I saw your hands and figured you needed to sleep off whatever happened."

Adora had gotten to know Catra well over the months they had been dating. She knew the way she laughed when she was really happy, the way her eyes lit up when she saw a bird outside the window, the way she flicked her tail when she was nervous. Catra's ears were tipped back slightly, her tail twitching slightly as she cleaned Adora's hands. She wanted to ask what happened but didn't want to push.

"I'm okay now. It was just a bad day." Adora knew it sounded hollow. Like she was hiding things.

"Okay sure." Catra's voice edged on annoyance. Adora watched as her tail flicked harder. She knew Catra must be afraid to ask what happened. Afraid something might really be wrong.

Adora tried to focus herself. She took a deep breath. "I've always had this…problem. I've tried to control it. But sometimes it's too much and the anger takes over. Today was just a really bad day."

Catra finished wrapping her hands and sat there, refusing to look at Adora but waiting for her to continue.

"I'm sorry I didn't tell you sooner. It's just been a long time since it's happened, and I thought I was getting better."

"You can tell me things you know. I can handle it." Catra's tail was twitching almost non-stop now.

"I know. I'm sorry Catra. Really. I talked to Huntara today and she made me realize I was being stupid."

"Did she do that to your hands?" Catra asked. Her tail had slowed its twitching and she held her gaze for a moment.

"No that was all me unfortunately." She told her everything that had happened and then the sledgehammer exercise. She told her about the anger outburst she got sometimes and how most of the time she managed but there would be days like this.

Catra visibly started to relax as her tail slowed even further and she let out a sigh. Adora sat forward to try and put her head against Catra's arm. Catra moved her arm out of the way but returned it to gently scratch at Adora's scalp with her claws. Her back broke out in goosebumps from the sensation. Suddenly she needed to touch Catra, to kiss her, to feel her fur against her skin. She grabbed Catra's hand and brought it to her mouth, kissing each of her knuckles. Catra gave a small grin and leaned down to kiss her. Adora returned the grin with a wicked smile as she leaned back and pulled Catra into the tub and on top of her.

Catra let out a high pitch scream as her hands and feet touched the water. Adora tried to hold her in place but she quickly wiggled out of her grasp and launched herself out of the tub.

“Adora! I clean up your hands and this is how you repay me?” She was shaking her hands and feet out, trying to get the water off.

Adora couldn’t help but laugh at her as a blush spread across her face. She looked miserable but still so cute.

“Aw come on Catra. I just wanted to cuddle.”

Adora pulled the drain plug from the bathtub and stood up fully naked in front of Catra, which made her blush for some reason. Adora loved to make her blush. It wasn’t usually as easy as being naked in front of her but it was always enjoyable. It’s not like she hadn’t seen Adora naked before even. Catra threw a towel at her before sticking her tongue out and leaving. Adora smiled to herself as she gingerly wrapped up in the towel and followed.

Catra was sitting there pouting, her arms crossed and looking far too cute for someone so grumpy. She locked the door behind her, let the towel fall to the floor before walking over to the closet to put on some pajamas. Catra blushed again and Adora smirked.

“I’m sorry I got you wet” Adora said as she took Catra’s hand and kissed it. She didn’t respond but also didn’t pull her hand away.

“I can get you wet in a different way if you want” Adora said into her ear, trying not to laugh at the stupid joke. She bit her bottom lip and smiled.

“Ugh you’re the worst” Catra said before letting out a small laugh. The laugh she only did when it was just the two of them.

Chipped

Chapter Summary

> Catra can be a little melodramatic when things don't go the way she wants.

Chapter Notes

> I have a few specific chapters planned out but if anyone has suggestions I would love to hear them :)

Catra was going to be homeless. There was just no way around it. She had accepted it. She'd live in a cardboard box in the break area behind Horders and sleep on a mattress of old coffee beans.

Okay. Maybe she was overreacting. Being a teensy bit too dramatic as she laid on her bed face down into the mattress. But could anyone blame her? Scorpia. Her best friend. Her only real friend. Had just told her that she was going to move in with Perfuma when the lease ended in a few months. Entrapta had taken it well as far as she could tell? Entrapta didn't seem to show much emotion and then went on a rant about experiencing new social situations or something like that. But Catra. She had been upset. Hurt even. Scorpia was her friend. She wasn't supposed to leave. Sure, Scorpia could have a life outside of Catra and be happy with Perfuma or whatever. But she hadn't thought this day would come so soon.

It's not like she could just ask Adora. Sure, they slept at each other's places every night and shared each other's closets and secrets and pretty much everything. But they'd only been dating for seven months. That wasn't enough time to move in with someone was it? No. No way. Plus, what if Adora broke up with her? Then she really would have to sleep on coffee beans in an alleyway. What if she hated that Catra threw her clothes everywhere and was messy? What if Bow and Glimmer decided they didn't like Catra and made Adora kick her out? She couldn't

compete with their friendship. What if an alien invasion took over the city and brain chipped everyone and she had to stop Adora from being a stupid hero and trying to save everyone? Okay so that last one. Really too dramatic even for her. And also. Unlikely. But an endless onslaught of what ifs filled her brain.

She laid like that, face down, kicking the mattress absent mindedly until she flipped over to stare at the ceiling. She balled up her fists and pressed them into her eyes, letting out a groan. Maybe she could just sleep in the back of Horders and no one would notice. At least she'd always have coffee then.

She heard the door to her apartment open. It was probably Scorpia coming to tell her she was leaving town and never coming back and never wanted to see Catra again. Or Entrapta wanting to run some experiments on her. The last time she had reluctantly agreed to help she lost the fur on the tip of her tail from "unexpected electrical shock" as Entrapta had put it. It had taken her weeks to grow her fur back! She heard someone walk up to her doorway and she groaned.

"If you're an alien invader you can just chip me now" Catra grumbled still staring up at the ceiling.

"First, don't sound so excited to see me. And second, are you saying you want me to probe you?" Adora asked from the doorway.

Catra sighed. "Sure why not. I'm gonna be homeless anyways so maybe I can walk around with a sign that says, 'Aliens probed me and all I got was this dumb sign'."

"Nah. Doesn't roll of the tongue quite the right way." Adora walked in and laid down stare up at the ceiling next to her. "So just to be clear, you're gonna be homeless because aliens want to chip you?"

"Yeah that about sums it up" Catra said before sighing and continuing. "No. I found out Scorpia's moving in with Perfuma

when our lease ends and I don't think I can afford to live on my own. Entrapta is alright but she's a little much and Scorpia's kind of like the glue that keeps us all together."

Adora let out a sarcastic snort and moved to lay on her side looking at Catra. When Catra still refused to look away from the ceiling she grabbed her chin and pulled her face to look at her.

"You know you practically live at my place already right?"

"Yeah but what if you secretly hate me and break up with me and then I have to live in a box in the alley?"

"What? No. Okay. You've forced me to do this."

Adora practically slammed her body on top of Catra to crush her in place like a very heavy weighted blanket. She gave her a quick kiss on the forehead and looked her directly in the eyes.

"Catra, you're being stubborn. Do you want to live with me when you're lease ends? Because I think I'd like that. If you're ready. Otherwise I have a big box apartment that you could probably sleep in."

Catra tried to turn her head away but Adora kept a firm grasp on her chin to hold her head in place. "Okay…fine….maybe I want to live with you too. I'm just scared you know. I love you a lot but I don't want you to hate me when I move in and I'm messy and dumb."

"Your stuff is already all over my room and it's fine. It would be great if you could clean up a little but we can make it work. And I've never hated you and that's not gonna change. Unless I get chipped by aliens and have no control. But that's kind of not on me at that point."

Catra chuckled before taking a deep breath. "You sure?"

Adora gave her a light kiss. Her hand moving from her cheek to wrap to the back of Catra's neck, sending a shiver down her spine.

“Yes, I’m sure.”

You Promise?

Chapter Summary

Catra moves in and learns to open up.

Chapter Notes

This goes from reeaalllyyy close to smut to just the saddest thing I've ever written.

Adora, Bow, and Glimmer had all helped Catra move her stuff into their apartment and were working on unpacking. Catra had bought everybody sandwiches and they were taking a break before getting back to it. Even though it was exhausting, Adora was really excited to have Catra move in. Things had been going great between them and she wanted to take this next step. Catra still seemed wary but she figured it would take some time to adjust to the changes. She didn't seem to be someone that handled change well, but Adora would be there to help.

"It looks like I mostly just need to organize my clothes and put away some random things so Bow and Glimmer if you wanna be done that's totally fine" Catra said.

"Oh I don't mind. Always glad to help" Bow said before picking up another box. He had started to open it when Catra jumped and ran off the bed.

"Um this one is fragile. I can handle it" she said blushing and grabbing the box away from him before hiding it deep in the closet. Adora was curious now. The box was just labeled "Bedroom 7", no clear indication of what it might be. Catra was obviously shy but she had hid something in there and Adora needed to find out.

Bow looked at Adora confused but shrugged and headed out of the room, Glimmer following and closing the door behind her.

Adora stared at her girlfriend who was standing there awkwardly. She smirked as she started to head to the closet. Catra blocked her at the doorway.

"What's in the box Catra?" Adora smiled and tried to pick her up but she latched her claws into the doorframe.

"Hmm? What box? There's no box? You're losing it Adora."

"Riiighhhttt." Adora had to know now.

She figured her best route of attack was a full-frontal assault. She pressed her body firmly against Catra's as she grabbed the back of her head and pulled her in for an intense kiss. Their lips and teeth smashed together from the force as Adora felt heat began to pool inside her. As badly as she wanted to see where this went, she needed to know what was in that box. But distracting Catra a little more certainly couldn't hurt.

She grabbed Catra's hips and pushed her against the doorframe, her hand sliding down Catra's leg to have her wrap it around her waist. She pushed her hip forward causing her thigh to press between Catra's legs. Catra's moan and gasp for breath were music to her ears. Her claws extended as they clung to her shoulders, her hips, anywhere she could reach. Each mark leaving behind a symphony score of all the notes Adora drew from her. She could feel herself losing curiosity in the box as she focused more and more on drawing more sounds from Catra's lips. Her left hand slid up Catra's side before firmly grasping her mane while her left slipped down to her ass, pulling her tighter against Adora's thigh. Her lips were hungry with a desire that would not be denied. Adora lost herself in the moment. Maybe she could get the box later. Yeah. No need to ruin this perfect moment. Girlfriend now. Box later.

Many moments later they laid curled up together in bed, clothes spread all over the room. Adora held Catra tightly to her side as she pressed kisses into her hair and stroked her cheek. Catra

responded with purring and nuzzling, the soft fur slightly ticking Adora's exposed skin.

"So you're gonna tell me what's in that box right?"

Catra grunted and flicked her tail. She got up and walked over to the closet. Adora making sure to check out her beautiful naked girlfriend the whole time of course. She walked back and sat on the bed opening the box. She threw some clothes onto the floor, Adora rolled her eyes, before pulling out a small stuffed elephant.

"My mom gave me this before….before she died."

Catra had mentioned once or twice that her mom had passed but never really in detail. Adora didn't want to press, knowing how painful it must be to talk about. She gently rubbed her hand on Catra's thigh, trying to let her know it was alright.

Catra cleared her throat before continuing. "She…I don't remember her. I was really young when...it happened. But I guess she gave me this. I know it's embarrassing to have a stuffed animal."

"Not at all. Come here" Adora said as she let Catra come back to snuggling against her side. Catra held the elephant tightly in her hand resting it on Adora's stomach. Her tail wrapped tightly around Adora's ankle.

"I love you" she whispered into her hair. She could feel the drip of silent tears falling onto her bare chest. She held Catra tighter against her as she rubbed her back. The silence hung heavy but she waited patiently, afraid that even breathing too loudly would force her walls up even higher than before.

Her voice was mumbled from being pressed into her side, but she could just barely make out her words. "My aunt raised me after my mom died. I never met my dad. My aunt's a total bitch, but I guess it was better than being an orphan….sorry. I didn't mean it that way."

Adora had grown up in foster care. She had done everything to be personable, charming, a great student and yet none of it had worked. The families that met her always ended up choosing another kid. It had been really hard at first. She cried herself to sleep most nights. But as she got older, she got stronger. She learned to accept it. When she got into weightlifting in high school it helped her feel like she belonged somewhere. She could push every thought out and just focus on the weight, the execution, the feel of the strain of every muscle. She was good at it. Good enough to get a scholarship to a local college and worked twice as hard as everyone to be the best.

"Don't apologize. I get it. Sometimes the family we're born into can be terrible. Or it's taken away."

Adora stroked an ear on the elephant as Catra laid there quietly.

"I named him Mr. Hugglesworth" Catra said quietly.

Adora couldn't help but chuckle a little. She pictured tiny Catra with her crazy hair holding the stuffed animal and it made her heart ache. It was so sweet and so incredibly sad.

"You're my family now Catra. Nothing really bad can happen to as long as we have each other"

Catra lifted her head to look in her eyes. Adora smiled weakly as she stroked her cheek. She lifted her head to gently kiss Catra, tears starting to flow from her eyes.

"You promise?"

"I promise."

Schrodinger's Girlfriend

Chapter Summary

The perks of unpacking

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra is part feline. She knows it. Adora knows. Everyone knows it. But that didn't make her cute.

Not. Cute.

It didn't make her someone's pet. Everyone could just fuck right off if they thought she was going to be cute and play with string or chase a laser beam.

As hard as she tried though. There was always….

Urges.

Desires.

Things she wanted to do that were just really…catlike. Sometimes it was little things like having Adora rub her ears but that's just because Adora knows how to rub just right. To get that one spot that's really hard for her to scratch herself. Other times maybe she did want to chase sun beams around the room. Not that she'd ever admit it or do it in front of someone.

Catra's tail flicked back and forth as she glared at the last box on the floor. It had taken her a couple weeks to full unpack and after some not so subtle hints from Adora she was done unpacking the very last box. But now it was empty on the floor. Tempting her. Looking just ever so inviting.

She crossed her arms and squinted her eyes even further. Stupid box.

She probably wouldn't even fit.

But then again….

No. She wasn't going to succumb to this stupid desire.

But no one was home.

And maybe if she tucked her legs in just right…

She walked out to the kitchen to make sure for the third time today that no one was home. Bow and Glimmer had class. Adora's second day at The Crimson Waste was today but maybe she would get to come home early and entertain Catra.

Catra: *Hey Adora*

Adora: *yes my love?*

Catra snorted at the new term of endearment. She had been testing out a few lately. Pumpkin (terrible). Kitten (NEVER ever EVER gonna happen). Force Captain (didn't even understand that one).

Catra: *I unpacked the last box*

Adora: *yay good work streudel*

Catra: *you're so weird*

Adora: *I know! Be home in a few hours. Love you*

It was just Catra.

And the tantalizing box.

She groaned and paced back and forth.

“Fine! Is this what you want?” she yelled as she stood inside it.

“Stupid box” she muttered to herself.

She just stood there with her arms crossed. Waiting for something to happen. For the idiotic desire to go away.

Catra let out a sigh before sitting cross legged in the box. Well at least she fit. And it did make her feel better.

She sighed and accepted her defeat by curling up in a ball in the bottom of the box.

Box: 1 Catra: 0

She hadn’t noticed how tired she was before. Or how comfortable this box was. Kind of reminded her of how Adora held her when she curled up after a nightmare. Maybe she’d take a quick nap.

She jolted awake at the sound of keys in the front door lock. Her feet and head slamming against the sides of the box. When had she even fallen asleep?

She panicked. The bedroom door was open still. If it was Bow and Glimmer she’d never live this down.

She quickly tried to jump out of the box but it was too tight of a fit and all she managed to do was tip the box and herself over.

“Catra? Are you home?” Adora called from the kitchen. On her way to the bedroom. There wasn’t enough time to get away from the box.

She flipped the box over all the way and hit under it.

“Catra?” Adora was looking for her. Maybe she’d just leave? Catra was an idiot and this wasn’t going to work.

“Catra, I see your tail poking out.”

Shit. She thought she had tucked it in. She grabbed it and pulled it under the box. Okay. She was out of options.

Catra got up on her hands and feet and tried to crawl out of the room with the box on top of her head. She was pretty sure she was heading the right way. She could hear Adora laughing but she kept going.

She smacked into the wall causing the box to tip backward off her. Her eyes went wide as she looked back at Adora.

She was clutching her sides with tears in her eyes from laughing so hard. Catra blushed and ran out of the room to hide behind the couch.

“Catra….wait” Adora called to her. Still clearly laughing and struggling to breathe.

She felt the couch shift as Adora sat down, still catching her breath.

“Come on Catra. I know you’re back there.”

“Only if you promise to not call me cute.”

“I promise to not call you cute Catra. Now come out of there dummy.”

Catra crawled out and sat down on the couch next to her, knees up to her chest with her face tucked into them so she wouldn’t have to look at Adora.

“I can feel you staring at me Adora.”

“Sorry. I just love you a lot you know” she said as she rubbed Catra’s shoulder and leaned her head against her.

“Yeah well I guess I love you too” Catra said. Trying to hide a small smile that was slowly creeping to her lips.

Without any warning Adora pushed her over and smushed her into the couch. She kissed her forehead firmly with a loud “mwah” sound that made Catra laugh.

“Streudel though? Really?” Catra asked. Raising her eyebrow and smiling wide enough that her fangs poked out.

Adora just shrugged and smiled back at her before her hand found that one spot on her ear and rubbed it. Instantly Catra was purring and closing her eyes.

Maybe sometimes it wasn’t so bad to give in to instincts.

Chapter End Notes

Someone drew some awesome fanart of Catra with a box on her head and yeahhhh

https://www.deviantart.com/yuri-murasaki/art/Catra-the-Cat-775360869

Woo Woo

Chapter Summary

Catra has a long day and Adora gets drunk

Chapter Notes

Going to be switching POV in this so there's lines to help indicate that.

Adora's first week at The Crimson Waste had gone great. Huntara had given her a tour and had her shadow one of the other trainers. A few people had recognized her from the Brightmoon ninja race and were excited that she had joined the gym. She had blushed a little as she showed some of her tricks and technique tips, but she loved it.

Adora needed to celebrate. She was just about done with work when she checked in with the "Best Friends Squad" group chat to see if everyone was free.

Adora: *This week was so fun! We should go out and celebrate! Meet up at KoS?*

Glimmer: *Yeah! I'm so glad you had fun. Bow and I are free in an hour or so*

Bow: *<3 great job Adora! See you soon* 😊

Catra: *Ughhhhh I'm stuck at work still. Meet you guys there*

Adora: *Love you babe. Can't wait to see you after work*

Glimmer: *Ewwwww*

Adora rolled her eyes and put her phone away. She finished putting away equipment and organizing everything before she headed out.

“Hey kid. You did great today” Huntara said as she smacked Adora on the back so hard that she almost fell forward.

Ouch. Adora tried to pretend like that hadn’t hurt. “Seriously thank you so much. I already love it here. And I’m happy to talk about improvements. Or maybe some new classes. I’ve got a whole list of things here somewhere.”

“Woah woah slow down kid. I’m happy to hear your ideas but there’s plenty of time. Don’t you have a girlfriend to get home to?”

Adora smiled to herself, a slight blush spreading across her cheeks. “Yeah she’s stuck at work for now but I’m meeting up with her and my friends for some drinks tonight. Wanna come with? I’d be happy to introduce you to everyone.”

“Nah it’s alright kid. You go have fun. I’ve gotta get home to the missus” Huntara said with a wink before leaving.

Did everyone wink in her life? Adora pondered the strange nature of everyone around her as she walked to KoS. The bar, Kingdom of Snows, or KoS for short, was a stylish martini bar in the heart of the city. Everything was white with soft blue lighting to give the feel of an ice room and there was plenty of small nooks with booths to sit in if the bar was full. It was a few more blocks than she normally wanted to walk but it was a nice night out and she was enjoying the time to herself. She wanted to see Catra and tell her about how the day went but she’d see her later.

When she got there somehow Bow and Glimmer were already there and hugged her immediately.

“We’re so proud of you Adora!” Glimmer shouted into her shoulder.

“First round’s on me” Bow said.

They all shuffled into a booth before a server brought their drinks over. Adora had no idea what he had ordered for the three of them, but it was delicious. Some sort of peach and cranberry martini that she was going to have to get more of.

They sipped on their drinks as Adora told them all about how the first week had gone. Sure, they had seen her throughout the week but with their school schedules it had been hard to go into detail.

She could feel the booze working its way into her system and was feeling really good already. There was a warmth in her stomach that was nice and the only thing that could make this better was if Catra would show up. She smiled to herself as she thought about her girlfriend. Everything had been going great since she moved in. Adora had started to picture a future together. Okay more than picture. She had planned out so many different little details like where they would live and how many kids she wanted. But she would be happy with anything that happened if Catra was there.

"Whatcha smiling about Adora?" Glimmer said giving her shoulder a gentle nudge.

"Huh? Oh. I was thinking about Catra."

"Ugh you two are too cute it's almost gross. Seriously."

Adora let out a sarcastic snort. "You're one to talk. I see how you and Bow look at each other all the time."

Glimmer stuck her tongue out as Bow kissed her on the cheek.

Adora stuck her tongue out right back at her before leaning over and giving her a hug.

"Alright this round's on me. What was that drink called Bow? It was sooooo good" Adora said as she got up to head to the bar.

"It's a Woo Woo" Bow said non-chalantly.

She stopped walking forward and just turned back to stare at Bow. She must have misheard. No way that was a real thing. Adora bit her lip to try and keep herself laughing. She looked over to Glimmer who had her hand up to try and cover her own laughter.

"What? It's not like I named it" Bow whined.

Adora and Glimmer both bust out laughing at the same time. Glimmer was almost in tears as Bow hugged her, only making her laugh harder. Adora made the motion to signal a trucker to honk their horn as she shouted "Woo Woo!" She could barely breathe, and her stomach hurt from laughing so hard.

She tried to catch her breath and straightened her shoulders. "Alright. Time to get Serious….Woo Woo!" She immediately fell back into a fit of laughter.

"Alright I'll just go order for you since you're clearly busy" Bow said. Adora was still laughing and snorting as she handed Bow some money.

The two girls flopped into the booth trying to catch their breath and stop laughing.

"Ugh if I laugh anymore I'm gonna puke" Glimmer said grabbing her stomach.

"Okay. We got this." She took a deep breath and tried to focus. "How's school been going?"

"Pretty good. My thesis project is taking forever but I can't believe it's already my last semester."

What's the plan for after graduation?" Adora tried to keep her tone casual but she was secretly anxious. She hadn't been in Brightmoon long, but she loved living with Bow and Glimmer. If they left she would miss them terribly.

“Not sure yet. A lot of students get job offers at the end of the semester when the senior thesis presentations happen. I’m just still in shock of getting this far I guess” Glimmer said with a shrug.

“I’m sure whatever happens…. Or wherever you end up you’ll be great Glimmer” Adora said giving her friend a hug again.

“Don’t worry Adora. Bow and I aren’t going anywhere. We’ve already talked about it and Brightmoon is our home. We’ll find jobs here and make it work. We can’t mess up the Best Friend Squad. Not when we just finally got you here.”

Just then Bow came back with the drinks and they all clinked glasses.

Adora was really starting to feel great. Just really good. She felt herself swaying back and forth to the music in the bar and smiling.

“Let’s do shots” Glimmer demanded as she charged the bar, dragging a smiling Adora behind her to the bar.

Adora wasn’t paying attention but all of the sudden there was a drink in front of her and she shouted “Cheers!” before downing the shot. She cringed. What a gross thing. Nothing like the yummy drink from before. Her throat and stomach felt warm though which was just really nice.

“Doing okay Adora?” Bow asked.

“I’m fiiiinnneeeee” Adora responded.

The room was spinning a little. When did that start? It didn’t matter though because her mouth tasted bad and she needed to fix that pronto.

“Bow. Glimmer. It’s time.”

Neither of them responded and just stared at her. She sat up straight and put on her most serious face before waving for the bartender to come over.

"Excuse me Mr. bartender sir. My friends and I would like to purchase…" she paused to make sure how many people she had come with. "…purchase 3 Woo Woos please and thank you and good night."

Adora smiled. She was proud of herself. She had said the drink with the funny name without even laughing. Maybe she had slurred her words a little but probably not.

The bartender stared at Adora before turning to Bow and Glimmer.

"Okay… no idea how she got drunk so quickly but she's cut off after this. You two keep an eye on her."

Adora took the drink but glared at the bartender. What a mean person to not give her more alcohol. She was going to have to tell Catra about this. Catra! She had almost forgotten she was coming. Where was she? She should text her.

Adora: *Caahhhrhrrttaaa whherr yuo?*

Catra: *Oh boy you're drunk already? I'm on my way. Drink some water dummy.*

She smiled at her phone. Catra was so nice and cared so much about her. And just so pretty. The prettiest. And soft. And….

"Adora? You in there still?" Bow asked with a hand on her shoulder.

“Yayyy there’s a rainbow!” Adora shouted before finishing her drink.

“Okay…that made no sense. Let’s get you some water.”

The room was starting to spin a little more and everything was a little blurry. Bow’s face swam into view and then there was a water glass in her hand. Not as good a Woo Woo, but the water was nice and cool and refreshing.

She went to spin around on her bar stool when the whole word started to tip over. Before everything went horizontal though there was a warm arm holding her up.

Today had been a rough day for Catra. Work had been alright, but she had spoken with her lawyer and they were ready to move forward with the case. Which meant she would need to testify against Prime in court. She would do it. But it still made her uneasy knowing she would have to be in a room with him again. She reflexively rubbed her neck where he had hurt her.

She tried to push the thoughts of the day away as she walked to KoS. She could only imagine how drunk Adora was by this point. And she doubted Bow and Glimmer would be watching to make sure she didn’t get trashed.

Catra walked in the bar and spotted Adora almost immediately. Even from the doorway it was apparent that Adora had gotten very drunk. Her head flopped back and forth as she tried to talk to Bow about something. She could see her trying to do some sort of flailing spinning motion and watched as she started to fall off her stool. Bow didn’t see it happening since Glimmer was in just as bad of shape. Catra rushed forward and wrapped her arm around Adora’s back just before she would have fallen.

“Hey Adora.”

“Catraaaaaaaaaa! My beauttiffulll girlfriend. I knew you’d come back for meeee.”

Catra chuckled and kissed her cheek. “I see you’ve been having a good time. I’m here to take you home.”

“More like I’m here to take you home” Adora said as she poked a finger into Catra’s chest and laughed. Catra just rolled her eyes.

“Yeah drink with ussss Catraaa” Glimmer said nearly falling onto Adora before Bow could prop her up. So she couldn’t hold her alcohol either. Of course, they were friends.

“No Catra’s right. It’s time to take you princesses home.”

Catra mouthed “thank you” at him as she tried to get a grip on the floppy Adora. She somehow melted into a puddle of a human making it extremely difficult to get a good hold on her.

The bartender looked thrilled as the four of them left, Bow and Catra both half carrying, half dragging a drunk girlfriend.

The cool night air felt great compared to the stuffy bar and Catra breathed a sigh of relief. She had never been big about bars. Too many drunk people doing stupid stuff. Like getting really drunk and having to be dragged home.

Adora flopped forward and Catra nearly dropped her face first onto the sidewalk before catching her. How could anyone be this floppy? She looked over to Bow who had given up and was just bridal carrying Glimmer. She debated if she was strong enough but knew Adora was pure muscle and way heavier than she could lift. She shifted Adora to have her behind her with her arms around her neck. She was choking Catra a little but at least she couldn’t fall forward.

“Mmmm so warm” Adora mumbled into her back as her feet dragged behind her. Catra grunted with the effort but kept going.

Getting the two girls up the stairs had been nearly impossible. At one-point Adora had just laid fully down on the stairs with a dumb drunk grin on her face. Bow had managed to get Glimmer into the apartment and came back to help drag Adora the rest of the way.

Catra let Adora flop onto the bed as she got her undressed and into some pajamas. She even managed to get her to sit up long enough for some water before she tipped back over and immediately fell asleep. Catra snorted but sat on the bed next to her causally stroking her hair. She kissed her hair before getting herself ready for bed.

As soon as she crawled into bed Adora hummed and snuggled up against her side, resting her head on Catra's chest. She stroked her hair again as she stared at the ceiling.

"Catra…yerr the besss" Adora mumbled.

Catra sighed and closed her eyes.

Adora woke up to a pounding headache and horrible dry mouth. It was dark and she didn't feel Catra in the bed with her. She tried to open her eyes, but the room started to spin.

"Catra?" she asked to the dark room.

She heard shuffling from somewhere over by the window. And then a reassuring hand rubbing her back.

"I'm right here. You okay?" Catra pushed the hair out of her face.

"Headache. Couldn't sleep?" Adora mumbled.

"Yeah but it's okay. Let's get you some water."

Adora cautiously rolled over and sat up in bed. If she kept her eyes closed it didn't seem to be too bad. Catra placed a cup in her hand and she drank the whole thing while Catra stroked her arm.

"Come back to bed?" Adora asked as she laid back down.

Catra didn't respond but curled up behind her, pressing her whole body tightly against Adora's back. Catra seemed upset but her

head was still pounding, and she couldn’t keep awake much longer.

“Talk…morning… Catra” she said before falling back asleep.

Emotional Support

Chapter Summary

Catra makes a new friend and tries to open up more

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora hadn't woken up early enough for Catra to say goodbye in the morning, which was alright. She wasn't sure what to say about everything with the lawsuit. It was just something she had to deal with. She was grateful that Adora had let her borrow money for the lawyer but that didn't mean she wanted to tell everything about it. She rubbed her neck as she walked to work.

Things had been running pretty smoothly at Horders. Catra's team respected her and she did her best, well better, to not yell at them when things went wrong. The improvements she had made to reorganize the shop had made everyone's lives easier and also been reported to upper management, which had made her look good.

Paperwork was still not her strong suit though. It was just all so tedious. There had to be four different forms just to get one thing to happen. And there was just. So. Much. Paperwork. She groaned and left the office to see what Scorpia was up to. Maybe she could bribe her into helping.

Scorpia wasn't in the back room. The shipment had been put away for the day already. She wasn't in the front of the shop either.

"Hey Lonnie, you seen Scorpia?" she said poking her head out from the kitchen.

"She got all excited about something behind the dumpster and ran off over an hour ago. Can I go on break soon?"

“Yeah sure let me just find Scorpia first.”

Only Scorpia would want to check out the dumpster. She cared a lot about her friend, but she could be really weird. Catra missed her a lot since they didn’t live together anymore. Even though she saw her all the time at work it just wasn’t the same. She wanted to hang out outside of work but didn’t want to come off as needy.

She headed out back to the dumpsters and found Scorpia. Just crouched down next to the dumpsters making cooing noises. Not weird at all.

“Scorpia?” Catra asked tentatively. If she was trying to coax a rat out from behind there Catra was going to lose it.

“Shhh shhh shh Catra come here” she whispered and motioned with her pincers.

“Scorpia I swear if it’s a rat…”

She rolled her eyes and crouched down next to her to peer behind the dumpster.

Two turqouise blue feline eyes reflected back at her in the dark. Well it wasn’t a rat.

“I’ve been trying to get them to come out for an hour now. I even brought out some milk. They just keep meowing back there.”

A strand of Catra’s hair shifted and tickled her nose just then and it made her sneeze.

The cat meowed back.

“Okay that is just so…” Scorpia started to say before Catra slapped her hand across her mouth.

“Don’t you dare say it” Catra glared at her.

Scorpia pursed her lips and didn't finish the sentence. Smart move.

Catra groaned and put her hand out to try and get the cat to come out. It moved cautiously out and Catra finally got a good look at it. It was an all grey short hair cat with admittedly pretty eyes and no collar around its neck. Its fur was covered in garbage and it looked hungry but otherwise healthy.

It sniffed her hand before bumping its forehead into it. She moved slowly to stroke its ear and it began to purr. Scorpia shifted and it hissed, backing up slightly.

"Hey Scorpia, can you just back up a bit. I think two people is too much for them."

"Oh right sure thing Wildcat."

The cat hissed more until Scorpia was sitting quietly at the break table. It got braver as it came out and sniffed Catra's legs before rubbing against them. Catra would have thought it was cute, but their fur smelled horrible. She wrinkled her nose and sneeze again. The cat meowed back at her before going to drink all the milk Scorpia had put out.

"Wow they really seem to like you Wildcat! You should name them."

"What? I mean. Maybe?" Catra thought about it for a minute. "Melog." The cat meowed in response to the name. Huh. It was just the first thing that popped into her head. She didn't know why but it just seemed right.

The cat seemed to instantly bond with her. Enough so that she was able to rub its fur with a wet cloth to clean it up a bit. Well. Now what she thought.

Catra: *Hey…does our lease allow pets?*

Bow: *Maybe?*

Glimmer: *Let's get a dog!*

Catra: *Dogs suck. But also this…*

She sent an image of her with Melog headbutting her face.

Adora: *OMG! Can we keep them???? Pleasssseeeeeeee*

Bow: *SO CUTE!*

Glimmer: *We can check the lease tonight. Bring them home with you!*

She'd gotten so wrapped up in dealing with Melog that she had forgotten about Lonnie. She didn't want to just leave them outside though now.

"Well I guess you're gonna have to stay in the office until I'm done."

Melog meowed at her and scratched at the door to the shop. She picked them up and carried them inside, Scorpia following behind. She tried to lock them in the office but they immediately darted out and twisted between her legs.

"Okay….I guess you can run around? But I'm kicking you out if you cause trouble."

Melog meowed back again.

She was probably breaking at least half a dozen Horders rules and not to mention some food safety rules but it was just a one-day thing. She'd take them home and figure out what to do then.

Melog followed her to the front of the shop and hopped up by the register, sitting patiently on the counter as she took over for Lonnie. They meowed at every customer that came up, who all

doted over the well-behaved cat. Catra rolled her eyes. For a dumpster cat they sure did seem to be an attention whore. Melog was getting the shop quite a few bigger than normal tips though. Might not be such a bad thing to have a shop cat.

As soon as Lonnie was done with break she headed back to the office, Melog hot on her heels. She finished some paperwork and the weekly order before she was done for the day.

"Ready to go Melog?" She asked the cat as she rubbed its ears.

Melog purred and meowed back.

The whole walk home Melog walked right next to her. Weirdest cat she'd ever seen.

As soon as they got into the apartment Melog darted off to go smell everything and jump into anything they could find.

"Oh now you're gonna be a normal cat? Don't break anything….Anybody home?"

No answer. She figured Adora was probably at work for awhile still but Bow and Glimmer's schedules were pretty erratic. Maybe if she tried to get to know them better she'd actually know when they'd be home. Adora had tried to get her to hang out with them on her own but she always came up with an excuse to not. She wasn't avoiding them or anything. She just didn't know if she trusted them. If they really wanted to be her friends or just put up with her because Adora liked her.

She looked around and found Melog standing on the kitchen counter just staring at her.

"Off the counter Melog. Want some food?"

Melog meowed and hopped down to wait by the fridge. She found some leftover chicken tenders and pulled the breading off before feeding them. She'd have to get some real food for them but for now she jumped onto the couch to laydown and watch some TV.

Melog hopped up onto her chest and curled up to go to sleep. She pet them and felt herself falling asleep too.

She woke up because there was a lot of whispering coming from somewhere in the room. She peeked an eye open and saw Bow, Glimmer, and Adora all just staring at her with big googly eyes. Bow was taking photos and she growled at them. Melog felt her shift and moved to stand on her as they hissed at the newcomers.

"Can you not give me a hard time right now?" Catra tried to keep her tone calm. There was a very angry weird cat standing on her and did not want to be it's scratching post.

"Alright. Sorry. Do your thing" Adora said as she cautiously walked over and sat on the floor.

Catra gave a gentle pet to Melog who calmed back down and purred. They meowed in Catra's face, chicken scented, before hopping down to sniff Adora. Melog looked back at Catra before putting their front paws on Adora's shoulder and licking her face.

Adora let out a squeal that made Catra melt. She really wasn't sure how this was going to go but they seemed to be getting along well.

"Everybody this is Melog. Melog, Everybody" Catra said as she sat up on the couch.

Melog meowed and came back to sit on Catra's lap and went back to napping.

Bow and Glimmer offered to go pick up some cat food and supplies for her so she wouldn't have to leave Melog alone. Adora got up and came to sit down next to her, Melog peeking an eye open at her before going back to sleep.

"Well it looks like we have to keep them" Adora said as she pet the sleeping cat.

Catra just sat there appreciating the comfort of Melog and the closeness of Adora.

“Hey I’m sorry we didn’t get a chance to talk this morning. Are you okay? You seemed off last night.” Adora asked.

Catra’s tail start to flick back and forth betraying her emotions. Melog shifted and flicked their tail too. Weird coincidence.

“It’s nothing. Just couldn’t sleep” Catra lied. She was upset. She just didn’t know how to talk about it.

Melog got up to sit and stare into Catra’s eyes.

“What? Now you’re going to give me a hard time too?” she asked Melog. They flicked their tail in response.

“Catra?” Adora asked.

“Ugh fine. Melog is good at telling my emotions or something weird like that. Weird dumpster cat thinks they know everything” She grumbled.

Melog meowed. Adora rubbed Catra’s arm and waited for her to continue.

“I…I guess I’m nervous. About the lawsuit.”

Melog headbutted her chest.

“About seeing Prime again. I just didn’t wan to burden you with it.”

Adora leaned in, pulling Catra’s chin towards her and kissed her softly on the lips. She could feel the tension in her shoulders relax. Melog purred.

Adora pressed their foreheads together. “You’re not a burden Catra. And I know it’s hard to talk about stuff but I am here for you whenever you want to talk.”

Melog stood up on Catra and headbutted both of them. Catra snorted and smiled before kissing Adora again. She pulled away slightly to rub Melog's ears.

"I think Melog might be your emotional support cat."

Catra stuck her tongue out and glared. Melog betrayed her by licking Adora's arm.

Adora laughed at the ticklish sensation and Catra couldn't help but laugh too.

"Yeah well they don't know everything…But thanks. I'm sorry I didn't say anything. I just didn't want to ruin the night. And I don't know what to say really. He's just super creepy."

"I'll be there with you okay? You don't have to go through this alone. Bow and Glimmer support you too. Don't be afraid to give them a chance."

Catra nodded.

"Alright Melog. You need to go because I wanna make out with my girlfriend" Catra said giving them a gentle shove. They let out a tiny growl before running off somewhere.

Catra smirked before pulling Adora in closer.

"We've got a few minutes before Bow and Glimmer get back right?" Adora asked between kisses. Her hands already pulling Catra onto her lap.

"Plenty of time" she responded.

Catra bit her lip and smiled.

Chapter End Notes

Wild Melog Appears! I picture them as a russian blue cat for this but feel free to picture whatever :)

Away

Chapter Summary

Catra works even harder to open up

Chapter Notes

Another changing POV chapter

Well this ended up being way longer than I expected but I think it turned out okay :)

“Why can’t she send someone else?” Catra asked with a pout.

“Catra we’ve talked about this” Adora responded across the room.

“I know” Catra said as she visibly deflated. Adora couldn’t deny how cute she looked wrapped up in a blanket on their bed. Melog was curled up next to her with their eyes closed, tail gently flopping up and down.

Adora stopped packing to sit on the bed and hug her. She gently cupped Catra’s head to turn her face towards her. She went back to averting her eyes as soon as Adora let go to pull the blanket off Catra’s head. Adora grabbed her comb from the bedside table and brushed her hair. She hadn’t cut it still and it was nearly to her shoulders. Catra let out a very quiet purr but looked miserable.

She felt bad for leaving so close to Catra’s court date but Huntara had asked her to go and represent the gym at one of the biggest conventions in the area. She really didn’t have a choice.

“It’s only a couple of days. And besides, Bow and Glimmer will be here for you if you want to hang out with them or get to know them or try and be friends.”

“Wow. Subtle much” Catra said with an eye roll.

Adora sighed. “I wish you would try harder to get to know them. They’re my best friends Catra.”

Catra sat staring down at the bed and didn’t respond. However, Melog perked up and came over to stand on Adora’s leg. She smiled at Catra as she pet Melog. They hadn’t been there long but Melog really did seem to be good for Catra.

“Ugh fine….I’ll try harder with them” Catra grumbled.

“Thank you, my love. Now I really need to go” Adora said as she grabbed her bags and headed to the door. She felt a hand grab her wrist and stop her. Catra’s hand slid down to hold hers as her other hand held her cheek and pulled Adora’s lips into a tender kiss. It was warm and soft and filled with so much sadness. It was going to take all of her strength to leave her for the next few days.

“I love you Adora” she said with her eyes still closed.

Adora kissed her one more time before hugging her tightly. “I love you too.”

As soon as Adora was gone, Catra wrapped herself back up in the blanket and laid down on her back to stare at the ceiling. Melog came and of course had to lay right on top of her. Purring like a big dumb idiot cat.

“You think you’re so smart don’t you? Standing on Adora so she gives you attention.”

Melog meowed at her and flicked their tail aggressively.

She stuck her tongue out right as Melog went to paw her face. Melog’s paw practically going into her mouth.

“Ugh gross. I’ve seen what you do with those paws” she said as she tried to lick her arm to get rid of the taste.

She laid there for so long that she started to doze in and out. Melog contently purring and napping too.

Sometime later she woke up to the obnoxious sound of Bow and Glimmer shushing each other and whispering out in the hallway.

"Either come in or let me sleep" she shouted.

There was a little more whispering before she heard them at the doorway.

"Hey Catra…." Bow said cautiously. She could tell he was pitying her. She didn't need his or anyone's pity. But she did tell Adora she was going to try. She lifted her head to look at them.

"Sorry to bother you. We just wanted to see if you wanted to do dinner and a movie with us tonight. I rented a few from the library and we can order from Salineas if you want."

Catra let her head flop back on the bed. Melog got up, meowed at them, and moved to sit directly on her apparently full bladder.

"Aww yes of course you're invited too Melog" Glimmer said.

Melog started kneading their paws into Catra's bladder. Seriously. She had hoped she could just ignore the offer but Melog was making sure that wasn't going to happen. She let out a big sigh.

"That sounds….okay. But I want to pick the movie" Catra said pushing Melog off her.

"Great! Just let us know when you're hungry and we can order" Bow said as they both left.

Catra ran to the bathroom. Stupid Melog.

She went back and laid in bed for what seemed like a reasonable amount of time before heading out to find Bow and Glimmer. They were doing a puzzle on the kitchen table, so she pulled out a chair and sat down.

“Ready to order?” Bow said as he placed a piece.

“Yeah I guess.”

They ordered food and Catra sat there while Bow and Glimmer kept working on the puzzle. She felt her phone buzz.

Adora: *Just made it to the hotel. Miss you! Are you being nice to Bow and Glimmer?*

Catra sent a picture of the two of them staring intently at the puzzle.

Catra: *Your friends are dorks.*

Adora: *True but you live with them so that makes you a dork by association*

Catra: *Ugh in know… I miss you too*

Adora: *Be nice to them and maybe I’ll send you some pictures later*

Catra: *I’ll think about it*

Catra rolled her eyes and put her phone in her pocket. She casually looked over the puzzle pieces. Bow had been trying to force the same piece into a spot it clearly didn’t go for a minute now. She picked up the correct one and handed it to him.

“Here. Try this or whatever.”

“It fits! Yayyy Thank you Catra” Bow said smiling way too widely at her. It was just a puzzle piece and here he was acting like she saved the world. Still she felt herself blushing slightly.

The three of them worked quietly on the puzzle till the doorbell rang. Bow ran down to get the food and they moved over to the couch to get settled for the movie. Glimmer had picked a romantic comedy, an action movie, a nature documentary, and a science

fiction film. None of them really sounded interesting but she ended up choosing the sci fi movie.

The food was great as always even if she had to keep shoving Melog away. The movie ended up being pretty good too. A group of teens had to take an ancient spaceship into space to defeat an evil empire threatening to take over their galaxy. It seemed a little over the top and some of the characters were annoying, but she liked the protagonist. The cute blonde girl reminded her a little of Adora. Mostly that they were stubborn. And cute.

Bow and Glimmer were curled up together in a blanket and clearly engrossed in the movie too. The blonde girl was laying dying as her best friend held her crying and screaming at her not to give up. Right as she started to fade and disappear into darkness the other girl said she loved her. It was enough to save the blonde and as soon as she was free, they kissed. Catra felt butterflies in her stomach as she watched the scene. Bow and Glimmer both cheered and it made her jump.

The movie ended with the group of friends hugging as the two girls held hands. She guessed it was alright. Maybe good even. Okay she loved it. The kiss scene was amazing. And the characters complimented each other and made up for their issues.

"Umm I liked the movie…so thanks. For inviting me. It was nice."

She didn't look over in time to see them both make a face at each other before jumping on her.

"Glad you liked it Catra" Glimmer said planting a sloppy kiss on her cheek. Catra let out a squeak and squeezed out from underneath them. Her tail poofed up as she looked back at them.

"Awww so cute" Bow said.

Melog hopped up on them and let out several loud meows.

"I think Melog is trying to tell us something. Maybe that Catra actually likes hanging out with us?" Glimmer said giving Melog

chin scratches.

"Ugh. You two…" she paused and took a deep breath. Do it for Adora, Catra. She clasped her hands together. "Thank you for tonight. I am going to go to bed now. Good night." She quickly turned around and left the room as they laughed and said good night.

Catra was ready for bed and curled up in bed when her phone buzzed again.

It was a picture of Adora in a tank top smiling, clearly laying in her hotel bed.

Adora: *Bow and Glimmer say they had fun tonight*

Catra: *Checking up on me now?*

Adora: *Just making sure you weren't going to stay up all night doing the puzzle*

She rolled her eyes. She checked herself in her phone camera before sending back a picture of her in bed sticking her tongue out.

Adora sent back a photo of herself topless, her arm covering her breast. This had escalated way quicker than she had expected. Catra felt herself blush as she tried to memorize every detail of the photo. Her brain tried to formulate a response but all she managed to do was bite her lip and stare more.

Catra took a photo of her hand pulling down the waistband of her shorts.

Adora: *Wow. My girlfriend is hot!*

Catra: *lol dork. Wish you were here.*

Adora: *Me too babe… I should get some sleep. Gotta be up at 5am*

Catra: *You're a tease*

Adora sent a photo of her hand clearly down her shorts. She was biting her lip and her cheeks flushed, looking directly into the camera with a look that melted Catra every time she saw it. A look of vulnerability that she'd only seen when they were intimate. When it was just them and Adora needed Catra. Needed her to be in charge and whisper into her ear how good she was and how much Catra loved her. Not being there with her was torture even if she was loving these photos.

Adora: *Night. Love you!*

Catra: *Ughhh you're the worst*

Adora didn't respond. Had she seriously fallen asleep?

Catra: *Adora?*

A few minutes passed before her phone finally buzzed.

Adora: *Still awake. Was taking care of…something. But I do need to go to sleep now*

Catra laughed and shook her head. At least she wasn't the only one desperate for touch.

Catra: *Wow. Thirsty much. Get some sleep*

When Catra finally managed to fall asleep after taking care of… something for herself she didn't manage to sleep well. Nightmare memories of Prime grabbing and throwing kept playing in her mind and Adora wasn't there to ground her and chase away the dark thoughts. Melog tried to help and came to cuddle and purr by her but it wasn't the same. She drifted in and out of sleep for most of the night and felt terrible when her alarm for work went off.

Just one more day she kept reminding herself. One more day and then Adora would be back and she could sleep again, and everything would be fine. She tried to ignore the anxiety of the upcoming court date, but it was a persistent nagging at the back of her mind.

She spent most of the day in a daze, walking around slowly and staring at the same lines on the paperwork over and over. She must have looked rough because even Lonnie asked if she was okay. Taking half a day off was tempting but then she'd just lay in bed and mope at home.

"Hey Wildcat. I know I was just here. And I swear I'm not checking on you. Or anything. Um yeah. But I just wanted to see if you needed anything?" Scorpia asked from the office doorway.

This was about the fifth time in the last two hours that Scorpia had come to the office with a similar excuse. She sighed and pat the chair next to her. Lightning fast, Scorpia was sitting next to her and smiling.

"I'm fine Scorpia…Did Adora text you? Is that why you're harassing me?"

"No…Maybe…. Okay…Yes…. But also I just care about you silly."

"I'm alright. Just didn't sleep well."

Catra kept staring at the paperwork and was surprised when Scorpia didn't respond. Or immediately scoop her up in a hug. She risked looking at her.

"You're opening up to me" she said in an almost whisper, stars in her eyes and gigantic smile.

Catra rolled her eyes. "We are friends, aren't we?"

"Yes of course. But. You. Well you aren't the most open. With me. Or anyone for that matter."

In an extremely quiet mumble, she responded "I'm working on it or whatever."

And there came the giant scooping hug. Catra's hair stood on end for a second before accepting her fate and almost enjoying the pleasant rocking sensation of Scorpia swinging her back and forth like a baby. If she had been any more tired she would have probably fallen asleep. A really embarrassing fate that she narrowly avoided as Scorpia set her back down.

"Oh! I almost completely forgot. Would you like to have dinner with Perfuma, Entrapta and I tonight? I mean you don't have to if you don't want to. I know it's last minute. And you're probably busy and"

"What time?" Catra cut her off from her rant.

"Oh um. 6? Perfuma's cooking and Entrapta offered to bring some tiny desserts. You know how much she loves tiny foods."

She really did love tiny foods. "Alright well I'll bring some drinks. I gotta get back to this paperwork though."

"Great. See you later Wildcat!"

"Wait Scorpia. Um if it's too much just go ahead and say no. But… would it be okay if Bow and Glimmer came too?...Adora wants me to try harder with them" Catra said staring at the floor.

"Sure! I'll tell Perfuma to get out the big curry pot" she said with a smile and was gone.

She text Glimmer to make sure they actually wanted to come. Of course, they did. She let them know the plan and that she'd be home to walk over with them after work.

The rest of the shift was uneventful other than a few people had asked if Melog was around. She was still surprised how much people had loved them. A few thoughts of possible future plans

came to mind but she was too tired to follow them further. She'd think about it more after court.

Bow and Glimmer weren't home from school yet, so she had enough time to take a quick nap with Melog pressed up against her back. It helped a lot so when she heard the front door open, she felt almost ready for tonight. Almost.

The three of them walked over and picked up a few drinks on the way to Perfuma and Scorpia's apartment. The smell of mahkani instantly hit Catra's nose as Scorpia opened the door and welcomed them. Her stomach growled as she realized how hungry she'd been.

The buttery tofu dish was delicious and the beer that they picked paired well with the spices. Catra wasn't a great cook but thought maybe she could recreate this for Adora sometime.

Once all the dishes were cleared Entrapta brought out some tiny cupcakes and Bow and Glimmer picked out a board game. Catra managed to have fun and enjoyed seeing Scorpia happy. It was nice seeing Entrapta too. She spent some time talking with Bow about his thesis project after the game while Glimmer and Perfuma talked about house plants. Catra was pretty sure Glimmer would end up killing any plant that she tried to grow but Perfuma remained hopeful.

It started to get late and they made their goodbyes. Scorpia picked Catra up in one of her signature hugs.

"Thank you so much for coming over Wildcat. I missed you a lot. We should hang out more."

Catra blushed into her shoulder. "Yeah well…I guess I missed you too."

Bow and Glimmer both awwed at the same time. She just ignored them.

Entrapta pat Catra on the head and left. If anyone else did that she would be pissed but somehow was weirdly fine when she did it. The three of them waved goodbye to Perfuma and Scorpia and walked home.

"Thanks for inviting us Catra. Your friends are really nice" Glimmer said holding Bow's hand.

"Yeah. And it's been nice having you as part of the best friend squad" Bow said.

Catra let a moment pass before she responded. "Um thanks. For everything. For giving me a second chance after…everything. And yeah. It's been nice."

Bow and Glimmer hugged her simultaneously. She tensed but let it happen.

As soon as they got back to the apartment Catra said goodnight and went to bed. The nightmares were back and somehow more vivid, more terrifying. Replays of all the weird nightmares she had had of Prime attacking the giant Adora. Of what he had actually done to Catra in real life.

She woke to Melog standing on her and meowing. She scratched their chin and laid there. After awhile they curled up on her chest and she pet them. She was too exhausted to cry. To afraid to sleep. So she just laid there waiting for morning to come.

As soon as Adora's plane landed she text Catra to let her know she'd be home soon. She was nervous what kind of state she'd be in. If she had even left the apartment the whole time. She still felt terrible for having to leave but the convention had been really good for the gym and she felt more confident about herself as a trainer.

She didn't hear back from Catra right away, which only made her more nervous. Bow and Glimmer weren't responding either, but she figured they were probably busy with schoolwork. She knew

Catra had the day off but maybe she was sleeping. She rushed to get back home as quickly as she could.

Adora was a nervous wreck when she finally got to the apartment. She nearly tripped up the stairs and fell through the front door.

Catra, Bow and Glimmer all stared at her from the kitchen table as she bust through the doorway. Catra was sitting cross legged on the chair, a puzzle piece in her hand, and a faithful Melog asleep on the chair next to her. A weight lifted off her shoulders as she finally relaxed seeing Catra. She looked exhausted but it warmed her heart seeing her hanging out with her best friends. She had actually tried for her.

She put her bags down and walked over to stand behind Catra, wrapping her arms around her shoulders before leaning down to kiss her cheek.

"Hey Adora" she said sleepily. Adora loved the way Catra leaned into her kiss, a nearly imperceptible purr vibrating in her chest.

Bow and Glimmer ran over to give her a hug and told her all about hanging out. Catra went back to working on the puzzle as they talked but she could see her tail twitching as she got restless. She clearly wanted alone time but wasn't going to say it.

"I would love to stay and help with the puzzle but I'm gonna go unpack and take a nap" she said as she headed to grab her bags.

"Yeah as much as I liked hanging out with you dorks I've got to take care of…something…in the bedroom."

Bow and Glimmer chuckled as Catra gave them a wink. Adora blushed and stopped, opening her mouth to say something but before she could make a fool of herself Catra grabbed her by the hand and yanked her to the bedroom.

As soon as the door closed behind Adora she dropped her bag as Catra pushed her up against the door and kissed her. The kiss was electric and full of need but there was something off. As badly as

she wanted this she knew Catra was exhausted and needed to rest. But she was probably too stubborn to admit that so Adora would need to be sneaky about this. She gently pushed her back by her shoulder to look in her eyes. There were dark circles there and her hair was a mess. The way she looked made Adora's heart ache.

"Catra I'm sorry. I know I was a tease with those photos last night, but do you think we could take a nap first?" Adora asked.

She watched, or more so rather felt Catra sag against her with relief. She nodded her head against Adora's chest as she pressed kisses into her hair and forehead. Adora let out a breath she didn't know she was holding. She had really been afraid that Catra would get upset or try to shut her out.

Adora picked up her exhausted girlfriend and carried her to the bed, gently laying her down and getting her under the covers before laying down on her back. Catra adjusted to be pressed into her side, her nose and mouth gently resting in the crook of her neck.

"It's okay. I'm here now. You can sleep" she whispered into Catra's hair. She rubbed her back and listened to her purr that slowly faded to be replaced by a gentle snore. Adora closed her eyes and let herself drift off as well.

Court

Chapter Summary

CW/TW: court case with a lot of anxiety and a vaguely described dissociation episode. Please feel free to skip this chapter if you need to. There is a line near the end where it safe to read a little comfort moment that happens the next day.

Summary- Catra has her case against Prime

Chapter Notes

Please see the trigger warning in the summary above.

Sorry for anybody who saw this posted and then disappear last night. I got some really fast and good feedback (thank you and sorry your comment got deleted when i removed the chapter) that it didn't make sense and so instead of spending hours researching how to make it accurate I doubled down and literally made two cases into one and added some weird details about the fantasy legal system. Please know that this is very very VERY loosely based on the US legal system with a whole lot of garbage that I mixed together.

Today was the day. The court case was set to start in less than an hour as Catra sat in the spectator area waiting with her lawyer. They went over last-minute details and prepared her for the different steps in the process. The Brightmoon legal system was complex and her lawyer had managed to request a dual case: part civil, part criminal case. There would be evidence, testimonies, and witnesses from both parties and then the panel of judges would decide if Prime was guilty while the jury would determine if Catra received financial compensation. She stared down at her hands and watched them shake. Her anxiety was overwhelming, and she could barely focus on what the lawyer was saying. They

gave her a gentle squeeze on the shoulder and led her up to the defendant's table.

Adora was the first spectator allowed in the courtroom. She tried to sit as close as she could and gave Catra a sad smile and thumbs up. She forced a weak smile and gave her a thumbs up back. Bow was really rubbing off on her with his dumb thumbs up. The rest of the spectators slowly entered and took seats in the back. She saw Scorpia, Entrapta, and a few Horders management come in and sit directly behind her in the witness seating.

She watched as Prime and his lawyer entered. He was dressed impeccably and stared at her as he stood at the table. He was too close. She couldn't do this. The acid in her stomach churned and rose to the back of her throat. Her claws made indents into the surface of the table as she stared forward trying to breathe the too thin atmosphere. She clenched her hands into fists, her claws leaving gouges in the table now, as she steeled her nerves.

The jury entered next followed shortly by the deputy and three judges. She gripped the table as she stood to keep herself from shaking.

She couldn't focus as the case began. The jury was sworn in and both lawyers approached the bench for a few minutes.

Her pulse was rapid. Breathing no longer felt like an unconscious effort, her autonomic systems failing her. She forced air into her lungs and willed her heart to beat.

He couldn't hurt her she reminded herself.

She was safe. She was loved.

She had hurt people, but she could fix this. She could make up for it.

Both lawyers presented their opening arguments. Her lawyer explained her track record of being a diligent employee who was coerced by Prime and then assaulted for refusing to continue to

perform illegal acts on his behalf. Prime's lawyer stated that he had acted in self-defense when she attempted to blackmail him after he found out that she was stealing from the company.

The rage that she felt as she listened to his defense was a burning pool of magma in her. The anger honed into the blade with which she would destroy him. She bit back bile as she approached the witness stand.

A quick glance at Adora showed she was furious as well. She let that add to the burning fire inside her. Let it consume the anxiety that had kept her up for weeks.

She would not bend her will to him.

She would not be weak.

She spoke as calmly as possible as her lawyer had her explain her account of the weeks leading up to the assault, only stopping her a few times to clarify a point.

The last part of her lawyer's questioning was to present the footage of the assault. Prime's lawyer tried to request that the footage of the be thrown out of the case since it was taken without Prime's knowledge or permission. The judges deemed the footage admissible and a crucial piece of evidence in the case.

Catra, along with everyone in the courtroom watched the video. Her claws stabbed into her palms as she watched. She made eye contact with Adora who looked sickened. Scorpia and Entrapta looked nervous. Her breathing hitched as she watched herself thrown to the ground. Emotions swirled around her and she looked down at the stand in front of her. She was embarrassed and enraged and nervous and barely holding it all together.

The cross-examination by Prime's lawyer took a very different tone. They immediately went for a barrage of questions against her character. Asking her to confirm the verbal warnings in her employee file for her "bouts of anger" and "poor people skills." She silently cursed Hordak for his meticulous notes on everyone's

shortcomings. Her hands shook as she tried to maintain her calm tone.

"So you admit that you have an anger issue?" The lawyer asked moving closer and closer to the witness stand. Staring at her almost as intensely as Prime. His eyes made her feel like he was staring through her as if she was nothing.

"No. That's not what I said. I said I've never seen my personnel file" Catra responded.

"Just a yes or no please. Do you have an anger problem that has been addressed at work?"

She didn't know what to say. She felt flustered as the panic became overwhelming again.

Her lawyer tried to state the question was irrelevant and purposefully attempting to frame her as a poor employee. The judges allowed it.

"One last time. Did you ever receive a verbal warning for lashing out at your coworkers?"

She was holding back her tears and through clenched teeth she responded "Yes."

She watched a few members of the jury shift in their seats at her statement. She could feel Prime's eyes on her but refused to look at him, to give him the satisfaction of seeing her upset. His lawyer rested with that and she returned to her seat. She tried to discreetly wipe the tears from her eyes and catch her breath.

Scorpia was up next and all of the questions from her lawyer were centered on why she had been at the shop and her account of attacking Prime. She rambled a few times but Catra's lawyer directed her into explaining that Prime had attacked Catra first. Prime's lawyer chose not to ask anything.

Entrapta was called next and went over her account of how Catra had asked her to help with the security cameras. Prime's lawyer asked her several questions on if she knew she was there against store policy and filming Prime without his knowledge. She responded that she was unaware of the laws and policies, which seemed to cause a few jury members to look at each other. Catra couldn't read their emotions.

The judges called for a short recess in the case and Catra walked quickly to the bathroom. She ran to a stall and vomited the bile that had been in the back of her throat. Within seconds Adora was there, holding her hair back. She helped Catra up to wash her mouth at the sink and held her as she broke down crying. All the strength and anger leaving her body as she shook in Adora's arms.

"You're almost done Catra. He's not going to get away with this" she said as she held Catra tightly. The words held little comfort to her but Adora's touch was what she needed to ground herself. She took shaky breaths and tried to get back in control. Adora kissed her forehead and wiped the tears from her cheeks.

She nodded, a silent implication that she was ready to go back in. Adora embraced her one last time before they left the bathroom.

One member of the Horders internal management team was called as a witness by Prime's lawyer who asked about allegations towards their client. The person admitted they were newer to the company and had not heard anything previously. His lawyer presented Prime's personnel file, with several notes on his impeccable performance, as evidence.

The last person called to the witness stand was Prime. He stared at Catra as he was sworn in but quickly turned his attention to answering his lawyer's questions. Each question was designed to frame him as a model citizen who had been at the company for several decades. He looked confident and calm, poised and far less emotional than Catra could have ever appeared.

Her lawyer asked a few questions about the other charges that had been filed against him over the years. He denied being aware of their existence. The judges chose not to hear any further information on the previous charges.

There was a very brief recess while the judges and jury deliberated. Catra didn't leave her chair. She didn't have the strength to move, to do anything beyond breathe and stare at the table.

The judges returned to the bench shortly before the jury reentered. She was trying to focus but the words were coming through in a garbled mess. One word cut through the mental fog.

"… Guilty"

Prime was guilty.

Every sound past that was lost on her. The word guilty repeating over and over. She didn't hear the monetary amount she was awarded. She didn't hear her lawyer, barely even registered their touch on her shoulder.

Guilty

Guilty

She had done it. She had defeated Prime. Defeated felt too monumental, too grandiose. But it was over.

As she came back into focus, she registered her lawyer mentioning something about contacting her regarding the award and payment later next week. And then they were out of focus and gone again.

She looked up from the table in time to see Prime being handcuffed and led out of the courtroom to the holding cell. His composure had finally cracked and been replaced by seething rage. A wicked smile formed at his lips that terrified Catra more

than anything in the world. And then he was gone too. Her legs were too weak to stand on, so she continued to sit there.

She felt Adora's strong hands on her arm. She was kneeling there next to her, but her brain couldn't process anything she was saying. She let herself be led out of the court. She barely registered Scorpia and Entrapta hugging her. There was a car ride home, but everything was blurs of shapes outside of the window.

The next thing she remembered was somehow she was in bed with Adora. She was wearing pajamas and Adora was petting her mane and whispering to her. Telling her some story about how she almost broke a life size replica spaceship. Catra had no idea how long she had been talking but she placed a weak kiss at the corner of Adora's lips.

She wanted to tell her she was okay. That she loved her. That she was her whole world.

But there weren't words yet. She wiped a tear that was in Adora's eye and kissed her cheek. She could feel Adora relax that she had finally responded on any level. Melog let out a small meow and shifted to lay right by their feet. Catra laid her head back down on Adora's chest and fell asleep.

Catra and Adora had both taken the next day off after the case. She had woken up from several nightmares throughout the night that Adora helped her to get through. Bow and Glimmer came in to check on them and bring them some breakfast, but they spent the whole morning in bed. Catra clung to Adora like she was her lifeboat. She still hadn't said a word but Adora was trying to hold out hope that she would talk soon.

They rested on and off all morning, watching TV when they felt like it and sometimes just lying there in silence.

"Would you like to go on a walk? It looks pretty nice out" Adora asked after they had woken up from a nap.

Catra nodded. She had held her hand the whole time they got ready. It had made changing difficult but if it brought her comfort she'd gladly oblige.

Whispering Woods was full of people enjoying the weather so Adora led them through the grove of trees to the semi-secret grassy field they had visited on her birthday. They found a nice spot to lay down in and she watched clouds pass by.

Catra cleared her throat and pointed at a cloud. "That one looks like a butt."

Adora let out laugh. Of all the things she expected to say it hadn't been that. "Yeah it really does."

Catra shifted to lay on top of her and stare into her eyes. There was a gentle sadness there that seemed to be slowly fading. She booped Adora's forehead and she went cross-eyed trying to stare at her finger. Catra snorted before leaning down to kiss her softly. She whispered "thank you" between kisses. Adora's wrapped a hand around Catra's waist and the other around her back. Adora wanted to tell her so many things but knew Catra needed time still. Needed to just feel safe and be held. And she would do that for as long as it took.

She knew there was still a lot to talk about and process but for now Adora was content to lay there with Catra and enjoy the warmth of the sun.

Operation: FtG

Chapter Summary

Adora decides to be romantic

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora woke up and decided she was going to make Catra dinner. And not just some fast and easy boxed meal. This was going to be fancy and delicious. She'd even bust out some candles and maybe a nice tablecloth. Did they have a tablecloth? She was getting distracted by details already.

There was just one slight problem to her plan.

She didn't actually know how to cook. Couldn't be that hard right?

The foster home she had grown up in did all the cooking for them and when she went to college she just ate from the cafeteria. Most of the time she ordered food or pre-made meals. She could do some really basic stuff and Glimmer had finally removed her ban from the stove, she still doesn't know how it started on fire, so she set her mind to the task of figuring out how to cook.

Operation: Feed the Girlfriend.

First things first, she snuck quietly away from sleeping Catra and out to Glimmer who was half asleep drinking her morning coffee. Adora grabbed her arm and pulled the cup away from Glimmer's face. Her eyes bulging out of her head as coffee splashed onto the floor.

"Glimmer! I need to learn how to cook right now. Can you teach me? Are there books? Does Bow know anything" Adora said in a panicked whisper.

Glimmer stared at her, trying to process everything. She tried to crane her neck down to get more coffee as Adora was still latched onto her arm.

"Glimmer this is serious. I need to make Catra dinner" Adora said as she pulled the coffee cup from her hands and started to drink it.

"Hey that's mine!" Glimmer said as she yanked it out of her hands and pouted. "Alright Adora you're not making sense. Or you are but it's so early still. Coffee first please."

Adora grabbed Glimmer's shoulders and forced her to sit down at the table before grabbing the coffee pot and refilling her cup. She sat across the table from her, both hands flat on the surface, and stared directly at Glimmer waiting for her to be done. She needed answers soon if she was going to learn to cook by tonight, but she was trying to be patient.

"Ugh fine. If you're gonna stare at me just go ahead. What do you want to learn to cook?"

"Oh…I have to decide that? Um…."

"Okay let's back up. What does Catra like?"

"She likes coffee, and long walks, and when I rub her ears, and…" Adora continued on her ramble, blushing slightly at the list of things.

"No. Adora. No. What does Catra like to *eat*?" Glimmer clarified.

"Right!....Fish? She likes seafood"

"Great. That's a start. I know she likes Salineas a lot. What if you made some seared tuna and like a soy ginger vegetable mix?"

Adora stared at her blankly. That sounded complicated.

“Are you sure you don’t want to just buy her dinner? That seems safer….less likely to cause a fire….”

“Nooo” Adora whined. “I want to cook for her. Things have been really tough since the court case and I want to do something nice for her.”

“That’s sweet. But I still think you should just order food” Glimmer mumbled into her coffee cup.

Adora gave her the poutiest face she could manage with big sad sparkly eyes. Glimmer arched an eyebrow and tried to stare her down. Adora put her hands up in a pleading motion.

Glimmer cracked a smile and sighed. “Okay okay but stop your dumb pouty face. I’ll help you find a recipe.”

Just then she heard Catra yawning as she walked into the kitchen, scratching her leg absently as she tried to wake up. Adora jumped up from the table so hard that it made Glimmer spill her coffee. Again.

She yanked Glimmer down the hallway and into her room, quickly closing the door behind them. Nothing suspicious happening.

She cracked the door open to see Catra standing there confused.

“Um don’t worry about it. Just helping Glimmer…with stuff… School stuff yeah. Nothing big. Okay gotta go.” She slammed the door shut again.

She opened it back up a second later, Catra still standing there confused, as she ran out, gave her a quick kiss and yelled “I love you” over her shoulder before slamming the door shut again.

She let out a deep breath. “Okay good. She has no idea what’s going on. Back to recipes.”

“Yeah she definitely doesn’t think anything weird is happening. At all. Totally normal day, Adora” Glimmer said as sarcastically as

possible, her tone completely going over Adora's head.

"I'm getting pretty good at acting" Adora said proudly.

Glimmer groaned and slapped her hand against her face. "Okay… Back to recipes. Let's see what we can find that's easy and going to also be…edible."

They searched on Glimmer's computer for a while and ended up picking a fairly simple sautéed salmon with a ginger and soy dressing and some honey garlic broccoli.

"What does sauté mean Glimmer?" Adora asked.

Glimmer turned from looking at the computer to stare at Adora. She didn't understand her reaction. Adora was just asking a simple question.

Glimmer groaned and hit her head against the desk.

They spent another half an hour watching basic cooking technique videos online. Adora was amazed and overwhelmed at all the different way you could chop something. She couldn't back down though. Operation: Feed the Girlfriend was of the upmost importance.

"So you just need to go pick up the ingredients and it says 20 minutes to cook but I would give yourself some extra time to… Why are you staring at me like that?"

Adora blushed. "I don't know how to pick out fish?"

Glimmer groaned again. She sighed, "Go get dressed and I'll help you get everything ready."

Adora smiled big at her friend, giving her an overzealous crushing hug and ran off to change. Catra was laying in bed playing on her phone with Melog sitting on her stomach. The two of them stared at her as she froze, tripped on her own foot, and fell on the floor.

Catra leaned over the bed to stare down at her. “Hey Adora”

“Oh hi Catra! Umm so I have to go to help Glimmer with something. With a school thing. The thing with her school that I’ve been helping her with. This morning.”

Melog hopped off the bed and licked her face. Catra smiled and flicked her tail back and forth. “Alright Adora. I’ll just be here. Laying in bed. Enjoying my day off” she said as she laid back and stretched.

Okay good. Catra had bought it. She just had to change and get out of the apartment. Her plan was going great…except she hadn’t remembered it was Catra’s day off. How was she going to secretly make food? Maybe Bow could help.

By the time she got dressed and kissed Catra goodbye Glimmer was waiting for her at the door.

“Okay so Catra has no idea. But I need to get her out of the apartment. Do you think Bow can help? Maybe distract her?”

“Yeah sure I think he’s free this afternoon. I’ll call him on the way.”

Glimmer had a long talk with Bow about the situation and he agreed to get Catra out of the apartment for the afternoon. They pulled up the ingredient list on Adora’s phone and circled around the grocery store a few times before they had everything. She also grabbed a Madame Razz’s berry pie. It was one of her favorite brands and figured Catra would probably like it too.

They got back to the apartment and she snuck all the groceries into the fridge before Catra came out to the kitchen. Adora held her breath and tried to act casual, leaning against the counter. She was totally pulling it off until Catra went to the fridge and Adora slammed it shut before she could look in there.

“Oh let me get that for you? What did you need? Milk? A snack?” Adora asked.

“You’re so weird. I just want some creamer for my coffee.” Catra pointed to the cup in her other hand.

Adora opened the fridge the smallest amount, shuffled a few things around, grabbed the creamer and shoved it at Catra.

“Here you go.” She smiled wide.

Catra snorted and raised an eyebrow at her. She poured a little creamer into her cup before handing it back to Adora and walking back to their bedroom.

Adora let out a giant sigh of relief when she left the room. “Ill be helping Glimmer. With her school thing if you need me” she shouted down the hallway.

Glimmer jumped as she entered without knocking and shut the door behind her.

“Adora you have to knock still!” Glimmer yelled.

“Right. Sorry. So, what’s the next step in Operation: FtG?” Adora asked.

Glimmer looked confused. She explained the name.

“You two are cute idiots. I hope you know that.”

Adora just smiled back at her.

They had a little time before they needed to start preparing so Glimmer showed her more cooking videos. Adora wanted to do this on her own as much as possible so she told Glimmer that she would do all the prep and cooking herself. The videos made it seem so easy, couldn’t be that hard.

She’d never been more wrong in her entire life.

As soon as Bow got home and they had a chance to explain things a little better, he had grabbed his deck of cards and took Catra to

show her magic tricks in the park. Coming up with some excuse about the lighting and atmosphere being all wrong for magic in the apartment. Glimmer stayed in her room with the promise that she wouldn't help unless Adora asked for it.

She started washing the broccoli and got it chopped up. The pieces were all different size but that didn't seem like too big of a deal. Next came the different sauces and she figured she didn't need to actually measure anything and just approximated the amounts. There were a few spills as she mixed and stirred everything, but things looked about right, and she could clean up later. She could taste the sauces later too. She threw all the broccoli in a pan and put the lid on it, setting the heat to medium, before grabbing the fish. The videos had said it was very crucial to oil the pan and not move the fish around when it was cooking so she put a large amount of oil into the pan and dropped the filets into it.

The broccoli was starting to look sort of cooked, so she dumped the sauce on top and mixed it around before putting the lid back on. She had a minute or two before the fish had to be flipped so she grabbed a tablecloth and some candles from their bedroom. It took her a little longer than she expected to pick out candles that she thought would smell nice. She almost dropped a lit candle as she remembered the food.

Catra knew Adora was up to something stupid and had decided to play dumb and not push her on it. The sixth time though that Bow had shown her the same magic trick was the final straw. She was going home, and it was not her problem if Adora wasn't ready for whatever surprise she had planned. Bow tried to come up with some excuses about needing to show her another part of the park, but she shrugged them off.

"Do you hear that?" Catra asked as they were walking up the stairs to the apartment. She could hear the fire alarm going off and she started to run. Smoke flooded out the entrance as they walked in. Glimmer was there throwing baking soda onto a small

stove fire as Adora ran back and forth panicking. Catra went and quickly opened some windows to let the smoke out.

"I'm sorry I tried to distract her" Bow said as his deck of card scattered onto the floor.

With the fire successfully out and the stove turned off Glimmer put a towel over her shoulder and walked back to her room. "Your stove ban is officially reinstated Adora. Indefinitely." Bow just shrugged and followed her.

Adora's shoulders slumped and she started to laugh into her hands. Catra pulled them away from her face to see she had tears in her eyes.

"I just wanted to do something special for you." Adora sobbed.

Catra squished Adora's cheeks between her hands and make her make eye contact.

"You are an idiot and I love you very much" Catra said releasing her face to asses the damage.

None of the food was salvageable and there was a new darker smoke stain on the ceiling that covered Adora's previous incident.

Adora rubbed the back of her neck before grabbing a pie from the cabinet she had hid it in.

"Well at least we go this" Adora said with a shrug.

Catra looped her arm through Adora's and led her to the front door. "Come on. Let's go pick up some food and we can go eat at the park. If we order from Salineas you can tell Sea Hawk all about your adventure" she accented the last word in the same stupid way he always said it. Adora chuckled and followed along.

After ordering and listening to a few of Sea Hawk's stories about lighting boats on fire, she had been right about the pyro tendencies after all, they took their food and headed to the park.

There was a nice picnic table in the sun, and they gobbled down everything. Catra was a little thankful that whatever Adora had been trying to make had been destroyed because there was no way it beat this.

Once the finished eating they walked around and just enjoyed the evening.

"It was really sweet of you to try and cook for me. But please don't do it again. At the very least not without supervision."

Adora nodded. Clearly still upset about how things had ended up.

"Can't say it was the surprise I was expecting but nobody's ever romantically tried to burn down my apartment before so that's a new one" she teased. "If you just wanted to get me hot and bothered you could have just kissed me you know."

Adora laughed before pulling her in tight for a surprise kiss. "Like this?"

Catra's heart nearly jumped out of her throat. "Mmm.. Y-yeah that'd do it" she sputtered. She hadn't been expecting the kiss.

Adora looked at her hungrily before she tried to make a serious face and picked Catra up. "Don't worry ma'am I'm here to save you."

Catra laughed before pretending to be faint. "My hero…also the person that started the fire but my hero!"

They both broke down laughing hysterically.

Operation: Feed the Girlfriend was a success.

Chapter End Notes

I laughed a lot writing this one. Poor disaster Adora

Egg Challenge

Chapter Summary

Just Adora and Catra being dummies in love

Chapter Notes

This is fully inspired by Noelle and Molly's twitch stream where they tried the egg challenge. Highly recommend the video if you haven't seen it.

“Hey Scorpia, come check this out” Catra called from the back office. She was leaning back in her chair with her feet up on the desk watching a video on her phone. It had been an abnormally slow day at the shop, so everyone was taking it easy. Well Catra was at least.

“What’s up Wildcat? Oh, is it a video? Did you see the one where the owl and cat are best friends? It’s pretty cute. And there’s this other one where…”

“No. What? Shut up. Look at this. It’s called the egg challenge. You try and crush a raw egg with your bicep. I’ve been laughing at all these dumb meat heads trying to crack eggs” she chuckled.

“Oh huh. That doesn’t seem so hard” Scorpia sad while staring at her flexing arm.

“We got some extra eggs in the fridge if you wanna test it out. Bet we could get Lonnie to try it too.”

Scorpia went to get Lonnie while Catra got a few eggs. Apparently Catra had to be a little more specific with her wording because in walked Scorpia carrying a disheveled Lonnie.

“I didn’t literally mean grab Lonnie, Scorpia” Catra said chuckling.

“Oops” she said as she dropped Lonnie a little too hard. She responded with an angry groan.

“Why am I back here anyways?” Lonnie said while looking at Catra holding the eggs.

“Here. Take this and try and crush it with your bicep.”

Lonnie stared at her. Not moving. Did she need to explain it slower?

She pointed to the egg. “You put the egg.” Switched to point at the crook of her arm. “In your arm.” She flexed her bicep. “And you try to crush it.” She made sure to talk slowly and annunciate.

“Yeah no I understood the first time. I just thought it was dumb. Why don’t you go first” Lonnie said with a hand on her hip.

“Pfft. I don’t want to crush a dumb egg. Scorpia, you do it.”

Right as Catra was about to place an egg in Scorpia’s arm for her, pincers and eggs don’t go well together, they heard the door to the shop open.

“Don’t start without me. I’ll go take care of the customer” Catra said as she set the egg back in the carton.

“Hey Catra” Adora said walking up and giving her a kiss over the counter. “Where is everybody?”

“No clue but come in the back. I want to show you something.”

“Oh yeah?” Adora wiggled her eyebrows. “I bet you wanna show me something back there.”

“W-what? No it’s not like that.” She could feel a blush spreading across her cheeks. So maybe she did want to make out with Adora in her office but not right now.

“Okay Catra. Whatever you say.” Adora grabbed at Catra’s sides tickling her and causing her to let out a squeak right as she opened the doors to the back. Scorpia and Lonnie just stared at them with knowing smiles.

“Oh hey guys what’s up? What are you doing?” Adora asked like she hadn’t just embarrassed Catra in front of her employees.

Catra tried to stop blushing as she explained the challenge and went back to placing the egg for Scorpia. The edge of her exoskeleton almost immediately caught the egg, cracking it and causing egg to drip all over her arm and onto the floor.

Catra laughed as she threw her a rag to clean up with. “Alright Adora you wanna give it a shot?” she said holding out an egg for her.

“Yeah sure. Seems like it’s pretty easy.” She took the egg looking cocky and confident. Cockiness soon faded to confusion as she couldn’t crush the egg.

“Oh….Oh…this is way harder…than I thought” she said as she tried adjusting and getting different angles. She stuck her tongue out a little between her teeth, one of Catra’s favorite dumb faces she made when she was concentrating. It always reminded her of the first time they had gone to try sushi on their “totally not a date” hangout.

Catra felt herself blushing again as she watched Adora’s bicep straining. She bit her lip and hoped there would be time for a quick office visit after this. The more Adora struggled to crack the egg the more her muscles bulged. It was taking all of her mental effort not to reach out and feel her arm.

Lonnie coughed into her hand and cleared her throat. “uselesslesbian…sorry something in my throat” she said giving Catra a dirty smirk.

She stuck her tongue out at her. How dare she interrupt Catra’s admiration of Adora.

“Why don’t you try it if you’re so cool” she sneered at Lonnie.

The front door opened again. Lonnie shrugged and left to go check it out.

Adora was turning bright red, her forehead a little sweaty and still fully engrossed in trying to crack the egg. Scorpia was cheering her on in the same way gym bros cheer on their buddies doing stupid lifts. She rolled her eyes and laughed.

Catra put her hand on Adora’s shoulder and reached to grab the egg. Adora blushed and pouted.

“I could have totally gotten it” she said crossing her arms.

“Of course, you could babe” Catra gave her a wink before putting the egg back in the carton. Now to get Scorpia out of the back for a bit.

“Scorpia why don’t you go ahead and take your break now.”

“But I just took a break before this boss.”

Catra took a deep breath and tried to find a better excuse.

“It’s okay you can take a second since it’s so slow.”

“No no that’s okay. I wouldn’t want to abuse our friendship” Scorpia said with a big smile.

Catra gave her a big fake smile and tried to keep from clenching her fists. “Scorpia…. please go take a break while I show Adora something in the office….”

“Oh…oh…Ohhhhhhhh okay Wildcat” she said with a wink and left.

Catra turned back to Adora who was giving her signature shithead smile with raised eyebrow. Catra groaned but couldn’t help smiling as she grabbed her by the hand and led her to the office. As soon as she closed and locked the office door she sighed and leaned

back against the door. Adora was leaning against the desk with her arms folded, smiling at Catra.

“If you wanted to see me flex all you had to do was ask Catra.”

“You’re so full of yourself that’s not” she stopped talking midsentence as Adora rolled up her sleeve and flexed. That shit eating grin beaming ear to ear. Catra thought a few different ways she could wipe it off her face.

She shook her head to try and focus. “N-not what I was doing-g”

Adora, still flexing one arm, grabbed Catra by the waist and pulled her in close. She let out a gasp as Adora was so close now. This wasn’t how she wanted this to go. She wanted to be in control but confident Adora always found a way to fluster her.

“You can touch if you want.”

Confident Adora was hot but overly confident, cocky Adora was ridiculous. Catra rolled her eyes and shoved Adora in the face. She let her arm trail gently down Adora’s arm. Just so happening to land on her bicep. Accidentally of course. One claw tracing down the exposed skin. She watched as goosebumps broke out along her arm. She twisted her hand to wrap around Adora’s arm, letting her claws dig in and fixing Adora with a mischievous grin. Adora let out a small gasp giving Catra hope for gaining the upper hand.

She gave her a soft peck on the lips. “Well princess. I should get back to work.”

“No” was all Adora said before standing up, picking Catra up, and sitting her down on the desk. One hand grabbed the back of Catra’s neck and the other went under the hem of her shirt and grabbed her lower back to pull her in tightly against Adora. Catra instinctively wrapped her legs behind Adora forcing their bodies even closer. She was still gasping from the sudden aggressiveness when Adora slammed their lips together. It was all need and passion and somehow still not close enough. Catra needed her

closer. Needed to feel every inch of her skin. She felt lightheaded and on fire as every contact point between them felt charged with electricity.

“Okay now you can go” Adora said with a smile. Pulling away slightly but still close enough that Catra could feel her shallow breathing. Adora’s legs were shaking gently from holding herself over the desk.

She dug her claws in and used her legs to keep Adora from pulling away.

“What’s wrong princess? Too scared to finish what you started?” she whispered into Adora’s ear before biting the lobe. Adora moaned and had to catch herself on the desk to keep from falling over as her legs buckled. Catra took a moment to just enjoy the view. Her hair had come loose from the tie and draped down her shoulders, her eyes were shut tightly as she tried to catch her breath. As much as she loved confident Adora she loved this small display of vulnerability just as much. The way her hands and lips showed Catra how much she needed her more than any words could.

Adora took a deep breath and placed her hand on Catra’s shoulder. “As badly as I want to finish you right now” she winked, “I’m not having sex with you in your work office.”

Catra sighed but couldn’t help a smile. “You’re no fun.”

Adora put her hair back up and Catra tried to smooth her clothes out a bit before they headed out of the office. She’d looked worse before and this was at least for a very good reason. Catra watched the beautiful view of Adora’s backside leaving the shop.

After a long boring afternoon of work and a very enjoyable night with Adora Catra found herself wide awake laying in bed. Adora was sleeping soundly next to her, the blanket pulled back exposing her defined back with a few fresh scratches. She tried her best to not leave too many marks but Adora always knew

exactly where to touch, where to place a kiss, to bite that left Catra digging her claws in and whimpering. So really it was Adora's fault. She kept telling herself that as she placed a few gentle kisses on Adora's back before sneaking out to the kitchen.

She made sure Bow and Glimmer were asleep too before grabbing an egg from the fridge. Her fur made the challenge even more impossible as it tried to slip out from the crook of her arm almost immediately. She squeezed and tensed, trying different angles and after several minutes finally cursed the stupid egg and gave up.

Dumb egg challenge.

Cockroach

Chapter Summary

CW/TW: Talks about parent death/ grieving. Please skip the whole thing if you need to.

Summary- Money brings out the worst people.

Chapter Notes

Please double check the TW in the summary.
Oof. I've been trying to get more descriptive/flowery with wording and hopefully it's paying off?
This is a unrelated note but thanks to listening to the twitch stream I think I will be making this a 3 part series now with the third chunk being even farther into the future. That'sa big commitment since this piece is ended up being way longer than i expected.

Adora was home alone watching some training videos on her day off when she heard a knock on the door. She hadn't been expecting anybody but went to investigate. She didn't recognize the woman standing there. Her long black hair flowed wildly around her head and shoulders. She wore a dark red cowl sweater with a matching floor length skirt. There was something deeply unsettling about her. Maybe the way her dark eyes searched over Adora like she was merely an obstacle in her way. No, it was more like she was pawn piece to be used as she saw fit. A mask of indifference covering her face making her emotions unreadable.

"Does Catra live here? I've been trying to track her down all morning" the woman said attempting to look into the apartment over Adora's shoulder.

"She's out getting some lunch right now. I'm sorry but who are you?" Adora asked. Should she have said she lived here? Was that a mistake?

"She didn't tell you about me? Figures. She's never been one to be proud of her family. Or even stay in touch apparently. She hadn't even given me her new address. I'm Shadow, her aunt."

"Oh. Yes… Catra's mentioned you. I'm Adora her…" she stopped before finishing the sentence. Did Catra tell her about Adora? Or being gay?

Shadow looked Adora up and down, a slight frown pulling at her lips. "I see. Well are you going to let me in while we wait for her?"

Adora stood in the doorway for a moment debating whether she should let her in. Catra hadn't said much about her aunt that had raised her but when she did there was such fierce animosity when she spoke. She doubted Catra would enjoy coming home to find her sitting in their apartment.

"Umm I don't know if" she started as she heard the distinct sound of Catra's footsteps, her claws always clicked on the steps, coming up the hallway stairs.

Catra stopped and stared at the back of her aunt. Adora could see the panic in her wide eyes, see she was debating if she could turn and run. Shadow turned to face her.

"Ahhh Catra there you are. I was just talking here with your… roommate. Won't you let me in?"

Adora watched as Catra's demeanor changed from panic to annoyance. Her shoulders rolled forward slightly, her knuckles tightening around the bag of food she had brought back for them. She pushed past Shadow and Adora into the apartment.

"Let's get this over with. I figured you'd hear about the money and come crawling out with the rest of the cockroaches."

Adora's jaw dropped as she stood still partially in the doorway in shock. Shadow didn't even seem to acknowledge the retort as she slid past Adora into the kitchen area.

Catra worked on setting out the food as Adora still in shock slowly shut the front door. Now she was the one debating if she could turn and run. But Catra needed her here.

"That's entirely unfair Catra. I did hear about your terrible assault and wanted to check in on you, but your phone number had changed. And your address apparently. The people at your last place were kind enough to share with me your new address. You should really keep in touch better dear."

Shadow took a seat at the table while Catra handed Adora a bowl of food before hopping up on the counter to eat hers. Adora stood awkwardly in the middle of the kitchen in view of both, unsure of where to go or what to say.

"Oh Adora I'm sorry I should have introduced you. This is Shadow my aunt. Shadow, Adora is my girlfriend" Catra said between bites of her food. The disdain she placed "aunt" very apparent to all.

Adora froze as Shadow glanced over at her and scanned her once more. She'd been with her for only a few minutes and could understand Catra's reaction.

"Charmed I'm sure. Dear, do you have any wine? We really should celebrate your victory."

"Nope. I would never touch the stuff. Besides I don't think you'll be staying long enough to finish a bottle yourself."

Shadow glared at Catra for a moment before readjusting back to an unsettling slight smile.

"No matter. I love your hair by the way Catra. You look just like your mother. Well you would if you smiled at least. Adora have you seen pictures of my sister? She was really quite beautiful. Truly a shame what happened."

Adora opened her mouth to respond but stopped when she saw the look of burning rage on Catra's face. The way her claws dug into the countertop and her tail twitched.

“Don’t. Talk. About. Her” Catra hissed between clenched teeth.

“Oh sweet Catra are you still refusing to talk about her? It’s been over a decade now. You really should open up about it.” Shadow spoke over her shoulder to Catra, her body faced towards Adora.

Catra’s claws unlatched from the countertop with a creak before storming out of the room. Adora put a hand out to try and stop her but Catra shifted out of the way. Unsure of whether to chase after her or keep an eye on Shadow she stayed rooted to the floor.

Shadow kept talking as if nothing had happened. “It was truly a terrible accident. The police said the fire started in Catra’s room from a hair straightener she left plugged in, an unfortunate style phase of hers. She had been out for the night doing who knows what and her mother didn’t wake up in time to get out of the house.”

Adora couldn’t hardly process what she had said. Her heart ached for Catra. She could barely even fathom the guilt that she must feel. It was no wonder she never wanted to talk about her mom.

“I…I should go check on Catra…”

“Wait…Adora. I just want what’s best for Catra. She can be rather…reckless with her choices. It would be better for her if I were to handle the money from the court case.”

Adora didn’t know what to say to that. She was disgusted by the obvious attempt at manipulation.

“I think it’s time you leave” Adora said as she opened the front door and stood there.

“I see…Very well. Here’s my phone number. Have Catra call me when she’s being less emotional. It was…nice to meet you Adora” Shadow said as she handed Adora a piece of paper and left.

Adora closed the door forcefully behind her. She shoved the piece of paper into her pocket, dropped her food off on the counter, and went to find Catra. She found her curled up in the bottom of the closet, Melog protectively sitting in front of her. Adora knew she needed time still, so she sat down with her back against the bed leaving plenty of space for her to leave if she wanted. Melog came over to sit on Adora's lap and she stroked them while keeping an eye on Catra.

After quite some time Catra sat up and crawled over to sit next to her. She tucked her knees to her chest and curled her tail up. Adora debated on reaching out again but could still see how tense she was. She sat silently afraid that any sound or movement might cause her to run.

"Well you've met my family. What's left of it at least" Catra mumbled into her knees.

"I'm so sorry Catra. I didn't know what to do and she seems horrible."

"Oh trust me she is. She was drunk most of the time I lived with her. And the times she wasn't she was even colder and vile. I was just a nuisance that she kept around to keep the life insurance checks coming in. When that ran out, she kicked me out. Been on my own since that. I knew that bitch would be back though when she heard about what happened."

Catra rubbed at her neck. Adora recognized it as her tell for when she was thinking about Prime. Everything in her wanted to reach out and hold her. To make things right somehow. But she knew she wasn't ready to be touched yet.

"Did she….Did she tell you what happened?"

Adora shook her head as Melog hopped off her lap to rub against Catra's legs.

"It was my fault. I-I was…She told me to be more careful…and I… I killed her." Catra broke down sobbing.

Adora wrapped her arms around Catra and pulled her closer. “No. No you didn’t. It was an accident.”

Catra clung desperately to Adora. Her claws digging in sharply to her sides. Adora tried to fight back a wince as she held her tighter. She looked so small and fragile as if any word might shatter her into a million pieces.

Catra tried to talk between sobs. “T-that’s why… my hair… I can’t…I think of h-her every time I try to b-brush it. “

Adora felt tears streaming down her face as she held Catra. Adora had known she didn’t like to brush her hair but to find out the reason why was so painfully heartbreaking. She shifted the fragile girl on to her lap so she could press their foreheads together and stroke her cheek gently.

“It’s okay” she repeated in a whisper over and over. She pressed tear-soaked kisses to Catra’s forehead and cheeks as she held her close. Melog sat patiently pressed up against Adora’s leg.

Catra shifted to look into her eyes. A lifetime of pain and sadness in those beautiful blue and yellow eyes. Adora would do anything to take any of that burden from her. To make a fraction of it better, less painful. Her hand weakly pulled at the back of Adora’s neck as she leaned in to kiss her. The softness of the gesture bringing more tears to Adora’s eyes. They kept their foreheads pressed together; eyes closed. The only sounds in the apartment was a gentle purr coming from Melog.

“Your tears are dripping on me” Catra whispered.

Adora let out a small chuckle as she tried to wipe her eyes without losing the contact. “Sorry.”

Catra let out a small broken sigh, a sob choking in her throat. “I haven’t gone to her grave since the funeral…Would you….would you go with me?”

Adora nodded and kissed her again. “Of course. Whenever you’re ready.”

The Queen's Throne

Chapter Summary

Catra talks about future plans

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was in her favorite place. Just the two of them in bed in their underwear. Adora's arms wrapped tightly around her, one ear pressed into her chest and her tail teasingly tickling against Adora's bare leg. She watched dust motes float lazily through sun beams as she purred softly. Melog was curled up at the foot of the bed, their mouth and paws twitching slightly from some dream. Moments like this weren't uncommon but she treasured them all the same.

Adora let out a soft hmm before moving to rub Catra's ear. She purred louder and nuzzled deeper into Adora's chest. The perfect pillow.

"What did you want to be when you grew up Catra?"

Catra shifted to rest her chin on Adora and look up at her. Adora was still staring up at the ceiling and rubbing Catra's ear.

"Queen of the known universe" Catra said flatly.

Adora snorted and looked down at her, fixing her ocean blue eyes on Catra. The smile on her face so warm and bright that Catra could melt from just a look.

"I always wanted to be a superhero" Adora said. Catra raised an eyebrow sarcastically as Adora tried to pose with her hands on her hips. The effect entirely lost as Catra was flopped on her and Adora couldn't keep herself from laughing for more than a second. Catra squirmed up her body to kiss her neck, her tail wiggling to

try and tickle Adora's leg. She playfully kicked at it and squished her nose up before kissing Catra's forehead.

"You're my queen" Adora said with a blush.

"Ugh gross. That's so cheesy" Catra responded with a playful bite on Adora's neck. Adora just laughed and squeezed her tighter.

A few moments passed in a comfortable silence. Catra lazily traced a claw over Adora's chest while she rubbed the soft fur on her back. Sometimes when they cuddled lazily like this it led to sex but Catra was very content to just enjoy the feel of Adora's skin. To listen to her heartbeat pound in her ear. To smell her sweet perfume and taste coffee on her lips. She brought peace and comfort to Catra on a level she had never known before. She felt safe and often found herself lost in thoughts about the future. Their future together.

"I've been thinking though…about what to do with the money. I was thinking maybe I could open my own coffee shop. It's just a dumb idea I had."

Adora pulled her chin up to look in her eyes before placing a kiss on her lips. "It's not a dumb idea. And I think you'd be good at it. Plus, then I can get free coffee form you whenever I want" she said with a wink.

"Um no you still have to pay Adora. But I'd be willing to work out some other payment options" Catra said with a smirk, a fang poking out between her lips making her look even more mischievous.

Adora bit her lip before kissing her again. "I think I can live with that." Her hands roamed over Catra's body but after a moment she pulled back. "Can I brush your hair?"

Catra's ears perked up. "Right now?"

Adora gave a shrug and nod. "It's relaxing for me."

“Weirdo.” Catra rolled her eyes but sat up so Adora could sit behind her. She ran her fingers through her mane before pulling it into one hand and kissing Catra’s neck. A quiet moan escaped her lips as her claws dug into the bedspread. Adora chuckled, her breath warm on Catra’s neck, before grabbing the comb and starting to brush her hair.

“You’re a tease” Catra whined.

Adora cockily hummed to herself knowing she had won for the moment. She was too thoroughly enjoying the feeling of the brush on her scalp to voice her complaints. When Adora finished she tied Catra’s hair up into a short messy ponytail and turned her around so she could look.

“I like it. You look cute like this” she said booping her nose with a finger.

Catra bit at her finger and growled, “I’m not cute.”

“Yes, my queen.”

Catra growled louder and pushed Adora over back on the bed. Before she could teach her idiot girlfriend a lesson there was a knock on the door. Catra moved to sit her butt directly onto Adora’s abdomen before shouting for them to come in.

“Hey…are we interrupting?” Bow and Glimmer popped up in the doorway looking down at Adora who was blushing from only being in her underwear and also red from Catra sitting on her.

“Oh no I’m just teaching Adora a lesson about calling me cute. What’s up?” Catra said as she wiggled her butt. Adora let out a small groan but didn’t try to move her.

“We just wanted to see if you wanted to come to the harvest festival with us tonight. There’s gonna be a ton of cool things and fireworks.”

Catra’s eyes went big and wide. “Fireworks? Where? I’m in.”

Adora let out a breathy chuckle that died in her throat as Catra jumped off her to get dressed. She threw a shirt and pair of shorts over her shoulder at Adora hitting her directly in the face.

“Okay. I’m ready. Let’s go now” Catra said beaming. She had always loved fireworks. Sometime about big explosions. She just couldn’t resist.

Bow chuckled. “It doesn’t start for a couple hours yet, but we can go as soon as it opens.”

Catra pouted and grumbled as she pushed the half-dressed Adora back down to sit on her again, effectively trapping her arms in the shirt over her head.

“Catra!” Adora yelled and flailed, unsuccessfully removing Catra from her throne.

Bow and Glimmer laughed, set up a time for them all to be ready and left.

“Please get off me Catra” Adora wheezed from underneath her.

Catra obliged and slid off to sit next to her on the bed, legs crossed and casually looking at her nails. Adora sat up taking deep breaths and finally pulling her shirt down from over her face.

“You’re mean” Adora sneered and pointed.

Catra smirked and licked all the way up her arm. Adora squealed and flailed her arm around making Catra bust out laughing.

“Catra! That’s gross” she whined.

“That’s not what you said last time I licked you” Catra said with a wink and devilish smile.

Just as she expected Adora blushed, opening and closing her mouth to say something but no words coming out. Teasing Adora could be so easy and so rewarding.

“Come on dork. Let’s go get some food before the festival. Your queen demands it” she said the last bit in her most regal and official tone.

Adora laughed and followed along.

Chapter End Notes

> Just a little fluff to set up the next chapter. If anyone has any feedback on how the tone is going or anything I would greatly appreciate it :) thank you

Fireworks

Chapter Summary

The gang goes to the harvest festival

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Brightmoon's harvest festival was one of the biggest annual events in the city with visitors flocking from all over to come try the various fried foods, see live music, and play totally not rigged games. Adora had never been before but Catra had assured her that she would love it and that she would get her the biggest funnel cake she could find. Adora's mouth watered at the thought of all the delicious food she was going to try.

After they had gone out for lunch, they came back home and Catra decided to change again for the festival. It had seemed strange; she wasn't one to normally want to dress up and always seemed content to be in either comfy clothes or something she stole from Adora.

Adora had been playing on her phone sitting on the edge of the bed while Catra changed and wasn't paying attention when she came back out of the bathroom.

"Hey Adora"

"Hey Cat….tra" Adora had started to speak before she looked up and all words disappeared from her brain when she saw Catra's outfit. She had on a form fitting red tank top with a black mandarin collar top, but the best part was the cut out just below her neck that showed off the slightly thicker fur on her chest. The room was suddenly too warm and her mouth way too dry as she gulped and tried to catch her breath.

Catra's fangs stuck out in a hungry smile that threatened to devour her whole as she walked over to Adora and sat sideways across her lap. "What's wrong Adora. Cat got your tongue?" she teased as her tail rubbed against Adora's chin.

"Um…uh…what?" Adora was pretty sure her entire body was blushing as she snaked a hand under Catra's legs and behind the small of her back. Her eyes laser locked onto the cut out of the tank top as she licked her lips. Was it worth Catra teasing her for hours if she dove face first into the lush fur?

"Woah I knew this would get a rise out of you but still. You really are obsessed, aren't you?" Catra crooned, a hand lazily stroking Adora's bottom lip.

Adora pried her eyes away from Catra's chest to look in her eyes. Catra's smirk changed to panic as Adora started to cry. Catra frantically pawed at her face. "Are you okay? What's wrong?"

"Y-you're just so so pretty" Adora said wiping a tear from her eye.

Catra laughed and kissed her. "And Lonnie called me a useless lesbian."

Adora shrugged and gave an embarrassed smile. "I mean…I'm new to this whole identifying as a lesbian thing so I get a free pass right?" Adora had known for a long time that she was attracted to women but didn't really know what that meant or what to do about it. Besides she hadn't really met anyone that she wanted to be with until she met Catra. It had taken her awhile to really come to terms with her sexuality but Catra was patient with her and very supportive.

Catra smiled and kissed her again. "Sure thing. Besides I'll scratch anybody that says otherwise."

Catra shifted to straddle her and sat up to shove the cut out of her tank top directly into Adora's face. "Just get it over with. I know you're going to drool all night if you don't get this out of your system." She laughed and nuzzled into the soft fur, taking a

few deep breaths before Catra leaned back to kiss her. “I love you.”

“I love you too Catra.” Adora was pretty sure she was never going to get over the joy of hearing her say it. Or the feeling of being so loved and cared for. Catra had really worked to open up since she moved in and not just with her but with Bow and Glimmer too.

“You sure you’re okay? We can stay home if you need. I don’t mind.” Catra’s eyes searched her for any hint of hesitancy.

Adora leaned in to kiss her again, breathing in Catra’s scent. “I’m okay. Besides you promised me a funnel cake” she said with another kiss and beaming smile.

The four of them arrived at the festival just as the sun was beginning to hang low in the sky. It was already packed with people and much louder than Catra had expected it to be. Crowds really weren’t her thing, but she was doing this for Adora. And the fireworks. She grabbed Adora’s hand to calm herself, Adora smiled with the wonder of a child and it made Catra laugh. She made good on her promise by getting Adora a funnel cake and pulling her fingers back to safety before they could get accidentally chewed off. With most of the powdered sugar wiped off her face, Catra may have helped lick the last bit from her lips, they were ready to try something new.

“Oh! Can we do the archery game? Please please please” Bow begged.

“Bet I can kick your butt!” Adora was already running, dragging an excited and squeaky Bow behind her. Glimmer and Catra made eye contact, gave a mutual shrug, and followed their partners.

Catra and Glimmer decided to watch on the sidelines as the Bow and Adora squared off. Each player was given ten foam tipped arrows to hit as many targets as possible. Bow weirdly looked poised and confident as nearly every shot he took hit a target.

Adora however was a disastrous mess. Most of the arrows barely made it halfway or flung off in wild directions causing other festival patrons to give them a very wide berth. She did manage to hit one target which earned her a high five from Bow. He walked away with a giant stuffed teddy bear, nearly the size of Glimmer, and Adora sheepishly walked up to Catra with a small plastic alicorn. Catra tried not to react as Adora pretended to make it fly through the air and neigh, but she couldn't help but laugh at how happy she looked.

"You're such a horse girl."

"Am not" Adora said pouting but still playing with the toy.

"You really are Adora" Glimmer agreed.

Adora huffed and walked off a few steps. Unable to pretend to be mad she turned back around. "What's next?"

Before they could decide a booming voice came from behind Adora.

"ADVENTURE!... Oh hi Adora and crew." Sea Hawk walked up with Mermista following a few steps behind looking annoyed while also eating cotton candy. She always looked annoyed so Catra couldn't tell if this was for a special reason.

"Hey Sea Hawk. I didn't know you guys were coming." Adora smiled and gave him a hug.

"Oh yes. I'm Mermista's plus one. Well I would be if there were invites." Mermista groaned into her cotton candy.

"Anywayssss… do you guys want to hang out or whatever? Sea Hawk keeps going on and on about some dumb arm-wrestling competition."

"No way! We have to sign up for that." Adora looked like she was going to start foaming at the mouth with how excited she was.

They made there way over to the competition grounds and Adora, Bow, And Sea Hawk all signed up. Catra, Mermista, and Glimmer being the smart ones decided to grab some fruity drinks before taking seats to wait for the event to start.

Adora sized up her competition as she casually flexed her muscles. Sea Hawk seemed overly confident based on his stature and she ruled him out immediately. Bow might be a tougher challenge, but she had faith she could take him. There were a few other people that she wasn't worried about.

And then she saw her.

Standing much taller than Adora with arms that she'd kill for was a beautiful woman with a set of large oxen horns sprouting from her hairline. The woman sized up Adora before giving her a smirk and turning around. Adora checked to make sure she wasn't drooling before looking for Catra in the crowd. She had clearly seen how Adora reacted based on her eye roll and head shake. The smile on her lips gave Adora relief that at least she wasn't upset at her for being a "useless lesbian" again today.

The first few rounds went by quickly and easily as Adora took out her opponents within seconds. Sea Hawk was next and he had been tougher than she expected but she beat him still. He walked off pouting to go sit with her friends on the side lines. By the semifinals it was down to Bow, Adora, the buff woman and some other guy. She easily beat the guy as she watched Bow lose to the woman. Bow gave her a pat on the shoulder and went off to sit next to Glimmer and their giant teddy bear.

The two women sized each other up for a final time before placing their arms on the table. The bell rang and they immediately were locked in place. Adora was sweating and straining as she felt her arm being pushed to the table slowly by the woman. "Give up kid" she said between clenched teeth. "Never" Adora responded as she started to push their arms back towards center. Adora was putting everything she had into this, her arm shaking under the strain as

she started to gain ground. She screamed and slammed the woman's hand down to the table. She heard her friends erupt in applause as she shook the woman's hand. "I'm impressed kid. Didn't think you had it in you" was all she said before she walked off.

Catra had watched intently and still had no idea how Adora had bested the much larger woman. She ran up to their group carrying a gold medal around her neck and smiling. Catra stood up and gave her a kiss "Good job babe" and added in a hushed whisper "we'll talk about your crush later." Adora turned bright red but nobody else seemed to notice. She looked cute and Catra wanted to tease her some more but she'd be patient for now.

Seahawk and Mermista left in search of more "adventure" while the four wandered around trying different foods and playing random games. Catra found a dunk tank that she spent far too much money on, but thoroughly enjoyed dunking the obnoxious person inside over and over. Bow decided he wanted to get his face painted so the girls walked off to watch Adora play a strongman game while they waited for him. It took Adora a few tries but she managed to ring the bell and won a tiger plush.

Bow came back over smiling ear to ear with his face painted to look like a cat. Everyone laughed except Catra who didn't find it amusing. "Your friends are idiots." Adora squeezed her and gave her a kiss on the cheek.

"You know you love them."

Catra shrugged and tried to pout more but Adora peppering her face with kisses made her laugh. "Fine. Whatever. I guess I like them a little." Bow and Glimmer wrapped her up in a group hug before she could run away.

Eventually the sun set and they rushed to get in line for the Ferris wheel. If they timed things just right, they could be on the ride when the fireworks started.

Luck happened to be on Catra’s side for once as they made it to the top of the ride right as the worker stopped it. She held Adora’s hand and leaned her head on her shoulder for a moment just enjoying the peace of being away from everyone but Adora. She peaked back over her shoulder to Bow and Glimmer who were making out feverishly. She pointed it out to Adora, and they were laughing and looking for something to throw at them when the first firework went off. Catra pulled Adora in for a quick kiss before holding her hand and watching the show.

Chapter End Notes

I think I'm near the end of what I want in this series? I have no idea what I'm doing still :) I think i've got about 5 or 6 more chapters

Lilies

Chapter Summary

CW/TW: more about dead parent/ vague dissociation description. I think this is the last one hopefully

Summary- Catra deals with Shadow and visits her mom's grave.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As much as Catra did not want to deal with Shadow she knew that if she didn't call her she would just keep showing up at the apartment. It had been horrible enough with just Adora home and she couldn't image having to try and deal with Bow and Glimmer too. She took a deep breath before punching in her number on the phone.

"Yes?" It was late morning and she already sounded a bit slurred. Catra didn't respond at first as she felt anger boiling in her stomach. "Catra…Is that you?"

"Hello Shadow" Catra responded through clenched teeth.

"Ahh Catra. I'm glad to see you've come to your senses. Has Adora convinced you that I am more capable of handling your finances?"

"What are you talking about?" Catra couldn't process what she was saying. When would they even have had time to talk?

"Did she not tell you? After you stormed out rather rudely, I urged her to help you rethink how you'd be handling the money. I handled your mother's life insurance for you, and it seems only logical I would handle this as well."

Catra was fuming and couldn't process what to say. Why hadn't Adora told her? She clenched her hand around the phone so hard she heard something crack.

"And by handling the money you mean drinking it all."

"I provided you everything you needed to succeed Catra. I may have been tough on you, but you would be nothing without me."

"Everything I am today. Every good thing that I've fought for. Is because of me. Not you. All you ever did was make me miserable. You used me to get that money. And I will do everything in my power to make sure you never see a cent of this."

"Catra you're being unreasonable. If you would just listen to me"

She cut her off before she could lie anymore. "Don't call me. Don't show up at my apartment. I'm done with you trying manipulate me." She hung up and threw the phone across the room. Tears fell down her face as she fell to her knees and her hands clawed at her mane painfully. Melog came out and rubbed on her but she ignored them.

Time passed without her realizing it. She was lost in the anger and frustration when she felt Adora grabbing her hands and pulling them away from her mane. She hissed and swatted Adora away, shuffling to have her back safely against the wall. Adora looked upset and went to reach for her but stopped. "I just wanted to help. Sorry. I can leave if you want." She started to get up to leave.

"You…you should have told me. What Shadow had said. About wanting to handle my money." She took some deep breaths and tried to calm herself. It wasn't Adora's fault and she didn't deserve her anger.

Adora sat back down on the floor. "I didn't think it was a big deal. I'm sorry. It's your money and you're an adult. I didn't see how she could even get to it." Catra could see her point. It's not like Adora would know how manipulative Shadow could be. How she

could get into people's minds and get them to do whatever she wanted them to in order to benefit herself. It was a sick power of hers that Catra hoped she would never have to deal with again when she moved out. But that bitch always found a way to sneak back into her life.

"I just wish you would have told me." Catra scooted back to sit cross legged in front of Adora, reaching her hand out for Adora to places hers in it. She took another breath before relaying how the conversation with Shadow went.

Adora slowly and gently leaned forward to press her forehead to Catra's. "I'm sorry. I should have told you."

Catra kissed her forehead. "I'm sorry I got upset." She kissed her cheek. "Thank you for being patient with me. She kissed her lips, savoring the soft sensation. "Thank you for taking care of me." Adora wrapped her arms around her and leaned back so Catra was laying on her on the floor. She laughed and kissed her again. Melog taking the moment to hop on Catra's back. They let out a few loud meows before laying down and purring. "Really Melog?" Catra called over her shoulder still smiling and looking at Adora. They responded with a small meow but didn't move.

"I…I think I should go visit my mom's grave today. I know I'm asking last second so don't feel like you have to come" Adora cut her off with a peck on her lips. "I would love to come with. Can I run out and do one quick thing first though? Shouldn't take me long." Catra nodded and got up, disturbing Melog.

Adora gave her one last kiss and triple checked to make sure that she was okay before running out of the apartment. She jogged the whole way over to Perfuma's boutique and was slightly out of breath when she barreled through the door.

"Oh! Adora. It's nice to see you. Is everything alright?"

“Hi…Perfuma…Need….Flowers…Now….Please” Adora panted as she tried to regain her breath. She took a few giant gulps of air before giving an actual explanation to her running in unannounced. Perfuma helped her pick a bouquet of white lilies, asked that they do a double date sometime soon, and sent her on her way. Adora didn’t risk running home in case it damaged the flowers but walked as quickly as she could.

Catra jumped as she nearly fell through the door but then gave her a sad smile when she saw the flowers. “Ready to go?” she asked. Adora shook her head and they headed back down to the car waiting for them. She couldn’t read the expression on Catra’s face but there was sadness and pain in every line and crease of her face. A lifetime of it.

Adora held her hand and gave it a gentle squeeze as the car pulled up to the cemetery. It took them awhile to find the gravestone, but time stood still as they stared at it. The weather felt so incongruous with the moment; the sun shining brightly on a nearly cloudless day as birds chirped peacefully from the trees.

Catra shakily knelt down. “Um sorry I haven’t been back in so long. I wasn’t ready.” Her breathing was shallow and Adora could just barely see tears running down her face from where she stood still clutching the flowers. The vulnerability in her voice was like a hot lance to Adora’s gut as she forced herself to be strong for Catra. “This is Adora, my girlfriend. I-I think you’d really like her. She’s the best thing to happen to me since….” Catra started to sob and Adora finally knelt down to wrap her in a hug. Catra clutched at her tightly as tears clouded her vision. She knew coming here would be hard, but this was devastating, and it wasn’t even her parent. Adora couldn’t even fathom the pain of losing a parent, especially one that actually cared.

Catra’s sobbing slowly faltered to shaky breaths and sniffles as she ran out of tears. Adora shifted to sit down and pulled Catra into her lap, her hands weakly clutching at Adora’s shoulders. She brushed a few strands of hair from Catra’s face who solemnly nodded without looking up at her. A small sign that she was

mentally still there but not ready to move or speak. Adora would sit here all day and night if it made Catra feel better. If it made the pain somehow go away.

They sat there silently as the birds chirped and the sun tried to warm the coldness of the moment. After quite some time Catra shifted to rest her head on Adora's shoulder and let out a wavering sigh. Adora gently rubbed her back but still tried to remain mostly motionless, a rock for Catra to cling to for safety. "Are you ready to go home?" she whispered. Catra nodded into her shoulder.

She helped Catra stand before placing the flowers in front of the grave and taking Catra's hand to walk back to the car. The ride home was silent with Catra resting her head on Adora. She picked up the nearly unresponsive Catra and carried her into the apartment and placed her onto the bed. Adora laid down and Catra curled up into her with an ear flat against her chest so she could hear Adora's heartbeat.

Adora remembered the last time that Catra had shut down like this, after the laser tag incident, and knew it would be hours before she was ready to respond. And that was okay. She would wait. She'd be there to kiss her hair and whisper love and praise to her. She'd be there to feed her snacks when she was ready. She would stay as long as it takes.

Chapter End Notes

> Ugh so many feels. Will be back to much happier stuff next chapter!

Huntara: Competent Lesbian

Chapter Summary

Huntara gives some great advice

Chapter Notes

Just a heads up that the next chapter might take me a lil longer than usual. Struggling with an extra busy work schedule and obsessing over the upper west side fanfic. Seriously so good.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had been working at Crimson Waste for several months now and Catra could tell she loved working there, especially with the kid's ninja training groups. Sometimes she'd visit the gym just to watch Adora acting like a big dumb kid with them and running around like an idiot. She wished she could be like that. Just carefree. To just enjoy a moment and not overthink everything.

Catra was brought back to the moment by Huntara walking over. "Hey Catra how's things been?" She would never understand why the woman was so nice to her, or how she got so muscular, but at least she didn't always try and make small talk with her. Sometimes it was just a nod from across the gym or a quick "how are you" and then she'd be on her way.

"Hey yourself. Been alright. You?"

"Ah can't complain. Adora's been a big help. She's always rushing in to help with things before I can even ask her. It would be annoying if it wasn't so damn nice."

Catra snorted and went back to watching Adora. She really did have a problem with rushing in to help people. Always going out of her way to do things for her or Bow and Glimmer. Always taking care of her and making sure she ate breakfast before work. It was

annoying. But also endearing. It's what made Adora the big dumb idiot that she loved with all her heart who was currently being suffocated under a heap of children.

"You could have this you know. If it's something you want" Huntara said leaning against the railing Catra was perched on.

"What? Work at a gym with a bunch of smelly kids? No thanks. That's Adora's thing."

"No, I mean you could have kids. I see the way Adora lights up every time they come in for class. Have you talked to her about it?"

Catra blushed. Did Adora want kids? Did she want kids? Her mind started going a mile a minute as her brain sped full speed ahead into the panic of figuring out a future. Kids always seemed like something better left handled by well adjusted people. She didn't have anything against them really, at least in small doses, but mostly she had never thought about having her own.

"Uh that's really personal…But I guess I hadn't thought about it. I mean we're not even married and we haven't lived together that long and I need to figure out what I'm doing with myself…" Catra trailed off.

"It's not a rush Catra. Just something to think about" Huntara said. They sat in silence for a few moments watching Adora get crushed under a pile of kids, laughing the entire time. Huntara excused herself and got back to work.

Catra was still sitting on the railing, so lost in her thoughts that she didn't even notice Adora come up to her until she gave her a kiss.

"Hey Catra….you in there?" Adora said slightly concerned that she wasn't responding.

"Yeah…Hey…do you want to have kids?" Catra blurted out. Okay that was not how she was expecting this to go. Well the proverbial

cat was out of the bag. She felt her pulse quickening as she watched Adora's face go from blank to confused to something different. Terrified? Contemplative? She couldn't quite tell.

"Right now?" Adora's voice raising in slight panic and concern.

"Yes, right now. Impregnant me. No, you dummy. But like…in the future?" Catra felt herself holding her breath and tensing as she waited for the answer. Why was she so worked up about this? She'd never even thought about them having kids before this moment.

"I hadn't really thought about it a whole lot. I mean I guess when I picture our life together, I see a couple kids, and a house, and maybe some cats, and like a garden, and Bow and Glimmer are there, and all our other friends are there, and"

That was a lot of information for Catra to process. Adora had pictured years and years of their lives. Together. Married. With kids. And a future. Maybe having kids would be something she was interested in if Adora was there. She tried not to dig too deeply into the millions of obstacles that would make that dream nearly impossible.

Catra cut her off with a sarcastic chuckle. "Clearly you haven't thought about it much."

Adora blushed a little and leaned in to give Catra a kiss, Catra's legs wrapping around her strong waist. "Okay maybe I've thought about it a lot. But most importantly I want you. The rest of it is just kind of a bonus on top. And I don't want to rush anything. We have all the time in the world."

Catra wrapped her arms around Adora's shoulders and pressed their foreheads together. "So just to circle back to things…you want to get married?" That look of panic and something else came back to Adora's blushing face.

"Are you…are you asking me r-right now?"

What? No! Calm down. Just a hypothetical." Relief flooded her features. But also sadness? Catra felt like she was overclocking her brain to process this whole terrifying situation. Did Adora want to marry her? Now? And most terrifyingly…Why didn't that scare Catra? Could she be scared of not being scared? Was that even possible?

Adora seemed to take a second to process before answering in a soft whisper. "Oh…well. I mean just hypothetically. Yes….Very much so." Catra couldn't help the smile that crept to her face. Adora, the clumsy girl that fell all the time, almost burned down the apartment, and ate like a rabid dog wanted to marry her.

"Well…hypothetically I might be interested in that too." And with that Catra's brain imploded. She'd really just told Adora she wanted to get married. They said they loved each other all the time so it's not like she didn't know how to be mushy, but this was so much bigger. This was talking about their future together. And somehow it was terrifying and the most comforting sensation she'd felt all week. Sure, she had to actually ask her first, which that thought would be something to spiral into later but for now she tried to ignore it.

Adora hugged her so tightly that she swore she heard a rib pop. "Adora…too…tight" she wheezed. Adora blushed and loosened her death grip to a more reasonable level.

Adora leaned back to look in her eyes giving a mischievous grin that sent shivers down Catra's spine. "You know…you should get some practice with kids though to see if you're up for it" Adora said. She wasn't giving Catra an option on that as Adora pulled her off the railing, Catra still attached around her waist and shoulders, and walked them over to the group of kids that had been goofing off while Adora talked to her. Catra was yelling to be put down but Adora had a strong grip on her back.

"Alright everybody this is Catra, my girlfriend." Adora plopped her down and held her hands firmly on her shoulders. The group of

kids just stared at her. “She’s gonna teach you how to do the floating steps today.”

Adora walked off to watch from the sidelines while Catra tried to not panic. These were just kids. Just dumb kids that weren’t going to be mean or make fun of her. She’d watched Adora work out enough that she could probably figure this out. Or at least make up some decent enough garbage that the kids wouldn’t notice.

“Um.. Hi… So what you wanna do is get some good speed and just hop back and for them. I like to jump on all fours but if you’re big enough you can do one leg on each platform.”

With that Catra demonstrated by running on all fours and jumping back and forth between them. She decided to add in a little flair by landing into a summersault. The kids clapped moderately while Adora clapped overly enthusiastically.

“I guess you guys try now?” Catra really wasn’t sure how this was supposed to go. If only she had spent more time paying attention to what Adora was actually doing and less time staring at her muscles flexing. She mentally shrugged. Staring at her hot girlfriend was a better use of her time.

Adora walked back over. “Alright single file everybody. Let’s try and do Catra’s way.”

The kids for the most part did surprisingly well with only a few trips and stumbles. There was a young magicat boy that tried and missed the last jump, landing on the padded floor beneath the step. Catra watched as he ran off to go hide in a corner. Adora took over the group and asked Catra to go check on him.

He was hiding behind a large platform with his knees tucked up to his chest and tail wrapped around his legs. He couldn’t have been more than six or seven and had tears streaking down the fur on his face. Catra didn’t know what to do. She barely could handle her own emotions and kids were extremely emotional. She

decided to sit right next to him in the same position. She gave him a few moments to sniffle and cry himself out.

"When I was your age I wasn't very good at climbing things. I remember I tried to climb this huge tree and I got stuck up on a branch. I tried to come down but when I saw how high up I was I just panicked and froze."

"What happened?" he said between sniffles.

Catra laughed. "I cried a bunch before my mom had to come get me down. She was…she was really sweet. She told me that I'd get better at it as long as I kept trying." Catra thought about the bittersweet memory. The feeling of missing her was still a constant dull ache. Visiting her grave with Adora had helped to relieve some of the guilt for not going sooner but she knew better than to think the pain was just going to magically go away.

"I didn't want the other kids to laugh at me" the boy said.

"Sometimes people suck. I mean…sometimes they're going to be mean. But you can always do your best. And that's all you can really do."

All of the sudden the boy hugged her, taking her by surprise. She froze before giving his shoulder a squeeze. Maybe she wasn't so bad with kids.

"Alright you ready to try again?" Catra asked.

The boy sniffled one more time and got up. They walked back over to the obstacle and he tried again, this time making the last jump, landing into a clumsy summersault. Catra beamed at him as he jumped up and down excitedly.

Since it was Adora's last group of the day she decided to stick around and wait for her so they could walk home together. As hard as she tried not to, she kept picturing what their future could look like. And every time she looked up to see what Adora was doing it just made her want that future even more. She didn't

need it to happen right away, especially with her still trying to decide about opening her own shop, but maybe sometime soon. Besides didn’t some couples get engaged and then married way later? She’d have to do research.

Finally, Adora was ready and they walked home hand in hand, both of them smiling like big idiots.

Damn Huntara and her good advice.

Chapter End Notes

I wrote most of this I think two weeks ago (time isn't real) and it finally feels right in the timeline :)

Triple Date

Chapter Summary

> Picking up immediately after the last chapter Catra and Adora have a movie and pizza date night with friends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"OHMYGODTELLMEEVERYTHINGRIGHTNOW" Bow was rapid fire screaming and shaking Adora by her shoulders. Adora's eyes were wide but she was chuckling and blushing nervously.

"Okay so she just kind of blurted it out. Like just 'Hey Adora do you want to have kids with me and get married and live in the two story tudor home that you've dreamed about your whole life'… Okay well she didn't say all that. But like you guys. She wants to marry me! Can you believe it?'"

"No Adora. Who could have guessed that you and your hot girlfriend that is clearly deeply in love with you would have wanted to marry you? Gasp" Glimmer said sarcastically with a hand on her hip. Okay so Adora new she could be a little…slow and oblivious when it came to picking up on clues but Glimmer didn't have to be rude about it. She stuck her tongue out but almost bit it from the enormous smile she couldn't suppress.

The second that Adora and Catra had gotten home after she finished working, she had come up with a total fool proof excuse of needing to talk to Bow and Glimmer about paying rent next month and snuck off to their room. She was blushing and pacing and a total mess of flailing limbs but eventually managed to blurt out about how they were going to get married. And that's when Bow had cut in to shake her almost hard enough to give her whiplash until Glimmer shoved him aside and grabbed her cheeks in both hands and stared intensely into her eyes.

“G-Glimmer….what are you doing?” Was she going to kiss her? Right after she told them that Catra wanted to marry her? It’s not like Adora had ever thought about it or wanted it or fantasized about it when they first met…. Getting distracted. Adora was very happy that Bow and Glimmer were together and happy and… Glimmer cut her off before she could spiral further.

“I’m so happy for you Adora” Glimmer said before shifting to a rib crushing hug. Bow jumped in on it and practically lifted the two of them off the ground with a happy squeak. When they finally backed up she just so happened to look down at Glimmer’s hand…with a ring on it…a new ring…on her left hand. A few more second passed before the realization hit her like a train.

“DID YOU GUYS GET ENGAGED?” It was Adora’s turn to scream now. Bow and Glimmer gave each other a quick ashamed look before wrapping their arms around each other. She saw Catra’s head pop up in the door frame before leaning on it.

“Hey Sparkles you finally made the move? Congrats.” Catra knew? Also Glimmer proposed to Bow? The more she thought about it the more that made sense somehow. She was always so brave and usually the one to make the first move.

“Wait? You knew? I didn’t know…” Had they really not told her? Adora was their best friend and sure Catra had been pretty good with them lately but still. She pouted a little as Catra came over and wrapped her arms around her.

Glimmer fixed her with her best sad pout. “Adora I love you very much and you’re my best friend but…you are a terrible actor. I knew if I told you then you’d get all weird around Bow and he’d find out. And Catra is just really good at finding things out.” Glimmer blushed at that last bit of information. Catra just purred gently against her. Adora glared suspiciously out of the corner of her eye at Catra. She’d dig into that weird reaction later.

“Okay, okay. I guess you do have a point. I’m really happy for you both though.”

“And we’re happy for you two! I’m so proud of you for talking your feelings out and not waiting ten years to give me little Catradora babies” Bow said like that was a totally normal thing to say. Adora felt Catra tense against her back but not let go. Hopefully she wouldn’t be too upset that she had ran in and told them how the conversation went.

“Catradora?” Catra scoffed, rolling her eyes.

Glimmer shrugged. “He calls us Glimbow if it makes it any better.”

“Oh! What if we did a double wedding?” Bow shouted.

All three women looked at each other before yelling “NO!” Bow pouted and went to sit on the bed. Adora gave Glimmer a hug and a demand that they talk more later before grabbing Catra by the hand and yanking her back to their bedroom.

“If you wanted to get me alone you just had to ask” Catra said in that cocky voice that always made Adora weak. She was too weak to come up with a good comeback, but she thought of something better. She walked up confidently and grabbed Catra by the waist pulling her into a kiss. The little gasp that escaped Catra’s lips was all the proof she needed to know her plan worked. The shaky inhale Catra took when their lips parted and the way her eyelids fluttered for just a moment were just the cherry on top.

“Ugh don’t give me that smug smile Adora” Catra said pressing their foreheads together and smiling.

“I’m not doing anything” she said continuing to give her best smug smile. Catra rolled her eyes. Adora continued after a moment of gloating. “So…how come you didn’t tell me?” She tried to hide the hurt in her voice.

“I-I wanted to tell you I swear. But Glimmer threatened to show up to Horders and tell Kyle that I wanted to watch his one-man improv show multiple nights in a row.”

“Wow. That’s low. Especially for Glimmer.”

Catra looked like she genuinely felt guilty and Adora couldn't bring herself to actually be upset with her. Besides she really was a bad actor. She just never knew when to quit and always started to pronounce things weirdly. She thought of the time she tried to lie to Bow's dads to impress them when she first met them and told them she was a "schoLAR of the ACADemy" with Bow. Yeah, it hadn't gone well.

Adora brought her hand up to stroke Catra's cheek and gave her a warm smile. "It's okay. But it just means that I'm gonna make my proposal even more romantic."

"What? That's not fair. I thought I was gonna propose!" Catra squeaked.

"Shouldn't have kept secrets from me" Adora said with a shrug. So Catra wanted to be the one to propose? Well not if Adora did it first. The hotheaded streak of competitiveness emboldening her was probably going to be the death of her but at least she'd have a just as hotheaded wife to go down in flames with her.

Catra growled and jumped on Adora pushing them both over onto the bed creating a giggling breathless tangled mess of limbs. Catra's lithe frame snuck out from under her so she could sit straddling Adora. She looked really nervous as she seemed to be searching Adora's eyes for something. She took a breath before her voice started shakily. "S-so I really want to get married…b-but I'm not ready yet. I think I want to open my own coffee shop first... If that's okay with you."

Catra's voice trailed off at the end. Was she afraid that Adora would get upset? She gently pulled Catra down to lay on her and she immediately nuzzled into her neck. "Catra I just want to be with you. And if you think you'll be happy with your own shop then I'll support you fully. Besides we can let Bow and Glimmer go first so we can have a totally better wedding than them." The soft laugh and purr vibrating her chest was all she needed for an answer. She was happy to wait for Catra. For as long as it took.

After a few peaceful minutes of cuddling Bow and Glimmer bust in and jumped onto of them. Catra growled and hissed before launching off the bed to go hide with Melog. Adora accepted her fate until a bony elbow rammed into her stomach. "Ugh…off… please." She gulped in air as soon as she was free.

"Sorry not sorry. Hey, do you wanna have a double date with us tonight? We were thinking pizza and a movie? We can get your favorite with all the toppings on it" Glimmer asked.

Adora's mouth drooled a little just thinking about the pizza that Catra had called "an abomination in the eyes of all gods." A tad dramatic even for Catra but she was allowed her opinion, her very wrong opinion. "We actually have a double date with Perfuma and Scorpia tonight. Oh! What if we had a triple date? I can check with them and see if they'd be up for it."

"Is a triple date a thing? Isn't that just a hangout at that point?" Bow asked Glimmer while Adora text the other girls. Glimmer just shrugged in response.

Perfuma and Scopria were on board but since their place was fairly crowded with plants and the three cats they had adopted, Adora offered to host at their place. Bow, Glimmer, Adora and a begrudging Catra panic cleaned the apartment for an hour before they felt ready. After a "quick", it was anything but quick when Catra decided to join, shower they were ready for the "Triple Date Extravaganza" as Bow had started calling it.

Right on time Perfuma and Scorpia showed up at the door carrying the stack of pizzas they had intercepted from the driver on the way up. They had ordered several pizzas so Adora could eat her "abomination" all by herself. With a few bowls of popcorn to go with the pizza and everyone settled in, on, and around the couch and living room they pressed play on The Hunger Games.

"Oh I love this movie! Especially the part where" Scorpia started before Perfuma slapped a hand over her mouth. "Spoilers! Dear remember we talked about this. Adora hasn't seen the movie yet."

"Right. My bad. Sorry Adora" Scorpia said with an embarrassed blushed.

Adora had just settled in and was getting absorbed into the story of Katniss and her lame straight boy love interests when a piece of popcorn hit her in the face. She looked over to Catra who was sticking her tongue out and crossing her eyes. She chuckled but went back to watching in terror as Katniss selflessly volunteered for the games to save her sister. Another piece of popcorn hit her in the face. This time she glared at Catra before patting her lap. Catra smiled and hopped up to sit contently in her lap, laughing quietly as she fed Adora popcorn. Adora's eyes were glued to the screen and every time someone tried to butt in with a comment she'd shush them and flail her arms as a vague threat.

Catra watched with an amused smile throughout the movie as Adora would gasp and stare intently at every dramatic scene. The light from the TV flickering in her blue eyes was better than any dumb movie. How she had never seen the movie before was a real mystery, but she was happy to get to watch her enjoy it up close. Even with only partially watching, the emotional intensity of the movie proved to be a bit too much for Catra though who snuck outside to get some fresh air right as it ended. Movies had always been sort of a trigger for her anxiety. The intensity and raw emotion of scenes could leave her feeling panicky and nervous.

After a few minutes of staring up at the night sky she started to feel herself relaxing. She heard the door open and expected it to be Adora checking up on her but was surprised to find Perfuma.

"Oh…hey Perfuma…Just needed a break from all the noise" Catra mumbled. She didn't want to talk to her about how movies made her feel out of control. It didn't seem like Perfuma noticed anyways.

"It's a beautiful night. I just came to look at the stars for a minute."

They stood there in a comfortable silence. A silence that Catra needed. "Hey…can I ask you something?"

"Sure Catra. Did you finally agree to join my flower arrangement class? I have one this coming Tuesday."

"Oh hell no…I mean… no thanks…Anyways I just wanted to know if it was really hard opening your boutique or whatever."

"Oh well. It was rather challenging. There was so much paperwork and saving money and searching for a location and" Perfuma kept talking but Catra started to zone out. Maybe her dream of her own coffee shop was too hard. There was just so many hurdles to jump and obstacles to get through. She couldn't imagine herself sitting through a bunch of dumb meetings with banks and realtors and whoever else would want to take all her money. She let her shoulders slump as she felt the weight of defeat overtake her.

A gentle hand on her shoulder brought her back to reality. "It's worth it if that's what you were asking Catra. I love having my boutique. I love getting to make people happy with flowers or a haircut or just talking."

Catra nodded but didn't say anything, which apparently meant that Perfuma was just going to keep going on with her emotional motivation speech. "Scorpia might have told me about your dream to open a coffee shop. I think it's a lovely idea Catra. And I could help if you wanted. A boutique is quite different but there's still some general things that would be the same."

"R-really?" Catra was more shocked than annoyed. She'd barely even mentioned her dream to Scorpia and she'd not been the best to Perfuma since they met all those months ago. They barely even talked and Catra was…not the nicest in general. But here Perfuma was offering to help her figure things out. She fought back the self-doubt that had creeped in and told her that she couldn't do this. She knew she couldn't do it alone but with help? Maybe.

“Of course, Catra. Just let me know” Perfuma said with a smile and started to walk back inside.

“Wait…Perfuma. Just. T-thank you. For being nice.” Perfuma smiled so wide it looked painful before giving Catra an ambush hug. She let her get it out of her system and was just about to push her away when Bow popped outside. “Hey Catra can you come back in and stop Adora? Glimmer dared Adora to pick up the couch and now she’s lifting all the furniture while Scorpia and Glimmer cheer her on.”

Catra rolled her eyes and chuckled as they walked back in to rescue her dumb girlfriend from herself. Her dumb soon to be fiancé she thought. That thought alone was enough to make her chest swell with happiness and her mind race with ideas.

Chapter End Notes

> Had a really hard time thinking of what I wanted to say with this one for some reason. Hoping the next one comes easier!

Tiramisu Part 1

Chapter Summary

The Best Friend Squad goes to visit George and Lance

Chapter Notes

Well this chapter is getting ridiculously long so here's the first part of it. My writing pace is unfortunately slowing down more and more as I try and figure out where I'm going so please be patient with me :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Please tell me you’re joking Adora.”

“What? I kind of like it” she said pulling at the baggy homemade sweater that Glimmer’s aunt had made so she could stare down at it. The dark red color did look nice on Adora but the white alicorn with rainbow mane was just too much. And also so very Adora. “Besides she made one for you too” Adora said as she pointed to the bed.

A dark gray sweater with a cat face on it. “Uh uh. No way in hell. I’m not wearing it.”

Glimmer and Bow came in with their sweaters on. Bow had a white sweater with a giant red heart on it and Glimmer had a light purple sweater with a pink crescent moon. They all looked ridiculous. Catra crossed her arms and pouted as they all stared at her expectantly. Adora gave her big sad eyes and pouty lips like a cartoon character. Catra groaned and huffed as she put the sweater on. It was too big and floppy, the sleeves dangling past her hands.

“So cute” Bow said in a squeaky whisper. Before she could launch to scratch his eyes out Adora came and wrapped her up in a tight hug smiling innocently at her. She glared and let her body go limp

so Adora would have to hold her up. Adora let out a snort but obliged.

"Okay so the car is going to be here in a few minutes. Are you guys ready to go?" Glimmer asked.

"Yeah Sparkles we're ready" Catra mumbled. She couldn't believe they had convinced her to spend the holidays with Bow's dads. And even worse Glimmer's aunt had made them all these sweaters that were apparently a mandatory uniform for the weekend. It was some sort of tradition for the three of them to spend the weekend relaxing and exchanging presents. And now she was roped in with these idiots and their idiotic sweaters. Adora had promised it would be worth it whatever that meant.

Catra took a deep breath and snuck off to say goodbye to Melog. She found them sitting patiently on the couch as if they were waiting for her. She sat cross legged next to them and they gave a happy sound before curling up in her lap. Scorpia and Perfuma promised to take care of Melog for the weekend and to send her pictures and updates. It's not like she was nervous or going to miss the dumb cat. Okay maybe she'd miss them. A lot. But Bow had said George had forbidden cats from their house after a previous incident where one knocked an ancient vase off a podium.

Melog continued to purr and knead their paws into her leg while she tried to get a grip on her emotions. She knew she wasn't actually mad at Bow and Glimmer or anyone really. The last few weeks of working on the paperwork for the coffee shop had just been a nightmare and she was exhausted. Things were going quickly but that just meant more pokers in the fire. Plus she was still working full time and had had to find time to buy everyone gifts and hide them where Adora wouldn't go snooping around looking for them. But Adora was here and she had been helping all week any way that she could and had promised to find time to relax this weekend. Catra just had to keep from biting anyone's head off.

A big sigh and a couple sneaky kisses to Melog's head, she'd never let anyone actually see her do it, and she was ready to go. After carrying her small duffle bag full of clothes, mostly Adora's that she stole even though she had plenty of her own, and watching Glimmer struggle to drag her giant suitcase down the stairs and stuff it into the car they were on their way. Catra leaned against Adora as she watched out the window. Bow had got stuck up in the front seat next to the driver who was telling them their whole life story. Catra snickered. Served him right for calling her cute. Glimmer fell asleep almost immediately leaning against Adora's other shoulder and Catra watched as Adora fell asleep next with her arm wrapped around both of them. She thought she'd be jealous of how close they were. How intimate they could be for friends that hugged and touched more than Catra had in her whole life but somehow it felt so natural and innocent. Hell, even Catra was getting used to Glimmer giving her obnoxious kisses on the cheek. She knew Glimmer did it just to annoy Catra, it always worked, but it was oddly endearing. She loved this group of weirdos. She gave up fighting exhaustion and snuggled into Adora before closing her eyes and drifting off.

Adora woke up as the car shifted onto the cobblestone driveway. Glancing down at her girlfriend on one side and her best friend on the other she smiled happily as she wiped the drool of her face. Bow turned around to smile at them looking exhausted from staying awake the whole time, too polite to ask the driver to stop talking. Adora watched as two of her favorite people slowly woke up and blinked their eyes open as the car stopped in front of the house. The library turned house featured an ancient style of architecture, jewel studded Romanesque pillars covered in ivy vines, arched windows surrounding the rotunda, and wood framing around the gargantuan front door. It reeked of money and class in a way that foster care Adora would never feel comfortable with but Bow's dads, George and Lance, were truly wonderful people who had fallen in love with the building and done everything in their power, including chaining themselves to it, to preserve the monument. She knew the inside was filled floor

to ceiling, wall to wall with bookshelves containing books on anything and everything and artifacts from ancient times.

She looked over to Catra who's jaw had dropped upon seeing the library. "Holy shit. Bow how loaded are your dads and can they adopt me?"

Adora snorted. She had said nearly the same thing the first time she saw the house. Bow ignored the comment as he tried to yank Glimmer's bulging suitcase out of the trunk looking frustrated and stressed about more than just his fiancée's obnoxious overpacking. She went back, dislodging the suitcase fairly easily, and placed a hand on his shoulder. "Hey it's gonna be okay. Your dads love Glimmer. Besides Catra and I can distract them if things get tense."

Bow smiled and gave her a quick hug. "Thanks Adora. You're right. Just been a little nervous with the whole engagement thing" he replied with a smile. Adora and Glimmer had met Bow here for the first-time so many years ago and it had been rough at first, but George and Lance supported and loved their son no matter what. That love also applied to anyone that Bow trusted.

Although this might have been a big holiday for Bow and Glimmer, Adora had to admit that she wanted George and Lance to like Catra too. They were almost to the front doors when Bow's dads popped out and wrapped him up in a big hug. George waved at them to join the hug and Adora nodded to Catra to get in on it as well. She seemed skeptical but wrapped her around Adora's waist and leaned into the group hug. She tried to convey with her smile that everything would be alright. Catra smiled back, message received.

After dragging themselves and Glimmer's giant suitcase inside George and Lance let everyone get settled into their rooms on the second floor for a couple hours before dinner. Catra dropped her bag on the floor and hopped onto the bed as Adora started to unpack her clothes and place them neatly in the dresser. She wanted to look her best this weekend and not just to impress

George and Lance. Once she was finished, she sat down next to Catra and took both her hands in hers. “You okay? It was a lot for me my first time here too.”

Catra let out a small sigh. “Yeah. It’s a lot for sure. But I’m okay… thanks for checking on me princess.” What started as a gentle shove to the shoulder quickly escalated into all out wrestling on the bed. Several headlocks and a failed attempt at a suplex later, Adora had won and celebrated by heavily flopping on top of Catra, a breathy squeak escaping her lips as the air was forcefully expelled form her lungs. Adora shifted to make sure she wouldn’t suffocate before placing a kiss on her cheek.

“How are you so heavy?” Catra asked through catching gulps of air.

“I’m just so full of love for you Catra.” She peppered every inch of Catra’s face with kisses until they broke down laughing and squealing.

“You’re such a dork.”

“Yeah I know” Adora laughed into the soft fur of Catra’s neck. She was looking forward to having a whole weekend with Catra, without work, without Catra stressing about her business proposal and issues with finding the right location. Just her and her wonderful girlfriend and her best friends. She thought about the presents she had tucked in her small suitcase and smiled. It had taken her months of painstaking research to find the right gifts for everyone. She really hoped that she got them right.

“I can feel you smiling into my neck dork” Catra said while poking her gently in the arm with a claw.

Adora adjusted to look in her blue and yellow eyes. “Just thinking about how the gift I got you is the best gift ever.”

“No way. My gift is so good that you’re gonna cry. And then you’re gonna be all “Oh Catra you’re the best. I love you so much. You can propose first since you’re clearly the best gift giver.’” Catra

broke down cackling as Adora let out a loud snorty laugh. Every time Adora tried to say something she just broke down into laughter again till she was gulping for air and clutching her sides.

Finally, after gaining some composure she traced her hand up the side of her cheek and leaned in to kiss Catra, stopping only a fraction of an inch away from contact. "My gifts so good it's gonna knock your socks off babe." Before Catra could come up with one of her famous comebacks she pressed their lips together. Claws tried to pull her closer, to fuse their bodies together in the embrace as her own hands pulled at her neck and kept Catra's lips tightly to hers. A tail wrapped around her ankle, a silent request to never let go. She felt as Catra tried and failed to slide a hand under the hem of her sweater; her claws getting stuck in the extra long sleeves of her own sweater. She flailed and tried to retract them with a frustrated squeak. Adora tried her best not to laugh but Catra just looked so adorable as she tried desperately to free herself.

"Let me help dummy" she said as she grabbed her wrist and carefully pulled her claws free before giving her hand a gentle kiss. Catra glared and pouted before nuzzling into her neck, Adora's hands automatically moving to rub her ears and stroke her mane. A deep sigh turned into a gentle purr as Catra started to relax into her touch. They would lay there all day like that, dozing in and out of consciousness if allowed but dinner would be soon. A few minutes more wouldn't hurt though. Just a few more kisses to her girlfriend's hair. To her forehead. To any part of her she could reach. Because Adora could never get enough of Catra.

Their quiet moment of cuddling felt like an eternity and also an instant as the tenderness of it was shattered by a knocking at the door. Catra made no attempt to move in her half-asleep state but grumbled as Adora slid herself out from under her and over to open the door. A very enthusiastic Lance was there and announced that dinner would be ready shortly.

"Come on sleepy. You gotta get dressed for dinner" Adora called as she pulled her sweater and shirt off to change into her dinner

attire. Within seconds soft hands were wrapping around her bare waist and even softer kisses traced her shoulder. Catra's ear twitched against her neck in a way that tickled and made her laugh. She spun around in the embrace to face her.

"You know you could just go like this" Catra said as she continued to kiss her shoulder and neck.

Adora's hands grabbed at her lower back pulling their hips together. "Mmm something tells me Bow wouldn't be too thrilled about that."

Clawed hands traced up her spine forcing her to shiver and gasp. "Probably not. But I'd be very happy." Catra's blue and yellow eyes locked with hers, a crooked and hungry smirk with fangs spreading across her lips.

Adora shook her head to try and clear the fog of desire that threatened to consume her whole; grabbing Catra's shoulders and pushing her to arm's length. "W-we need to g-get dressed before we end up extremely late."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Always such a goody two shoes princess." Luckily for Adora she moved away and grabbed her clothes from her duffle bag. Adora let out a breath she didn't know she was holding and tried to go back to changing. She wasn't about to go to dinner half naked with Bow's parents but she still hoped her outfit would be enough to keep Catra interested in tearing it off of her later. A simple white pantsuit that she had tailored to fit just right. The sleeveless maroon silk blouse she wore underneath was loose fitting but somehow still hung to her curves just right. Finally, she combed and retied her hair in her signature pompadour ponytail and turned around to check if Catra was ready.

Catra knew she was staring, could feel drool threatening to drip from her slack-jawed expression but there was nothing in the world that would pull her gaze away. She had changed quickly

into the tux she had worn for pride prom all those months ago and turned around to watch Adora as she changed. She wasn't proud of it but had snuck a peek through Adora's suitcase to try and find out what present she had picked out but instead found the immaculate white suit. It was beautiful on its own but now seeing Adora in it was better than anything. Even better than her dreams of giant Adora in the skintight suit.

With all the confidence in the world Adora walked up to her as Catra's knees threatened to buckle. Was she breathing? If she had been, she certainly wasn't now as Adora traced a thumb across her bottom lip. Her voice taunting as Adora's eyes burned into hers. "Something wrong Catra?"

She gulped and had just enough brain power to closer her mouth to keep herself from drooling on Adora's finger. Her brain was short circuiting at how ridiculously hot her girlfriend looked. Adora had asked a question, right? She opened her mouth to respond and the quietest squeak was the only sound she could muster.

Get it together Catra. She tried to focus on anything else. Tried to tear away from Adora's magnetic gaze and mischievous grin. Taking a step back her knee finally buckled and Adora's arms were instantly wrapped around her, holding her up. Her sweet scent invaded every inch of Catra's air, suffocating her in the most delicious way. How did Adora still have such an effect on her after all these months? How could she reduce Catra to a squeaking limp puddle of a person with just a suit?

"Okay I'm actually starting to get nervous now. Are you okay?" Adora asked, her grin having transformed to a concerned frown. Catra finally registered that Adora was still almost entirely holding her up and adjusted to stand. She aggressively shook her head and coughed a few times to try and force herself out of her lust filled head.

"Yup. Doing great. You…you look alright."

Adora scoffed. “Alright? Catra you nearly fainted looking at me” she said cocking a hip and raising an eyebrow.

Catra crossed her arms and pouted. “Yeah well I’m just hungry.” Adora gave her a wink. “Oh come on Adora. Not like that. You’re so immature.” She tried to force the words to sound mean but she couldn’t help laughing. She pushed past Adora, shoving her shoulder, to open the door but before she could reach it Adora was grabbing her wrist and pulling her in, kissing her so intensely that electricity surged from her tail to her ears. And in an instant Adora was pulling away, smiling devilishly and out the door before Catra could even process what had happened. Catra walked out of the room in a stuttering and blushing daze only to run into Adora, Bow and Glimmer in the hallway.

“Catra you okay? You look really red. Oh no you don’t have a fever do you?” Bow asked as he tried to put a hand to her forehead. Her ears flipped back as she growled and slapped the hand away before glaring at Adora who stared back innocently. Stupid hot Adora.

“I’m fine. Let’s get this over with.” She ignored the looks Bow and Glimmer shared as she grabbed Adora’s hand and headed downstairs.

The dining room was as over-the-top fancy as the rest of the library including a chandelier hung over a large mahogany table, hand hewn exposed beams framing the arched ceiling, and stained-glass windows that George and Lance had carefully delivered and installed from where they had recovered them from some ancient ruin. George led her around the room telling her about random pieces while they waited for Lance to finish preparing dinner. Catra didn’t really care about archaeology or ancient stuff but she tried to focus, or at least make it look like she was, while stealing glances of Adora in her too perfect to be legal suit.

Lance started to bring out food, so they moved to take their seats, Catra sitting next to Adora and across from Bow and Glimmer.

George poured drinks for everyone while Lance finished bringing out food. As they finally settled into their own chairs at the ends of each table George raised his glass for a toast. “To our wonderful and talented son Bow and his equally lovely friends.” Lance smiled and looked like he might cry. Catra smirked as she recognized where Bow got his sappy overemotional nature from.

The food was amazing and Catra happily tried everything that they passed around the table when Bow cleared his throat. “George. Lance. I actually have an announcement to make.”

Lance perked up. “Oh Bow are you finally telling us you’re going to switch majors to Library Sciences?”

“No” Bow squeaked. “I actually wanted to tell you that Glimmer and I are engaged.”

George stood up abruptly from his seat. Catra couldn’t read the emotion on his face as he walked over to Bow, pausing a moment before wrapping him up in a hug. Lance ran over and was picking up Glimmer from her chair and crying on her while embracing her.

“We’re happy for both of you, Bow” George said as he finally let go of his son to hold his husband’s hand. “You’ll have to tell us all the details. Have you picked a date? Venue? Glimmer tell me you have a dress picked out?” Lance was excitedly asking questions. George placed a hand on his shoulder to calm him down. “Sorry. I’m just so happy for you both. We’ll talk details later.”

Catra felt Adora reach over and squeeze her hand. She looked up to see the beautiful heartwarming smile on her face. The type of smile that silently told Catra that she was happy and excited for their own future. Catra leaned over to give her a quick kiss while everyone else was distracted.

With the announcement out of the way and Bow seeming a whole lot less nervous George excused himself to grab dessert. He came back with a tray carrying a moka pot and six small plates of what Catra assumed to be tiramisu.

“Catra, Adora had told us a little bit about you and your endeavor to open your own coffee shop. We’re quite impressed. I’d love to hear more about it if you’re willing to share” George said as he served everyone cake and espresso.

She looked over to Adora who appeared slightly embarrassed but squeezed her hand again. Catra cleared her throat. “Um yeah. It’s been a lot of work, but I just need to find the right location and then I’m about set to open.” Catra took a bite of the tiramisu before continuing. Well she planned to continue but the sweet taste of the mascarpone and bitterness of the espresso on her tongue was so perfectly balanced that she ended up eating the whole piece before she even realized it. She blushed. “Sorry. Wow that’s the best tiramisu I’ve ever had. Might have to steal your recipe for the shop. I-if that’s alright I mean.”

“Of course” Lance said with an all too eager smile. “We’re just happy to see Bow and his friends succeed. We have a friend in the real estate business. I’ll give you his contact info later. Maybe he can help with the location” George added.

George let everyone know there would be a short break before exchanging presents, so they headed back up to their rooms to change and relax.

Chapter End Notes

> I forgot to add this note earlier but lemme just say a gigantic THANK YOU to anyone who draws Adora in a suit. Because WOW.

Tiramisu Part 2

Chapter Summary

Best Friend Squad Gift Exchange!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra rubbed a finger over her bottom fangs as she absentmindedly watched Adora shrug out of her suit coat and hang it up immediately like the dork that she was. The light of the room casting shadows to accentuate the definition of her bare arms. She slipped out of her own suit and back into the obnoxious sweater and a pair of Adora's pajama pants that she had ripped into shorts.

The electrifying tension of earlier had fizzled out and been replaced by a warm, comfortable silence as they cuddled in bed. Adora held and kissed her hands as they laid on their sides facing each other. Overwhelmed with her love for Adora and how insanely nice Bow's parents were Catra felt herself start to tear up. After a childhood so full of pain and neglect, of never feeling worthy of another's love she found herself here totally surrounded by people who loved her. She felt Adora's love even on days when she was angry and lashed out or too dysfunctional to talk. It wasn't always the burning hot passionate love that made her rip buttons off shirts and scream Adora's name. Sometimes it was soft and sweet. Sometimes it was Adora bringing her lunch to make sure she ate or showing her a cat video just because she knew Catra would want to see it. Sometimes it was many different things, but it was always there. She was always there.

Adora looked concerned at the sudden outburst of tears but Catra held a finger to her lips to keep her from ruining the moment. She pressed into her, letting Adora wrap her arms around her tightly. "Thank you for loving me" she whispered into Adora's neck. Arms

wrapped tighter around her as she heard a few stifled sobs from above her. Catra pulled back to look in Adora's eyes before letting out a small tear-filled chuckle. "We really are useless lesbians." Adora laughed and pulled her back in closer.

After a few more tears and many more kisses Catra was ready for the gift exchange. Ready as she could be at least. Since she didn't know George and Lance, Adora had agreed to do a gift with her as a couple but everything else she had picked on her own. She grabbed her pile of gifts, laughed as Adora fumbled with her own and they headed down to the study.

The study felt similar to the rest of the house but somehow far more comforting. The reclaimed wood paneling on the walls, recovered from a ruin, and the large fireplace with stone hearth, also recovered making Catra wonder if George and Lance were secretly grave robbers, brought a warmth and hominess to the room that felt missing from other parts. Chesterfield sofas and matching armchairs faced each other with a large coffee table in the middle currently covered in presents of varying sizes, shapes, and wrapping abilities. Bow was proudly eyeing his perfectly wrapped gifts when Catra came in and threw her not so neatly wrapped ones on top of his. "Quite the sweatshirt modification Bow" Catra snickered. He had somehow managed to remove the lower half of his sweater to make it a crop top without the yarn coming undone. Bow rubbed the back of his neck and blushed, but Glimmer swooped in and reached up on her tippy toes to give him a kiss on the cheek. "I think he looks handsome. Now let's open presents!"

Some of the gifts were certainly more extravagant than others but it was clear that everyone had brought their best when it came to finding the perfect gifts. Catra watched as Adora squealed with childlike delight upon receiving a gift receipt for free horseback riding lessons from George and Lance. Bow had made a similar sound too when he opened Catra's gift to him; a gift card to a local archery range. He had nearly crushed her to death, but she blushed knowing that she did a good job. "I just saw how much

you liked the archery at the carnival and thought it would be good. It's not a big deal."

Wrapping paper and gift bags flew all over the room as gifts were exchanged. Lance had inexplicably given Adora a pair of sandals and a pair of socks with unicorns on them. Catra was going to do everything in her power to not let her wear the two together.

Catra opened a card from George and Lance that contained a gift card for way too much money to a restaurant supply store and a small extra note with the recipe for the tiramisu from earlier.

Dear Catra,

Forgive us for a rather impersonal gift but we wish you the very best with the opening of your shop and hope that this helps provide a few supplies. We look forward to many more holidays with you and Adora.

Love, George and Lance

She smiled at them and tried to force herself to not cry for a second time today. Even useless lesbians had their limit on crying. "T-thank you" was all she could manage to say. George gave her a nod and Lance looked like he might cry too.

She looked over to Adora who had opened all of her other presents but was nervously holding the one that Catra had got her. "It's not gonna bite you" Catra teased her. Adora blushed and shakily tore the wrapping paper on the only gift that Catra had actually attempted to wrap perfectly. Catra had started calling Adora "princess" as a joke but it slowly evolved into a weirdly endearing term. She was Catra's princess so when she found a delicate gold tiara with a ruby in the center it somehow seemed like the perfect gift. Adora smiled as she traced her finger along its edges. "It's beautiful Catra" she whispered still staring at the gift.

"I know it's kinda fancy for every day, but I thought maybe for special occasions" she mumbled, rubbing her arm nervously.

Adora was still staring at it. Did she really like it? She looked happy but wistful as if miles away in a dream. She didn't have time for concern because all of the sudden Bow and Glimmer were there shoving a white clasp envelope in her hands. "This is from all of us" Glimmer said nearly squealing with excitement. Adora finally tore her gaze from the tiara to watch her, an expression in her eyes that Catra couldn't quite place. Nervous? Excited?

She opened the envelope and pulled a "Open" sign as photos fell out. Not what she had been expecting.

"Um so we kind of found the perfect place for your shop and put down a down payment on it for you" Adora said, the nervousness in her voice finally connecting with the look in her eyes. Catra picked up the photos and tried to mentally process what they were saying. She recognized the location in the photos because she had instantly fallen in love with it when it used to be an antique store. The small brick two story house that the first floor had been converted into a store with a living area above on the second floor filled with shelf upon shelf of knickknacks and priceless heirlooms. She loved wandering the aisles and staring at everyone's useless garbage that was cherished at some point or another. It brought a sense of ephemera, of simply being in the moment and enjoying the bittersweet passing of time, that calmed her. The store went out of business a few years ago and Catra stopped coming by. She assumed they had torn the building down for something new. "H-how…I-I went here and they…" she trailed off unable to formulate a full sentence.

Glimmer cut in. "Well Bow and I were walking around the city and we saw the for sale sign and instantly thought of you. So we brought Adora by and she said it was perfect too. George and Lance helped us get in touch with their realtor friend and ta-da."

She looked up at all of them. The excitement on Bow and Glimmers faces, the soft smile on Adora's as her hand still traced across the tiara, the proud smiles of George and Lance, they were

all too much for her. And for the second time today Catra broke down crying.

Panic set in as Adora saw the look on Catra's face, the one that said she was overwhelmed and overfilled with emotions. The same painful faraway look that had consumed her at her mother's grave. Tears had just started to fall to her cheeks when she was up and scooping Catra up to carry her out of the room. She yelled something over her shoulder about just needing a moment as she carried her outside to a small bench out in the back garden. Adora held her on her lap and smoothed her mane back.

"I'm sorry Catra. I knew it was going to be too much but they were all so excited to share this with you."

Catra sniffled and took a few sob filled sighs. "Yeah well. I know you just want to see me cry" Her tone much softer than the sarcasm of her words. That was a good sign Adora thought. She wasn't going to get lost in her head if she was still responding.

Adora did her best to sound smug. "I did warn you that my gift would knock your socks off. I guess I didn't account for it knocking your tears out."

The snort that came from Catra was worth whatever dumb line she had just said. "Dork…I don't even wear socks." She looked down to her bare feet, her toes wiggling. Adora laughed into her hair as she hugged her tighter.

She gave her a few more minutes to collect herself, listening to the sniffles taper off and her grip slowly loosening from around her neck. "I-I don't deserve this." Catra's whispered it so quietly she wasn't sure if it was meant for Adora or herself. She debated whether she should say something but Catra shifted to look in her eyes and continued. "I don't deserve you. Or all the things you do for me."

Adora's anxiety bloomed into a painful ache in her heart. How could Catra think that? After everything she had done for Adora. After she had given her the most amazing birthday that Catra had painstakingly planned? Her mind raced as she tried to find the right thing to say but Catra continued before she found her words.

"I don't deserve it but…I want to earn it."

Adora searched into her eyes, hoping to convey how she felt with more than just her words. She placed her hand on Catra's cheek, willing her to search into her soul through her eyes. "Catra, you don't have to earn anything. My love. My everything. It's all yours. I give it freely because you do deserve love." She took a shaky breath before continuing, never breaking eye contact. "We….we've both made mistakes but that doesn't change anything. Doesn't make me love you any less. I love you." Catra broke the transfixed gaze to kiss her, her lips tasting slightly salty from the tears. The darkness and pain of the panic that had filled Adora's chest was instantly obliterated by the love that poured from Catra's lips.

"We're even now" Catra said with a chuckle as she wiped away Adora's tears. "And I guess I love you too."

She placed a final kiss on Adora's lips before getting up and stretching feeling the exhaustion throughout her body. Crying this much really took a lot out of her. Damn Adora for making her feel so many things.

"Alright let's go face the peanut gallery" she said stretching her hand out to Adora.

The walked back in slowly. "What were you thinking about when you were staring off into space with the tiara?" Catra tried to ask casually but her tone came out nervous. She still couldn't place the emotion on Adora's face as she had looked lost.

Adora blushed and smiled bashfully. "I-I was picturing the future. I'll tell you later."

Catra gave her a suspicious look but let it go. She'd find some way to drag it form her later. At the edge of the study doors she took a deep breath and prepared herself. Adora continued to hold her hand as she faced the rest of the group, looking down at the floor to help her find the strength to face people that had given her something she had wanted for so long now. "Um. Thank you. I can't even begin to tell you how much this means to me but yeah…."

Bow and Glimmer were up in an instant and crushing her and Adora into a big group hug. George and Lance joined in too and she blushed but couldn't bring herself to admit that she hated this.

The rest of the night went by without crying thankfully as they sat by the fire and talked. Lance brought out the scrapbooks of little Bow in the bathtub which Catra would never let him live down. She even snuck a picture with her phone to use as blackmail whenever she might need it. The conversation died off and she watched as Glimmer nearly fell asleep on Bow before everyone decided it was time for bed.

She and Adora got ready for bed silently, simply enjoying each other's company. "Alright princess. Spill it. Let's hear this future dream" she finally said when they were cuddled up together in bed. She made sure she could see Adora's face in the dark room, her eyes easily adjusting to watch the changes in her expression.

"Oh…um well I was picturing our wedding. You were there. Obviously. And you looked so beautiful. You had your hair up in a messy ponytail and I had the tiara on and this white and gold dress on. And your cape across your shoulder matched it." Catra watched the softness in Adora's expression as she spoke, the way her eyes traced back and forth as if seeing the image on the ceiling above her.

“I sound hot.” Adora laughed and leaned her head to look at her. Her eyes the color of a calm sea at dusk transfixed her as much as the warm smile at her lips. Catra thought of so many things to say and yet somehow none of them were right. Not even the sarcastic ones that would make Adora laugh or the heartfelt words that would make her cry. So she kissed Adora, hoping it was enough. Hoping it told her more than her words ever could.

Adora slept peacefully with dreams of their wedding and future. Dreams of an older Catra with a child on her hip looking over her shoulder at Adora. Dreams of dancing and laughing. As badly as she wanted to continue to dream, waking up next to a softly snoring Catra was better because it was now. She watched her for a moment before Catra’s eyes fluttered open and she yawned. “Staring at me in my sleep ya creep?” Adora laughed and kissed her just as her yawn finished. “I need about six cups of coffee after all that emotional junk last night” Catra mumbled between kisses.

It took a while, and some coercion, to coax Catra out of bed but they finally stumbled their way down to the dining room where everyone else already was seated and eating breakfast. A cup of coffee was instantly in Catra’s hand as Lance set down a piece of the tiramisu from the night before in front of her. “Bow may have warned us that you can be…well not a morning person let’s say.” Catra glared at Bow over her coffee up and stuck her tongue out before digging into the cake excitedly. Poor Bow had tried to be his overexuberant self a few times first thing in the morning and had faced the wrath of Catra.

“So what’s the plan today?” Adora managed to get out between heaps of scrambled eggs and toast.

“We thought a picnic at the beach would be fun. It’s too cold to swim but should be nice enough with the sun out” George said as he began clearing the table. Adora was still grabbing the last bites off her plate as he took the plate away.

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone survived the sappiness overload in this one.

I think I've got one more part of this ridiculously long weekend and then the last two chapters of this story.

Tiramisu Part 3

Chapter Summary

> Wrapping up the Best Friend Squad hang out at the library. Adora panics. Catra comforts.

Chapter Notes

> I was just about to post this last night and then ended up writing three more pages (in Word) that's just Adora being Adora. Also sometimes I forget how snarky Catra is throughout the show so this is me reconciling that.
> Edit 6/26/20- I previously said I had two more chapters after this....probably more than that if im being honest with myself. we'll see!

Adora was weirdly taking a long time to get ready for the picnic so Catra went to go find Bow and Glimmer. Maybe she could get Bow to blush and squeak. That was always worth a laugh or two.

"Oh you're just making it too easy for me now Arrow Boy." Bow and Glimmer were standing in the hallway waiting for them with their sweaters on but Bow also had on a pair of rainbow socks and ankle strap sandals. Must have been a present he got while she was busy totally not crying or whatever.

"Arrow Boy?" Glimmer responded.

"Uh yeah. Cause the gift I got him? Keep up Sparkles." She winked to try and show she was joking. As much as she liked making Glimmer mad, it wasn't going to be good getting her upset this early in the day. But teasing her, that always on the menu. Glimmer stuck her tongue out at her but smiled. "So was there a deal at Dads-R-Us or something Bow?"

Glimmer snorted and tried to cover her laugh with her hand, but it was no use. The problem was she wasn't laughing at Catra's comment. She was looking behind Catra down the hallway where

Adora was. She was smiling so wide and it warmed Catra to see her look so genuinely happy. Her eyes traced down Adora's body, still wearing the ridiculous sweater. She did kind of like how it looked on her, baggy and comfy. Tracing further she saw what had made Glimmer laugh. The unicorn socks and sandals. Catra rolled her eyes so hard it hurt. "This is it. My own personal hell. Surrounded by idiots wearing socks and sandals" she mumbled to herself.

Adora came over skipping and gave Bow a high-five so hard it echoed down the hallway before squeezing Catra and kissing her cheek. She blushed and groaned. "Ughhhh. You guys are so embarrassing."

"Aww Best Friends Squad!" Bow squeaked as he furthered the 'Embarrass Catra to Death' plan by crushing her into a hug. She groaned and accepted her punishment. She always knew karma would get her one day for all those times she yelled at the fake-nice soccer moms at Horders.

The four of them walked downstairs to find George and Lance ready with a picnic basket and some other supplies for the afternoon. Lance looked so happy he might cry when he saw Bow and Adora wearing their fashion nightmares. Even sensible George was wearing sandals, thankfully no socks.

The walk through the forest down to the beach was pleasant and the weather was perfect. Sporadic cumulus clouds and seagulls dotted the otherwise crystal blue horizon. The sun shone brightly and warmed her fur as they cleared the tree line to a pristine and empty beach. George and Lance set up a few chairs and blankets on the sand while Bow, Glimmer, and a begrudging Adora laid down to relax. As much as Catra thought a cat nap sounded nice she wanted to explore the beach a bit.

Adora laid fitfully on a blanket next to her friends. How was anyone supposed to just lay here and relax? Maybe if Catra had stayed but without her this was torture. She tried to force herself

to stay still and quiet so Glimmer wouldn't keep glaring out of the corner of her eye at her. She bunched her hands up in fists. Shifted them to cross over her chest. Relax Adora. Relax. A seagull flew overhead and squawked. She tried to mimic it quietly. Another glare from Glimmer. She popped her lips together.

"This isn't working is it?" Glimmer turned to her and asked.

"No, can I please get up now?"

Before Glimmer could even do more than nod, she was up and running after Catra, stopping only a second to rip her socks and sandals off. She took in the scent of the ocean air as she ran, pushing her legs on faster and faster into a full out sprint. Glimmer would never understand that this was her freedom, the feel of her muscles exerting herself and nothing but the sound of her blood pumping and fast breathing.

She let her thoughts drift away as adrenaline pushed her forward.

Catra's ears flicked back as she heard her girlfriend barreling full speed at her over the sand. She had enough time to register that she should have slowed down by now.

She better not…

Adora rammed full speed into Catra and toppled her over causing them both to roll and tangle up in the sand. "Seriously Adora? The whole beach and you still run into me?" Catra said as she winced and pulled an arm out from under her heavy girlfriend. She snorted as Adora pulled her face up, completely covered in sand, where she had faceplanted. Catra's laughing grew louder as she pouted and tried to swipe the sand off her tongue with her hands.

After a few more laughs at Adora's expense and a few painful stretches from both, they walked hand in hand down the beach. As far as they could see in front of them the shore stretched on, nearly white sand glistening under the warm sun. Although it was nearly winter it was still perfectly comfortable in her dumb

sweater and her bare feet enjoying the feel of the sand between her toes.

Her thoughts drifted back to last night as she sat down to stare at a small crab scuttling across the sand. She was getting everything she had wanted for years now. The girl of her dreams who currently was sucking on her finger because of course she tried to poke the little crab and it pinched her.

The coffee shop would be open soon. Her coffee shop. With her rules. The idea still felt foreign. And the idea of feeling like she deserved this was impossible to grasp. She knew she wasn't the worst person in the world but still.

Adora came and sat next to her, tucking her knees up and resting her chin on them, looking out across the water. Catra stared at her, admiring her. The way the slight ocean breeze caught her hair. She had left it down today and Catra loved the way it framed her face and made her look softer. Her eyes traced every line of her face, the slight wrinkles around her eyes and the smile lines near her lips. The thinnest of scars across her nose from when Catra had scratched her after waking in a panic from a nightmare. It felt like a lifetime ago. Adora turned to her and smiled. "You're staring at me."

"Yeah well it's not cause I like you."

Adora playfully bumped into her, smiling even wider. Catra turned to stare back at the water as she continued to struggle with feeling worthy of Adora and everything good in her life.

She felt Adora tuck a loose strand of hair behind her ear before rubbing it gently. "You do deserve it you know."

Catra turned to stare at Adora. She hadn't said anything about what she was thinking. Was Catra right all along about Adora being a cyborg who apparently had telepathic abilities? She hadn't thought about her conspiracy theory in so long. She smiled slightly at the memory.

“You scrunch your face up a specific way when you’re doubting yourself” Adora replied to the question Catra hadn’t asked. Her hand moving to wrap around Catra’s shoulder and pull her closer. She gratefully leaned into the touch, resting her head on Adora’s shoulder.

As far as she had come emotionally while dating Adora, she still found it hard to remain open. To openly share her fears. Adora always seemed to have a sixth sense, or a telepathy neural chip, that clued her in on how Catra felt though. “I-it helps…when you remind me.”

Adora leaned back pulling Catra with her to lay down. The warmth of Adora holding her and the even warmer sand brought comfort and a sense of peace. “You are worthy of love and good things Catra Applesauce Meowmeow.” Catra burst out laughing at Adora’s use of her full name and felt so deeply loved that it made her chest ache. She scooted up to kiss Adora, still laughing so their teeth clicked together. It wasn’t graceful but it was perfect in the moment.

“You think the water is warm enough to swim?” Adora asked after a few minutes of staring up at the clouds. They sat up to look back over the water.

“Not a chance princess. But I bet I can beat you back to Bow and Glimmer.”

Catra pushed Adora over and started running for their friends. She’d always been told “there’s no honor in cheating” but if she won then who cared? Not her she thought as she heard Adora yelling and chasing after her. She didn’t dare look back as she put all her energy into the sprint.

She made it back completely out of breath, mere seconds before Adora who was only slightly breathing hard. She really should get around to testing her conspiracy theory. Maybe Entrapta could run a few tests? On second thought she decided it was better not let Entrapta mess with her girlfriend.

“Wow…Bow…You…Look…Ridiculous” Catra said between gulps of air.

Glimmer had been busy burying Bow in the sand and then shaping it to make him look like a rather busty mermaid. He smiled and winked at her. “Well I think he looks pretty but he better stop moving before I bury him completely” Glimmer chimed in as she reshaped the sand.

Adora gave her a playful shove. “I cant believe you always cheat, Catra.”

“Yeah you think you’d catch on by now.” Catra gave her a wink and shove back. Adora laughed and shook her head.

The temptation to tease Bow. She tried to resist. Well she thought about trying to resist. But it was just so easy. She bent down to squat next to him and gently let her tail rub against his nose. His face scrunched up as he whined, trying to keep from sneezing. Too late. He sneezed, just barely missing her tail as she squeaked and jumped back, and sand flung everywhere. Glimmer glared at Catra but didn’t say anything.

“Sorry Sparkles” she said as she got up, letting her tail tease across Glimmer’s shoulder.

Adora shot Catra a disappointed look and helped Bow up as he brushed the sand off him. She was about to mumble an apology to the two when George and Lance announced lunch was ready.

Glimmer grabbed a sandwich and was just about to bite into it. “Oh Lance, Catra was telling me she was a little disappointed that she didn’t have a pair of socks and sandals to match Adora and Bow. Did you end up picking her a pair like you had said?”

Lance’s eye lit up. “Yes! Oh Catra I’m so sorry. I picked them out, but George thought that you wouldn’t appreciate the gift. See I

told you George that she would want them. Don't worry dear. I'll be sure to get them for you first thing when we get back."

"Gee…thanks." Catra glared daggers at Glimmer who smugly smiled right back at her. Seconds later though she laughed and gave a small bow to Glimmer. She had to give her credit for being a lot more dastardly than Catra had expected. Glimmer nodded her approval and took a bite of her food.

Catra ate more of the delicious tiramisu, Lance packed it just for her, while Adora was literally funneling food into her mouth. George and Lance looked slightly concerned but Glimmer and Bow reminded them this was normal for Adora.

The rest of the day at the beach was peaceful. Catra took a nap in the sun while Adora and Bow kicked a ball back and forth, and Glimmer went over some wedding plans with George and Lance. All in all, Catra had to admit that Adora had been right about it being a good vacation. She could get used to the idea of doing this every year with her. Soon enough though they were packing up and walking back to the house.

Lance, true to his words, handed everything he was carrying to a confused George and ran off to their bedroom. He came back carrying a pair of black sandals and a pair of red socks with kitten on them. Catra took them while Glimmer and Adora snickered in the background. Bow would have probably laughed too if he wasn't being the "perfect son" and helping George putting everything away. Adora gave her a nudge and wiggled her eyebrows, hinting she should put them on.

Catra only ever wore partial foot coverings or shoes when absolutely necessary, like when Scorpia broke something at work for the third time in a month and she got sick of pulling glass out of her feet, so to wear full socks just felt horribly wrong. And to then put those full sock-covered feet into sandals was akin to torture. She stared down at her feet for a minute before taking her claws and ripping the bottom half of the sock off so her toes would be free.

“Actually, this ain’t so bad. Thanks Lance” she smiled and walked off. The shocked looks on Glimmer and Lance’s faces were worth it. She’d have to figure out away to keep the socks from unraveling but that was a problem for future Catra, and more likely future Adora.

Dinner was uneventful but delicious, another overly extravagant feast cooked up by Lance that Adora scarfed down greedily. Between her workouts and helping people train at work she could barely manage to eat enough to keep up with her caloric demands. So proper eating etiquette be damned, she was going to eat until Catra and Bow had to drag her upstairs to bed. She paused, fork nearly at her gaping mouth, to admire her friends around the table. A quirky bunch but so loveable and loving that it made Adora nearly burst with happiness every time she thought of them. And to know that Catra wanted to marry her…well that was a whole new level of happiness, and anxiety, that surged through her system.

“You good princess?” She turned to see Catra smirking at her. Adora had forgotten she was eating, the fork still hovering in front of her mouth. She blushed and quickly shoved the bite into her mouth and mumbled her confirmation.

Everything was great.

Totally fine.

Not panicking at all.

No, there was no reason she would have to panic about planning the perfect proposal and even more perfect wedding.

She just needed to make like seven binders.

And maybe a color board.

Definitely a color board.

And some diagrams for seating?

Was she getting ahead of herself?

It's not like they had proposed yet. Should she be working on that already?

Also when did the room get so hot? Was everyone hot? Or was it just her? She looked around furtively but everyone seemed fine.

…

Suddenly the food was gone, and her fork being gently taken from her hand, still near her mouth, by George as he cleared the table.

She sat back and tried to focus.

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So it was maybe too early for a seating chart but she could always get started on planning color palettes for the ceremony. And the reception.

But what color would Catra wear? She always looked good in red.

Ideas spun around her head so fast that it made her dizzy.

"I think she finally ate herself into a food coma" Bow commented from across the table as he rubbed his own extended belly.

A hand at her shoulder tried to pull her from the spiral of plans and ideas that swarmed her. Catra's hand. The hand that she was going to marry. Well the hand connected to the body that she was going to marry.

Did Catra want to get married in the fall? She seemed more like a fall person.

But then again…

She took a deep breath and tried to focus as the claws on her shoulder dug in just barely. Enough to convey concern. Enough to remind Adora that she hadn't responded since food had been placed in front of her.

She debated for a second if she could lie well enough to push away Catra's concern.

She could fake it right?

Not a chance.

Taking a deep breath, she shot a glance to Catra, letting the anxiety she felt inside hopefully convey through her eyes. Catra gave a nearly imperceptible nod and then an overexaggerated yawn and stretch. "Well as much fun as it is to watch Bow rub his food baby, I think I'm gonna take a nap. Adora you coming?"

Saved by Catra. The perfect girlfriend that she was going to marry sometime soon after the perfect proposal that would only take seven binders and a few color boards. She nodded, gave a rushed "thank you for dinner and everything" to George and Lance, before rushing out behind Catra.

Catra knew Adora was freaking out when she couldn't even remember how to put food in her mouth and chew it. Seriously, that girl could be a hot mess when she got stuck in her head.

She tried to think back through the events of the day to see if she could find a trigger. Was she upset that Catra had ripped the socks? It's not like she wanted to damage them just to be mean, but she knew it wasn't the nicest move still. She made a note to apologize to Lance tomorrow morning before they left.

Did she not like when she teased Glimmer earlier at lunch? She dismissed that; she would have said something by now. Besides Glimmer was the whole reason she was wearing the dumb socks anyways. She hadn't taken them off still, but it was just because the wood floors of this stupidly fancy house were cold. It wasn't

like she liked them even though she was planning to fix them when she got home.

Catra walked slightly in front of Adora all the way to the bedroom and laid down, propping herself up against the headboard. Adora trudged in behind her and flopped face first down into the bed. She groaned into the mattress before shifting to lay curled up into Catra's side. "Too full to lay face down" she mumbled as Catra rubbed her back gently.

"That's what happens when you eat three chicken breasts, a plate full of mashed potatoes, a bowl of green beans, and….was it two pieces of cake? I lost count." She was teasing but she knew it helped Adora sometimes to get her off from hyper focusing on whatever issue she got stuck on. "Three pieces of cake" mumbled from Adora who was pressed into her side.

Catra chuckled. "You gonna tell me what's up or do I have to start poking your stomach till you explode?" Her hand threateningly slid from Adora's back to her stomach. Not applying pressure, just a single claw ominously placed above her abdomen.

No response came other than some grumbling sounds. Catra applied a slight amount of pressure. "Catraaaa" whined the sad lump next to her. She pushed a little harder until a hand finally pushed her away.

"Okay fine but you're mean."

She shrugged. Nothing she didn't know already. Adora continued. "I just…I got thinking about proposals and weddings and color pallettes and you'd look good in the fall but the weather is nice in the spring and what if I cant find a dress because my shoulders are so big? And do we both walk down the aisle? Oh gods I didn't even think about who's going to talk me. Could I ask-"

Without realizing it Catra slapped Adora on the face. It was mostly gentle because of the weird angle she was at but she watched in horror as Adora's face turned red.

“Ow! What was that?”

“Sorry! You were freaking out and it was freaking me out.” Catra rubbed at Adora’s cheek gently as she took a deep breath. “Okay. Just try not to panic? Wow sorry that advice sucks. Let me…let me try again.”

She took another deep breath, mostly to stall, while she tried to figure out what to say.

“So you’re afraid that things won’t be perfect?” Adora nodded into her side.

“Well it won’t be.” Shit. That came out harsher than she had meant judging by the tears forming in Adora’s eyes.

“Okay hold on. Ugh. I suck at this. What I mean is that nothing is perfect.”

“Not helping” Adora mumbled as she hid her face again.

Catra adjusted to make Adora look at her. “Nothing is perfect because we’re people and life is messy and complicated but that doesn’t make it less beautiful. You can make plans for months and then something happens the day before that messes it all up. But that’s okay. Because the important part is that we’ll figure it out together.”

“Promise?”

“I promise” Catra said before placing a soft kiss on Adora’s trembling lips. She stroked her hair gently as she kissed her forehead.

“Besides we’re getting really good at improvising. Remember when you almost burned the apartment down and we ordered take out? It wasn’t perfect but I loved every second of it because I got to spend it with you dummy.”

Adora rolled her eyes and smiled. “You’re never going to let me live that down are you?”

“Not a chance, princess.” Catra placed more kisses on Adora’s lips, her neck, her cheeks. Enough to ensure Adora was feeling better. Definitely not because she couldn’t resist kissing her every chance she got. Totally just for Adora.

“I know you’re gonna go home and make like five binders to plan everything out but…you can talk to me about stuff…I have ideas too.”

“I was thinking seven binders…” The excited smile Adora gave her would have made her weak at the knees if she had been standing. Instead it reminded her how much she loved Adora.

Even if she was going to over-plan every detail of the wedding before either one of them actually proposed.

Even if she ate three pieces of cake in less than a minute and then spiraled into anxiety.

And even if she almost burnt down their apartment. Again.

Because Adora was everything that Catra loved and would always love.

Opening Day

Chapter Summary

Catra opens up her very own coffee shop

Chapter Notes

Ooff. I had a horrible time trying to write this so apologies in advance if it comes off...boring. Hoping the second part comes out much better!

"Four in the god damn morning. Why am I doing this again? Oh yeah cause I *love* torturing myself" she muttered under her breath.

The sky above still an inky black as she walked the silent streets. The street lampposts blotting out most of the stars in the early morning darkness.

Her nerves had kept her from getting much sleep last night. Just tossing and turning next to a fast-asleep Adora and snoring Melog, which had only served to make her more anxious and stressed about today.

She stopped in front of the building.

It felt like it had taken a lifetime to get here and now in this instant everything was rushed and hectic. Catra stood in front of the doors to Eternia, her hand hesitating an inch away from the lock.

Was she really doing this? Was she ready?

A polite cough from behind her distracted her from her thoughts.

A very tired looking Adora stood there holding Melog patiently. The smile on her face reminded Catra of the first time she opened

the doors after finding out her girlfriend and friends had paid the down payment on the building.

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"Lot bigger than I remembered" Catra said as she walked in with Bow, Glimmer, and Adora following closely behind.

"That's what she said" Glimmer snickered as she elbowed Bow in the ribs. He gave a snort and wandered off to look around.

The old building turned shop had been vacant for several months judging by the dust coating every surface. Light bled through newspaper covered windows illuminating the worn hardwood floors and red brick walls. Occasional structural pillars dotted the otherwise empty rectangular main room. The only other modifications to the first floor were a small back office, a door for the stairs to the second floor, and two bathrooms. Catra let her mind wander as she imagined her ideas for the shop. Cozy armchairs in the corners for quiet conversations, a large coffee bar with kitchen area in the back, tables spread throughout for people to work on projects or just hang out. She'd have to pay quite a bit to get an electrician and plumber to get more outlets around the whole room and water hookups for the bar area, but it would be worth it.

Adora came over and wrapped an arm around her waist. "So whatda ya think?"

"It's perfect" she whispered before turning to kiss her. How could she ever convey how grateful she was? This gift was everything she wanted and more than she could have ever expected from anyone.

Bow and Glimmer popped up out of nowhere and joined in on the embrace. "Catra's first coffee shop. Catra's first coffee shop" they chanted in unison and spun her around in a circle. She growled and snuck out of their arms as Adora laughed and smiled. A look in those eyes challenging her to admit that she actually did like

the attention. She rolled her eyes and walked off to the back, a small smile betraying her feigned distaste.

The stairs to the second floor creaked as they made their way up and into the biggest apartment Catra had seen since moving to Brightmoon.

"Can we live here? Dibs on the bigger room!" Glimmer called as she ran off to look at the bedrooms.

The stairs had led up into a large living room area with a balcony that hung over the back of the building with outdoor stairs for entry to the apartment. One bedroom was directly off the living area to the right while the other appeared to be off the kitchen and dining area in the front of the building. A large bay window to the side of the open design kitchen let light flood into the room. The kitchen was surprisingly up to date with stainless steel appliances, a gas stove, and an island with marble countertop. Catra made her way to the front bedroom to find a matching bay window and immediately went up to sit in it and peer out over the street. Living here did seem like a good idea.

Adora came up behind her and wrapped her arms around her, resting her chin on Catra's head. "You know…our lease is up in a few months."

"That is true. Andddd it would probably be cheaper than our current place since I own the building and all." She stretched her chin up to kiss Adora. Her hands pulling Adora down to sit between her legs in the windowsill. All of this still felt like a dream and if it was she might as well make the best of it. Their lips and hands became more insistent as they got lost in the moment. Her hand reached under the hem of Adora's shirt as claws traced bare skin. A small gasp at the touch and then shuffling to get closer, to get more contact.

Glimmer made a disgusted sound from the doorway. "Get a room geeze."

Catra pulled away from a blushing Adora to glare at Glimmer. "We're literally in a room. Besides I own the place so I can do what I want." She smirked at Adora and wiggled her eyebrows. "Or who I want to be more specific." The embarrassed blush and laugh from Adora and groan from Glimmer were exactly what she wanted. She doubled down on that embarrassed/disgusted energy by pulling Adora in for a rough kiss. Glimmer accepted her defeat with a groan and walked off to go make out with Bow or whatever. Adora smiled into her lips and gave her a gentle shove as she got up.

"Let's go see the rest of your building dummy." Adora turned her back to Catra which she took as an invitation to hop up on her back to be carried around. Adora laughed before grabbing her legs and holding her tightly.

…

Catra opened the doors to Eternia and flicked the lights on. They had spent months getting the building up to code, painting and decorating, and bringing in furniture and supplies. She had called in pretty much every favor she had from everyone she knew in town to help along the way. Many people had just offered to help though without her even asking. Entrapta had enthusiastically offered to wire the building, which she promptly refused, but she did end up helping setup a security system and speakers that seemed much less of a fire risk.

Even the name, Eternia, had been a gift from Adora. A made-up word that somehow felt right the second it passed her lips. She still couldn't believe how Adora had given so much already for this shop. She had been her usual annoying self-sacrificing self and had spent nearly every minute of her free time helping with projects. Even when Catra would send her home to get rest, because damn did Adora look as exhausted as Catra felt, she kept showing up. Kept pushing herself for Catra. The combination of guilt and gratitude that Catra felt only further muddling the mix of emotions in her mind. As much as this had been Catra's dream she knew she couldn't have done it without Adora. They'd even

spent their anniversary at the shop hanging up artwork before building a blanket fort in the middle of the floor and spending the night there. Catra had woken up so stiff she could barely move but watching movies in the fort and staying up all night whispering secrets while drinking hot cocoa had been one of her favorite dates.

Looking over the now furnished floor, she couldn't help but feel a burst of pride. She had wanted to make Eternia for everyone. This was not some corporate shop that only cared one month a year and spent the rest of the time treating employees like shit. She wanted it to scream inclusivity so loud that it shoved it down the throats of anyone that disagreed. If anyone had a problem with her hanging a POC pride flag over her front door then they weren't welcome anyways. She had poured over articles looking for accessibility options that she could incorporate. The eclectic mismatched tables and chairs offered a variety of heights that would accommodate wheelchair users while the in-house mugs came in all shapes and sizes with varying handle types. She had printed out menus in a variety of languages with pictures and even installed a room for nursing or just parents that needed to help their kids calm down in a quiet space. She may not have been a big fan of all those moms and their strollers stacked full of kids, but she wasn't ashamed to take their money.

Today was finally the day to see if all that hard work paid off. She needed this to work. Every cent she had earned from the lawsuit had been poured into this. She'd even accepted some of Adora's winnings from the race after she found out the rusty water pipes had to be replaced in the bathrooms and Adora had practically begged her to take the money for the hundredth time.

This was more than just about money though. This was about pride, about proving to herself and everyone else that she could do this and not be a failure.

But as badly as she wanted to believe that she could do this…

Doubts always came crawling out from the shadows. Whispers of failure always lurking in the corners of her mind grew louder with each second she stood in the all too quiet shop.

Spite as an energy source was what had gotten her through college and most of the shitty times after that but gnawing anxiety and crippling self-doubt, she could thank Shadow for both of those, were always there wearing her down. Spite didn't seem like it was going to cut it today though as the fear of all the people counting on her and trusting in her felt like an enormous weight on her shoulders. And having a mental break down in the back office on the first day really wasn't the ideal way to start a business.

Catra stood just inside the doorway rubbing the back of her neck. Adora let go of Melog who ran off to a front windowsill and laid down for a nap as the door closed behind them.

"I'm gonna do some last-minute checks so if you wanna nap go ahead" she said staring down at the floor.

"Hey Catra" Adora said softly, a hand pulling Catra's chin up to force her to make eye contact. Ocean blue eyes pierced into her. Demanding… No, Adora never *demanded*. Her eyes, so full of sincerity and compassion, *asked* that she let Adora in.

A weak laugh before a weak and faltering "Hey Adora" passed her lips.

Catra's shoulders slumped forward as she let her head lean on Adora's collarbone. Strong arms wrapping her up and forcing her feet closer so their bodies could press tightly together. The smell of her shampoo mixing with the smell of coffee around them. She took a deep breath in, focusing on Adora. A soft purr escaping her throat besides her best efforts to contain it.

"I believe in you. And I'm right here with you Catra."

"Promise?"

“I promise.”

She let Adora’s words rattle around her head until they start to stick. Until she’s forced to admit to herself that she might actually pull this off. That she might *actually* be good at this if she just tried. And Adora would be there, being overly supportive and encouraging and obnoxious in all the right ways.

So what if she didn’t have spite today. She had a tall, muscular, stupidly beautiful girlfriend that believed in her.

And if things didn’t work she’d just leave that same tall, muscular, stupidly beautiful girlfriend alone in the kitchen and collect the insurance money from the inevitable fire.

…

Catra set to work as Adora laid down on a couch near the front window. She watched as Melog hopped down from their resting spot to curl up on her chest and it made Catra’s heart flutter. This was no time to be soft and stare wistfully at her girlfriend like this was some romantic novel. She walked back to the kitchen and turned the lights on. Catra had checked over everything yesterday but it calmed her nerves to check again. All the food and supplies were ready and organized, the grinder dosed correctly, and the espresso machine working perfectly. She moved a few items from the fridge to the display case, Lance’s tiramisu sat front and center.

Right on time Scorpia showed up with Lonnie following behind. She would have never asked them to quit Horders and take a chance with her shop but they both had in a heartbeat. She figured Lonnie was mostly following Scorpia, but she’d take all the help she could get. She hushed them as they walked past the still sleeping Adora and headed to the back.

“Wildcat I’m just so proud of you. Oh my gosh. This is just so exciting” she said in the loudest whisper possible as she put a beefy arm around Catra and Lonnie and squeeze them together.

Lonnie grunted and gave her a nod. “Yeah. Gotta say even I’m impressed Catra.”

“Coming from you that’s almost a compliment.” She took a deep breath. “Thank you…both. I-I couldn’t do this without you.”

She set Scorpia and Lonnie to finish prepping everything for what she hoped would be a busy morning before going to make Adora a drink. An espresso con panna with caramel drizzle just like when they first met. Made with a gross amount of love and way too much whip cream.

Catra walked over to the sleeping duo and placed the drink on the table before leaning down to kiss Adora’s cheek. It had been tempting to be mean and wake her up with whip cream to the face, but she was feeling nice today. Adora stirred slowly, angering Melog who went back to their windowsill post.

“Here. You get the honors of the first official drink or whatever.”

“Aww” Adora said with stars in her eyes and way too sappy of a look for this early in the morning.

She finished the drink in record speed with only a small amount of whip cream on her face. Catra gave a mischievous grin before leaning over to kiss the whip cream off her face.

Adora raised an eyebrow and gave her best shit-eating grin. “You treat all your customers like this?”

“Only the cute blonde ones” she replied with a wink. “Besides you didn’t pay so you owe me.”

“Is that so?” Adora’s grin getting wider as she pulled Catra in for another kiss. The bitter espresso on her lips mixing with the sweetness of the moment. Catra wanted to melt into the moment and forget about everything.

Unfortunately, it was at that moment that a giant bouquet of flowers burst through the doors and levitated a few steps further.

Catra groaned at being disturbed before noticing the comically large bouquet. She stood up next to the couch unsure if she should help.

"…Perfuma?"

"Oh! Hello Catra! Yes I've brought flowers as Scorpia had requested. I thought it would be a lovely way to enhance the positive energy of today" came a voice from behind the bouquet. Perfuma finally set it down on a table before running over to Scorpia to give her a kiss.

"You didn't have to do that." The words came out harsher than she wanted as she nervously stroked the back of her neck. There was a limit to the number of nice things her friends could do before it became way too much.

Adora stood next to her and wrapped a hand around her waist. Clearing her throat, she spoke in a weird voice that Catra could only assume was meant to sound formal and intelligent. "I'm still learning how to speak Catra, but I think that means-" Her tone going flat and monotone as if reading from a cue card "- 'Thank you. That was very nice of you'."

Catra snorted. "Yeah yeah. Close enough."

Scorpia and Perfuma set to dividing the flowers into small vases that they placed on the tables around the shop and near the register. Catra went outside to place the sandwich board sign that she had let Bow decorate for today. 'ETERNIA: Best Coffee in Brightmoon', 'Grand Opening!', 'Cute Cat Inside!' and then a ton of little doodles of all of their friends and animated coffees finished off the sign. And rainbows because of course Bow had put rainbows all over her sign.

She had just gone back in and flipped the sign that Bow and Glimmer had got her to 'Open' when they showed up yawning and looking exhausted.

“Well look what the cat dragged in” she said as she leaned in the doorway.

“Too early for snark. Need. Coffee. Now” Glimmer responded while heavily leaning on Bow who looked like he might topple over any second.

“Fair. Come in before you collapse out there and scare the real customers away.”

Catra set herself to making drinks for everyone there. It was the least she could do really after everything they had done to make today possible. Within an hour of the shop opening there were a few actual customers that popped in and she let Lonnie take over the register while she handled keeping the bar stocked and washing dishes in the back. Her little team seemed to be handling things well while Bow, Glimmer, and Adora lounged in a corner.

She had prepared for a really slow morning but was surprised with a slow trickle of customers that picked up around lunch time. Bow, Glimmer, and Perfuma had left with the promise of returning that night for the grand opening party and Catra gave up trying to convince Adora to go home and sleep after the fourth try and let her nap in the corner. Melog on the other hand had somehow managed to find the energy to stay awake and worked on charming everyone that walked by. They rotated between lounging in the sun of the front window to sitting at the register and meowing loudly at customers to taking short naps with Adora. The little dumpster cat really did know how to work a crowd.

By mid-afternoon she was sending silent prayers to Lance for giving her the tiramisu recipe as she sold piece after piece. It had taken her a few tries at home, Adora gladly eating the failures, before she got the texture and ratio perfect, but the batch she made today was a near imitation of the original. By the evening they had sold out of the tiramisu and several other baked goods, she had a secret stash for the party later, and she was going to buy Lance so many socks and sandals if business kept up like this.

It surprised her the number of people that she knew that showed up to congratulate her. Huntara and her wife stopped by for a drink and stayed to talk to Adora for a while. Spinerella and Netossa came in and made googly eyes at each other and brought a general level of sappiness that sickened Catra for an hour. Kyle and Rogelio snuck in before their shift at Horders to "sample the competition" and ended up ordering a second set of drinks to go. Entrapta came in and requested the tiniest baked good so loudly that other patrons jumped. She took a few mini espresso macarons, Catra may have specifically made them mini for her but she'd never admit that and left with the promise that she'd be back shortly for the party. She was mumbling something about 'nepetalactone behavioral experiments on feline humanoid specimen' into her tape recorder as she walked out. Scorpia looked disconcerted about that while Catra just shrugged. She *almost* missed hearing Entrapta talking to herself down the apartment hallway in her science mumbo jumbo terminology that Catra could barely understand.

The final customers left as the shop officially closed for the evening and Catra let out a sigh of relief. Everyone but Adora had left to go home before the party and before she could even turn around, muscular arms were hugging her tightly.

She twisted around in the embrace and pressed her forehead to Adora's. "You did great today Catra."

"Yeah well I had a lot of help."

Catra felt herself smiling with a genuine feeling of happiness and pride. Adora kissed her forehead as a hand dropped down to hold hers.

"Is that Catra for 'Wow Adora you are the best and I love you so much'?"

"Don't push your luck dork." She smiled and rolled her eyes before kissing Adora's cheek.

Now she just had to survive a giant party with everyone she knew in the city without snapping at anyone.

No big deal right?

Party Time

Chapter Summary

> The grand opening party.
> CW: semi-involuntary drug use (it's just catnip though"

Chapter Notes

> Hey! I'm back! This took a lot longer than I expected to write (plan on that for the next one too probably) but it's also way longer than my usual chapters so evens out sort of? maybe? I've got a sort of beta now! And by that I mean I tricked my best buddy into pre-reading this for me :) Thanks Tony!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra growled as Adora tried to shift to a more comfortable position, her right arm had gone numb a while ago and the needlelike painful sensation was getting overwhelming.

With only a two-hour break between the shop closing and the party beginning they really didn't have time to go home and let Catra have an actual break so they opted for a couch cuddle. There were still decorations to put up and food to prepare. But now, trying to glance down at her exhausted girlfriend without moving she wished she had forced her to go home and sleep. The bags under her eyes and the irritable mood were sure to get much worse before the end of the night, which meant Adora would have to work extra hard to make sure she had a good time tonight.

"Catra" she whispered into the half-asleep girl's hair. She placed a kiss to the top of her head. "I know you're awake."

A groan and angry tail twitch. "Five more minutes" Catra mumbled from where her face was nested into Adora's numb and tingling shoulder.

She let out a small snort before trying to adjust again.

Another growl.

"You're such a brat."

Catra lifted her head just enough to stick her tongue out and glare at Adora before letting her head flop back down *hard* against Adora's chest. Melog stared at her from the back of the couch, tail twitching out of annoyance for waking them up.

Completely surrounded by brats.

…

Fifteen minutes later and Adora gave up on trying to be nice and wake her girlfriend up with gentle encouragements. "You only have yourself to blame for this." She sat up on the couch as Catra tried to scrabble and find purchase on her letting out a frightened squeak. Adora ignored the claws digging into her skin as she picked her up and carried her over to the bar, setting her butt gently on the counter. "You have one minute to show me how to make you an espresso shot or I'm going to start pushing buttons and levers until I figure it out."

"You wouldn't dare." Catra's eyes glared defiantly but she made no movement to stop her. Adora held her gaze before smugly raising her chin and walking over to the machine.

She made it three and a half steps before Catra launched off the counter and onto her back forcing her to spin and fall hard onto the floor, the rubber mats thankfully cushioning the blow. Laying on her back she raised up onto her elbows to look at Catra straddling her and trying to look coy. "We really should stop meeting like this."

Adora rolled her eyes before pushing her backwards, the unexpected force causing her to land on her butt with a *thump*.

“Like I said before. Such a brat. But a very cute one.” Adora put her hand out to help Catra up before yanking her hard to pull her in close for a kiss. The flustered look on Catra’s face making her smile. “Now are you gonna show me how to use this thing?”

Bolstered by more caffeine, Catra set to work getting ready for the party while Adora grabbed supplies they had stored in the empty upstairs apartment. She had just finished moving tables and chairs for the impromptu stage area when Bow and Glimmer came back with loaded arms full of decorations and random party supplies. She left Bow to figure out how to set up the karaoke machine while she helped Adora and Glimmer set up rainbow fairy lights and streamers until it looked like a pride float puked on the shop.

Glimmer was digging around in a bag of supplies and she squealed excitedly as she pulled out a tube of glitter. Before Catra even fully realized what she was doing she grabbed her wrist firmly and pulled the tube from her. “If you get so much as one speck of glitter in here I will *end* you Sparkles.” Glimmer opened her mouth to argue but seemed to think better of it. She let out an indignant huff, ripped her hand from Catra’s grasp, and walked off. It was...suspicious but she’d have to worry about it later because Perfuma and Scorpia walked in carrying even more flowers.

“Where are we even going to put all of these??” Catra squeaked. Every table still had flowers from this morning and now there were two more gigantic bouquets to deal with.

“Do you...do you not like my flowers Catra?” Perfuma looked as if she was about to cry. Shit shit shit.

“No I'm sure Catra loves them right? Don't you Wildcat?” Scorpia asked as she tried to comfort Perfuma.

“Yes. They’re...great. Sorry. I’m sure they’ll boost the positivity or whatever.”

Perfuma sniffled a few times before giving a weak smile. " I thought I could make flower crowns for everyone."

"ME ME ME! Oh please." Bow was jumping up and down, practically screaming.

With the crying crisis averted Catra set back to getting a food area set up while Perfuma and Bow made dumb flower crowns.

"Woww...yeah decorating is not your strong suit." Mermista and Seahawk had showed up holding a sushi platter. Catra took the food from them and brought it over to the tables she had set up.

"Sorry we're like late. Someone-" she said glaring at Sea Hawk, "decided he wanted to wax his mustache." At that Sea Hawk posed, one hand stroking his perfectly manicured facial hair. Bow appeared out of nowhere with an oversized flower crown on his head and fawned over him.

"At least someone appreciates me…Oh Bow. I'm so glad you're here. Have I told you the story of how I took out an entire army of men that tried to rob Salineas? No? Well it was a night like any other-" Sea Hawk had wrapped an arm around Bow and was leading him off to a corner, thankfully far away from Catra.

"So Sea Hawk's your plus one?" Adora asked with a smug smile.

"Ughhhh no he's just my ride. It's not like I was going to walk all the way over here or whatever."

"We're like two block from Salineas…"

"Yeah well you try listening to Sea Hawk for two blocks."

"Fair point" Catra added.

"Ugh I know right? Do you have any ice cream?"

"Back kitchen. Help yourself" Catra said as she walked off to finish bringing food out.

…

By the time the party was set to start there were more people than Catra had expected and plenty of them she swore she didn't even know.

George and Lance showed up being pulled behind an over-excited Bow. "Dads, you have to try Catra's tiramisu." He was thrusting plates of cakes into their hands with stars in his eyes. "Didn't see do great?"

George took a bite and gave an approving nod while Lance set his piece down so he could hug Catra. "You did great. We're so proud of you!"

Catra froze in the embrace. "Um thanks. I followed the recipe you gave me."

Lance finally let go. "Oh! I almost forgot." He ran over and started rummaging around in a shoulder bag George was carrying for him. "Here's the photo of baby Bow that you asked for. Wasn't he so precious?"

Catra snatched the photo, gave a quick thank you, and was running to the back before Bow could figure out what happened. She rushed past a confused Adora and straight to Glimmer who nearly did a spit take when she saw the photo of little naked baby Bow in the bathtub. "Here. I don't know why you needed this or why you couldn't ask for yourself. Don't wanna know. But you owe me Sparkles." And with that she walked off. Maybe she'd get a chance to enjoy the party. A glance over to Sea Hawk who was lighting candles with a-IS THAT A POCKET TORCH? Before she could scream at him Mermista was there throwing a cup of water on him.

"I *said* no Flaming Boat" Mermista said to a very sad, very wet Sea Hawk, torch still in hand. She took the torch from him and walked off with a groan. For a few seconds it looked as if Sea Hawk might cry, which would definitely make Catra's night, but

instead he took a deep breath, puffing himself up, before doing a hair flip. Water droplets flung off him in slow motion as the twinkling lights behind him made him sparkle like a god damn cologne ad. Catra tried to suppress the urge to gag while Bow (*again appearing out of nowhere, seriously how was he doing that?)* looked like he might faint from excitement.

With one crisis averted Catra braced for the next and as if on cue, Double Trouble walked in.

"Double Trouble. Glad you could *finally* make it" Catra said with a hand on a cocked hip, eyebrow raised.

"You can't rush perfection *kitten*." They bowed before spinning in a circle so Catra could appreciate their outfit. A sleek dark olive-green suit coat with knee length matching skirt and ankle length black heeled boots.

"Thanks for show up though. Wouldn't be a party without you."

Double Trouble gave a signature ravenous smile before leaning forward and poking a finger to her nose. "Always glad to put on a show for my fans darling." Their hand delicately tracing over Catra's shoulder as they circled her. She couldn't help the chill that ran down her spine. "As much as I'd love to stay and…*chat-"* Double Trouble has always had found a way to put her on edge, to get into her head. "-I would be remiss to ignore my fans." Before she could say anything though the hand was gone and Double Trouble was sauntering off to say hello to others.

Catra let out a breath she didn't realize she was holding.

Adora had never realized just how many people they knew in town. It seemed like everyone she had met in the past couple years was here and still more people coming in. She had been hiding in the corner for half an hour now, nursing a drink, until she spotted Huntara and her wife at a table nearby.

“Hey kid, have a seat” she gestured to the seat next to her before clapping Adora on the back so hard she had to brace against the table to keep from falling, her drink spilling slightly. “Quite the party you guys are having. Gotta say I’m impressed with what Catra’s done here.”

Adora smiled as if the compliment had been for her. “Yeah she’s really great…I mean…she *did* great. At this. The shop.” She let out a sigh. Huntara let out a deep belly laugh and slammed a hand on her shoulder, squeezing just a little too hard to be comforting. “It’s okay kid. To be proud of your fiancée.”

“Oh uh n-no. Not fiancée. Not yet at least. Well. We’re waiting because Catra wanted to open the shop first and she’s stressed about it…It’s complicated.”

“Sounds pretty *not* complicated. Like you’re just waiting for the right time.” Adora looked up at Huntara’s wife. She was never one to say much when she stopped into the Crimson Waste but seemed friendly enough.

“Yeah. Yeah I guess you’re right” Adora said with a smile.

They were just waiting for the right moment, weren’t they? Not avoiding the situation? She had felt sure before but now she wasn’t so sure. The small bubble of doubt edging up to the surface, threatening to pop.

It was time for the part of the night that Catra had been least looking forward to. Dreading honestly. Sea Hawk was making his way to the karaoke machine and she snatched the microphone away from him before he could start in on what would surely be the most annoying shanty-like song he could find in the playlist.

“Umm hi everyone” The entire crowd went silent and turned to face her, the only sound in the room was the slight feedback from the microphone. She could feel her hands starting to sweat. “I just wanted to take a second to say thank you. To everyone here.

This shop has been a dream of mine for a long time, but I couldn't have done it without the help of all my friends here. I don't want to make this some big dumb speech but yeah. Thanks everyone. Umm Enjoy the rest of the night."

People clapped and cheered as she handed off the microphone to Double Trouble. "Whatever you do, don't let Sea Hawk sing" she whispered as she walked off.

Double Trouble took only a few seconds to find the song they wanted, of course they knew exactly what song to perform. Catra could hear the smooth bass line, the soft baritone of Ike Turner singing backup, and an anxious laugh burst from her chest. She didn't even have to look over to know Double Trouble was about to put on one hell of a performance of Proud Mary.

Left a good job in the city

Working for the man every night and day

And I never lost one minute of sleeping

Worrying 'bout the way that things might have been

The crowd's excitement was nearly palpable as Double Trouble's voice drawled on. Catra spotted Adora in the crowd and watched her. The mesmerizing way the light filtered across her hair, her lips. Catra wanted t o drink in the image, memorize this moment. She worked her way through the crowd, slipping up next to Adora and sliding her hand into hers. A slight jump at the surprise in contact and then Adora beamed at her for a second, more than long enough to make Catra's heart flutter, before turning back to the performance.

Big wheel keep on turning

Proud Mary keep on burning

And we're rolling, rolling

Rolling on the river

Catra heard the pause in the song and watched a devious smile as Double Trouble grabbed the collar of their shirt and yanked the entire outfit off with grace and poise that shouldn't have been possible, revealing a sleeveless black and emerald green catsuit, cut outs on the abdomen showing off their soft green skin. The crowd burst out in applause as the lyrics of the first verse repeated but now with energy and excitement. Double Trouble *worked* the crowd, dancing and singing and making it impossible for anyone else to have a better performance than them tonight.

When the song finally ended, Double Trouble received a flower crown from Perfuma, and bowed for nearly a full minute before they finally left the karaoke station. Catra was about to ask Adora how she was doing when she was abruptly yanked backwards. She let out a squeak as she tried to wrestle her wrist away from the strong grasp but to no avail. A few feet away they grabbed her by the shoulder and spun her around. A very exasperated Catra being turned to face an overly excited Entrapta, tiny macarons bulging out of every pocket on her overalls.

"Catra! I've been looking for you everywhere. Well I was until I found out there was tiny food! Did you know there was tiny food? Yes, of course I suppose you did since this is your party!"

Catra stared blankly at her instead of responding.

Several silent seconds passed of Entrapta staring at her holding cookies in her hands.

"Right! I almost forgot. I've been experimenting on a concentrated nepetalactone formula that I've distilled from Nepeta *cataria*-"

“Entrapta. English. *Please.*”

She pulled a small spray bottle out of one of the pockets of her outfit, macarons falling to the floor, before speaking slowly and only a tiny bit condescendingly. “I took catnip and made it into a spray.”

“Congratulations. Why should I care?” Catra’s tone was encroaching quickly on angry and aggressive but Entrapta had pulled her away from Adora to tell her about some dumb catnip perfume and she wanted to get back to the party.

“I thought I could test it on you. You know since you’re a feline hybrid. It’s shown very promising results on small felines such as house cats and also larger jungle cats. Did you know you can be banned from the zoo?”

Catra smacked her hand against her face and groaned. “If I say yes will you leave me alone?”

“Well I would need to document the effects of the chemical compound on your system. I have my portable EKG machine in the backroom-”

“No machines but you can watch for one minute or whatever. As long as I can get back to the party.”

Entrapta gave a signature excited squeak and without any further warning sprayed it directly into Catra’s face. She closed her eyes and flinched. Bracing in case she exploded or something. Entrapta’s experiments had been known to range from volatile to doing absolutely nothing.

A few seconds passed.

Good. It seemed like absolutely nothing was the results for today’s harassment and she could get back to doing important things like stare at Adora.

"I think your dumb perfume is a-" Catra didn't finish her sentence because everything was *really gooood.* And spinning?

"Experiment 69…70? No definetly 69-"

Catra snorted. "Ha 69. Nice."

"-Subject seems to have had an immediate reaction. Pupils are fully dilated, respiration appears quicker, slight flushing of the facial epidermis. Demeanor appears to be more relaxed than their standard aggressive attitude. Previous experiments have shown an effect window of approximately ten minutes. Further research required to determine proper dosage."

Catra felt great. Like really great. The room spinning was a little annoying but who cares. Not her.

Wait. Had she been doing something?

Double Trouble had been singing and looking pretty. She had been watching the show and standing by Adora-

Adora. Shit she had to go find her and tell her something. Entrapta was still rambling into her tape recorder and being weird as usual but Catra had a mission. Find Adora. *Kiss* Adora. Tell Adora how pretty she was, and how happy she was to date her, and how she was gonna marry her and…

There she was. Standing talking to Bow and Glimmer (*they're kinda cute…for like big dumb nerds*) and looking like the prettiest girl in the entire world. Catra sauntered up behind Adora.

"Heyyyyyyyy Adoraaaaa"

A shiver ran up her spine before she realized how oddly Catra had said her usual greeting that always managed to get under her skin in the best way. Was Catra slurring her words? Adora turned her head at the weird sounding greeting to see a very relaxed Catra. So relaxed she slumped onto Adora's shoulder and looked to be

melting slowly into the floor. Adora wrapped an arm around her waist to steady her girlfriend and gave her a curious smile. "Having a good time Catra?"

"Oh just a *blast*. Shit. I almost forgot. Come here. I gotta tell you something" Catra whispered and tried to pull at Adora's neck to bring her closer. Her eyes as big as saucers looked frantic and desperate as she tried to scramble up Adora's body like a manic kitten. Bow and Glimmer's snickers were not helping Adora's slight panic at seeing Catra act so weird. She had just started to calm down over the anxiety of the proposal talk earlier and now this…

"Oh yeah?" Adora leaned in closer. Catra responded in the loudest stage whisper possible. "I just love you sooooo much. And I think you're *very* sexy and I'm gonna marry you soo hard."

Bow and Glimmer's snickers were full on cackles now and Adora was struggling to keep herself from losing it. She bit her bottom lip to keep from laughing and finally took a good look at Catra. Her eyes were dilated wider than when she watched birds out the window. She wasn't sure what happened, but she was high as a kite and probably going to say something she would regret tomorrow.

"Psssssst hey. Hey Arrow boy and Glitter or whatever your name is. Did you-did you know that Adora is like a robot? It's true. She's got like cyborg legs and-and a telepathic brain chip thingy."

Adora couldn't even make sense of that last one. She was a robot? "Hey how bout we go get you some water? Maybe get some fresh air out back?"

"You just wanna get me outside so we can make a baby."

Glimmer was bent over trying to choke in breaths between laughs and Adora couldn't contain her laughter anymore. "Yep babe. Let's go make a baby." She turned to Bow, wiping tears from his eyes. "We'll be back… keep an eye on things please?"

Adora hoisted the floppy girl over her shoulder, grabbed a cup of water on the way, and carried her out the back door. She set her down on top of some pallets and leaned her gently back against the brick wall. Catra's tail flopped a few times before weakly curling around her wrist. "Ready for some water?"

"No! I hate water" Catra tensed, claws coming out, tail poofing up and ears darting back. Her eyes shifted back and forth frantically as if searching for water that would come flying out of the dark and quiet space. Adora placed a hand on her shoulder and held her in place.

"To drink you dummy" she said as she tried to hand her the cup. Catra sighed and relaxed before letting her head flop back against the wall. Good thing she's cute. Adora rolled her eyes and held Catra's neck to pour a little water into her mouth. She watched a drop trickle down the side of her mouth, rolling down her chin before it slid down her neck beneath her shirt. Adora swallowed hard as she felt heat pooling deep in her. Shaking her head, she tried to focus again.

"You gonna tell me how you got so…floppy?" As if in response, Catra laughed and started to tip over and nearly fell off the pallet before Adora could grab her and pin her to the wall.

"Wow you're strong" Catra said as her hands ran up Adora's arms, squeezing her biceps. Any other time Adora would bask in the way Catra admired her muscles, but she was too nervous. Too worried about taking advantage of her. Adora placed a hand to the side of Catra's face to look in her eyes. Mismatched eyes looking back fondly before continuing. "Pfft I feel great. Entrapta sprayed me with some stuff…really good stuff."

Now that was…concerning. Why would Entrapta spray her with something? Whatever it was, she clearly couldn't be left on her own. "You're not making sense Catra. What did she spray you with?"

Catra flopped forward to press her face into Adora's abdomen, nuzzling against her chest and purring. The gentle vibrations doing nothing to help distract from her longing. Catra started to incoherently mumble into her chest until she pulled her back enough to hear her clearly. "-then she said some big words. Nepac- Napta- Nekko- Catnip! That's the stuff." Adora let her head flop back to her chest and breathed a sign of relief. Catnip spray. She could deal with that. She placed a kiss to the top of her head before picking her up and carrying her back inside.

The second Adora walked back in she was met by a bombardment of questions.

"Is she dead?"

"Is she gonna be alright?"

"Adora! Can you document every side effect she's had for the last several minutes?"

"Is there like any more snacks? Sea Hawk ate all the chips and all that's left is Perfuma's party kale."

There was too much to focus on and she was still carrying her very messed up girlfriend. She could feel her brain short circuiting as she tried to figure out what to respond to first. Catra shifted in her arms to look up at her, a vulnerability in her eyes normally reserved for Adora alone. "Adora…I want to go home."

She ignored all the questions, her attention focused entirely on Catra as she walked over to the couch. Catra's eyes were barely open, fighting off exhaustion. Her weak frame felt terribly light in Adora's arms.

"Come on Catra. You're not done yet. We're going home…soon but you have to stay awake for a little longer."

"Ugh fine. But you owe me." The effects of the spray seemed to be almost worn off, but she looked even more exhausted than before.

Adora let out an indignant snort. “I just took care of you. Even after you called me a telepathic robot.”

Catra’s eyes went wide and a blush spread across her face. “I said that? Out loud?” Her voice barely a whisper. So clearly the spray did more than just make her a loopy flirty mess. It messed with her memory too? As much as she didn’t want to make Catra freak out, she couldn’t resist teasing her at least a little bit.

“You said *a lot* of things.” Adora gave her a smug look, a quick wink, and then disappeared back into the party. Catra wasn’t the only one who could be a brat.

The party had been dying down for a while but Sea Hawk singing a second karaoke shanty put the final nail in the coffin of the evening. A few people offered to stay and clean up and they did their best to make the shop presentable for opening tomorrow, but there were still streamers and other decorations around that would have to be taken care of eventually.

Adora grabbed Melog who had been contently sleeping in the back office away from the party and went outside to wait for Catra to finish locking up. The quiet walk back home let the anxieties from before start to surface again.

“Soooo… good party tonight huh?” Wow that came out even dumber sounding than it had in her head. Adora knew she had many good qualities, but small talk. Not one of them. At all.

Catra gave her a dubious glance before looking back to the sidewalk in front of her. “Yeah. I *loved* being drugged by my friend and listening to Sea Hawk sing.”

Adora winced. Yeah. Maybe it hadn’t been the best party from Catra’s perspective. “It wasn’t all bad though right? Everyone seemed to like the shop a lot.”

“Yeah that’s true.” Melog let out a quiet meow in Adora’s arms.

The conversation died off as they walked the rest of the way in silence. That uncomfortable feeling still lingering as Adora finished getting ready for bed first and laid down. Catra face planted into the bed and laid there a moment before getting under the covers, facing away from Adora. Had she done something wrong? Catra had seemed off but she had chalked it up to being tired. But now she wasn't even cuddling.

"I can practically hear your anxiety Adora" Catra said before turning around to lay facing her.

"Who? Me? Anxious? Pfft never." The little joke enough to make Catra give a tired smile. Moonlight filtering through the curtains made her freckled skin look so beautiful. Catra shifted even closer, their noses almost touching, before poking a finger to her forehead.

"What's up in that big dumb brain of yours?"

Adora sighed and shifted her eyes away from Catra's down to their hands. She traced her fingers across Catra's knuckles before lacing their hands together. "I just…wanna make sure we're good…I know the shop is a lot and if you don't want to get married now. Or I mean ever that's like totally fine. Totally cool. With me. Yep."

Catra lightly bumped her head against Adora's. "Of course I want to marry you dummy. Thought that was the plan?"

Adora physically sagged with relief. "Yeah. I just got in my head about it."

"Well…don't do that."

Before she could roll her eyes Catra leaned forward and kissed her. Any remaining anxiety floated away at the gentle touch of her lips; their hands still entwined between them. Catra broke off the kiss and nestled into her side, clearly too exhausted for anything more. Adora took a deep breath in and pulled Catra even closer. "Good night Catra."

“Night Adora.” Her fears assuaged, Adora drifted peacefully to sleep as she dreamed of binders and color boards.

Chapter End Notes

I'm back! This took a lot longer than I expected to write (plan on that for the next one too probably) but it's also way longer than my usual chapters so evens out sort of? maybe?
Anyways a big thank you to S1 who gave me the catnip idea. And a thank you as always to everyone who's commented and kudo'd. Y'all are great :)
I'm thinking that I'll be ending this at the proposal but could probably be convinced to write a wedding scene if people are interested.
Finally, I am shamelessly stealing/referencing John Krasinski's performance of Proud Mary on Lip Sync Battles for the karaoke bit.

Willows and Waterfalls

Chapter Summary

> Catra's finally ready to pop the question but can she find the right moment?

Chapter Notes

> I FINALLY FINISHED! this is a beast of chapter so apologies that it took me much longer than I anticipated to write it/ get motivation. It's a lot of fluff. You've been warned!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Five months

Catra had let her hair grow long again in the many months since she had met Adora. It would have been back to its usual tangled mess except a certain girl loved to brush her hair. And Catra was a sucker who would do anything for her. A messy ponytail had become her signature look, partially because she liked when Adora snuck in to give her kisses on her neck, and partially because she looked hot like that.

But right now she was focused on the look in Adora's eyes. A look of utter desperation and wanting to be over this burden. It was taking everything in Catra to not latch onto her, to use her body as a shield against this nightmare.

She had to choose. There was no time to push this off any longer.

"It's okay. I'm ready" Catra said.

"No" Adora firmly replied.

"Adora…" Catra grabbed her hands, tears forming in her eyes.

“No. No whatever happens I’m not leaving. I’m staying with you.”

.....

“Ugh fine. That one!” Catra yelled and pointed to the burgundy paint sample on the wall. There were easily a dozen different strips of wall painted in a variety of colors around the room.

“See that wasn’t so hard you dork” Adora said wrapping her arm around Catra’s shoulder and leaning in to kiss her neck. Catra rolled her eyes but smiled and wrapped her arms around Adora’s waist.

“Alright job’s done. Now can we go lay down?” Catra said as she worked kisses and light bites down her neck. Claws gently asking for more.

“Don’t think you can distract me that easily. Come on Catra. We’ve only got a few more boxes left.”

“You owe me” Catra grumbled.

With Eternia doing well, extremely well actually, the Best Friend Squad all moved into the upstairs apartment. They had just finished moving the last few boxes in the new home when all four of them collapsed onto the couch, legs tangled up.

“I’m never moving again” Bow said with his head leaning on the back of the couch and Glimmer resting on him.

“At least you didn’t have to move your girlfriend’s weight set. Seriously Adora. You work at a gym. You don’t need weights at home” Catra said teasingly as she nuzzled into Adora’s chest, legs up on the couch next to Glimmer’s.

“But I like being able to work out at home too. And I thought you liked watching me lift” Adora said placing a kiss in her hair. Catra did like watching her, sneaking kisses in between her sets, trying to distract her. Most of the time Adora was too focused to be distracted but every once in a while, Catra won.

The gang hung out on the couch for a few hours, ordering pizza and just relaxing after the hard work of moving. They still had a lot to unpack but at least everything was inside. Everybody decided to head to bed early so they said goodnight and went off to their rooms. Adora had started to pull her hair tie out to let her hair down when Catra grabbed her wrist.

"You owe me still remember" she whispered into Adora's ear as she pressed her body against her muscular back. She turned around in the embrace and easily lifted up Catra to have her legs wrap around her.

"Oh yeah?" Adora said with a smirk.

Catra's claws gently dug into her shoulders as she leaned in to playfully bite Adora's ear. "Do you know where you packed it?"

Adora let out a small gasp and grabbed Catra harder, pulling her body in tighter. "I don't know what you're talking about."

"Don't play dumb Adora. You know exactly what I'm talking about." Catra let her claws dig in a little harder and nipping at Adora's neck. The whimpering moan that Adora let out was heaven to her ears, driving her on further.

"Okay…just…okay I need a second to find the box" Adora said, trying to catch her breath, as she put Catra down. She started rummaging through the piles of boxes while Catra went to the bed. Adora finally found it and went off to the bathroom. Catra sat and leaned back on the bed, her arms holding her up.

"I don't have all day princess" Catra called.

Adora walked out wearing the white and gold trimmed outfit that she had worn to her ninja race. Catra gasped. Even after all the times she had asked Adora to wear the outfit it still took her breath away. She bit her lip as she looked Adora up and down. She would have been happy to just drink in her image all day but Adora walked over and pushed her down, getting on top of her on the bed. Catra felt her heart racing as she took shallow breaths.

“Hey Catra…is this what you wanted” she asked as her eyes burned with want. She took Catra’s hands and pulled them both above her head, pressing her weight down to hold her in place.

“Fuck” was all Catra could whisper before Adora took her.

Four months

Adora had mapped out nearly every detail of what her proposal might look like. She had kept meticulous notes in her binders, she had somehow managed to keep it down to three *very full* binders, chalk full of dividers and sticky notes, and a single color vision board, all hidden at the Crimson Waste because Catra was very nosey and would for sure find it at home. There were details on anything and everything from Catra’s favorite color to most romantic locations in the city to general etiquette about proposal techniques.

The only small hitch in her plans was figuring out when. There anniversary was still almost seven months away and she didn’t want to wait that long. It was late spring now which mean she could choose a romantic picnic or wait for a romantic walk through the changing leaves in the fall. There were just so many romantic options but would Catra want any of them? Was she overthinking things? Absolutely but she didn’t know any other way.

Three months

Catra had snuck to the back office no less than three times between the morning and early afternoon rush to browse for horse drawn carriage rentals. She groaned and let her head slump forward onto the desk. Why did this seem so complicated? Would Adora want a carriage ride? A breathy laugh escaped her lips as she imagined the dorky smile on Adora’s face being paraded around downtown. Yeah, she would be embarrassed but obviously love it.

"Okay. Well here's the deal. We go one round, winner takes all. You win, I'll wash dishes for an entire weekend here and I borrow your boat. I win, you let me borrow your boat, no dishes." She stared at him as intensely as possible, eyebrows arched, daring him to defy the challenge.

"That's a terrible deal. Two weekends and you bring Bow with so I can tell him more of my fantastic and daring exploits." Sea Hawk countered.

"One weekend."

"Yes well…You've got yourself a deal. Let me show you how it's done lassie." Adora reached out to shake on the deal and squeezed just a little harder than normal, enjoying the muffled whimper of pain from Sea Hawk. Neither tore their gaze away from the intense eye contact as they leaned over the table preparing for the ultimate arm-wrestling challenge. Adora was confident she could win. She wouldn't let herself think about any other outcome. Each of them tensed their arms in preparation.

"Umm doesn't Catra like hate water?" Mermista asked from where she was leaning against the counter looking bored as always.

Shit. Adora hadn't thought of that. She didn't tear her gaze away form her competition as she responded. "She hates being *in* water. She's fine with being *around* water. I think."

"You think?"

Mermista's sarcastic tone was making Adora doubt every single plan she'd been working on for months. She shook her head as if trying to physically remove the doubt that was muddling her mind. Catra had liked the beach so she would like being on a boat. And they could always stay at the dock if she didn't like it. "I know what I'm doing Mermista. And if you'll excuse me, I'm about to kick your boyfriend's butt. Well his arm. Kick his arm's butt? Ugh whatever. Are you ready Sea Hawk?"

“This is so dumb. Ready? Three-two-one-go or whatever” Mermista groaned as she walked closer to watch.

Both tensed at the same time, locking their arms in place with terrifying strength. Adora grunted and strained with the effort but wasn’t able to gain any ground in the fight. A small bead of sweat formed at her brow while Sea Hawk tried to look as poised and calm as ever.

“You call this a challenge? I once defeated a bodybuilder with arms the size of watermelons. I-”

Mermista leaned down and whispered something in his ear, distracting him for only a second but plenty of time for Adora to slam his hand down to the table.

“That’s cheating! Even if it was because of you my lovely Mermista.”

“Shouldn’t have let yourself get distracted Sea Hawk.” She got up from the table and shook out her arm. That would hurt tomorrow but she won. “What’d you say anyways?”

Mermista blushed. “Look I like you or whatever but I was not about to listen to shanties all weekend long if you lost.”

Adora opened her mouth to respond, obviously she knew she would have won no matter what but shrugged instead. The thought of doing dishes *and* listening to shanties all weekend sent an involuntary shiver down her spine.

Sea Hawk got up from the table and flipped his hair. “Truth be told. I let you win because I would be honored to have my boat, *Dragon’s Dauther Three*, to be used in what will be a beautiful and bold romantic gesture of love.”

Dragon’s Daughter Three? There was a story there for another time. Adora snorted and called over her shoulder, “I’ll let you know the date when things get closer. Thanks Sea Hawk. Bye Mermista.”

Two and a half months

"Are you sure it's legal?" Adora asked.

Silence. Entrapta stared at her blankly, no emotion or expression conveyed on her face.

"The fireworks?"

Entrapta blinked but continued to stare.

"The fireworks?... for my proposal?... to Catra that I just asked you about ten minutes ago?"

Adora was trying to be patient but if Entrapta couldn't remember the conversation they just had she was going to lose it. Finally, a look of understanding and a devious smile indicated that she remembered. "Oh! Those fireworks! Yes, well my research indicates that it is not necessarily legal but there are no current city guidelines against the use of homemade fireworks in public parks."

That response was…unsettling to say the least. But Catra loved fireworks and she had to have them or things wouldn't be perfect. She'd contacted a few local companies that put-on shows but the price had been extravagant and so here she was, asking Entrapta to rig up some potentially lethal homemade fireworks in a public park where it was most definitely not legal to fire them off. Was it smart? Absolutely not, but every time she thought about the look on Catra's face when she saw fireworks it made her more determines to go ahead with the dangerous plan.

"Alright…Just try not to blow anything up until the proposal. And let me know if you need money for supplies. Not sure if you need like tools or…actually it's probably better the less I know."

"Are you sure? I could show you how to rig multiple visco fuses together to get a *really* big explosion!"

"No no no no no. I mean I appreciate the offer but…I have to go help Catra. With a thing. At the place. So I should go. Thanks again Entrapta….And don't blow yourself up."

"No promises! Bye Adora!"

Two months

Adora was pretty set on the late summer since it had been unseasonably hot recently and Catra was still seemed really stressed with the new shop. She'd also managed to find the perfect ring while she was out for her early morning run. A simple white gold band with a ruby placed in it. In all the time they dated Catra had only worn jewelry a few times so a big diamond ring was really not going to be her thing. She had snuck a piece of string around her finger while Catra was sleeping one night so that she could measure to make sure the fit was right. The band would fit perfectly.

Catra had woken up as Adora fiddled with her finger in her sleep. She faked sleeping and kept her breathing slow and even, but her heart was racing. Adora was taking ring measurements. Shit. She thought had more time still.

The next morning, she woke up and stole a ring from Adora's small jewelry box, it had a horse on it because of course Adora would have a horse jewelry box. Now she just had to find a ring that would be perfect.

As soon as Adora had left for work, Catra had to beg Glimmer to go ring shopping with her. She'd almost gagged when she asked for help and nearly gouged her eyes out when an overly helpful salesperson asked if Glimmer was her fiancée but after the fourth store they managed to find a ring set. A plain white gold band, so she could wear it to the gym, and another with small diamonds set into the band with a larger princess cut diamond in the center.

One month

“Please please please please please please please” Adora begged. She fell to her knees, hands knotted as if in prayer and put on what she hoped was her best ‘sad puppy dog eyes.’

“Dear…I think we should let them. Catra does seem to be much more…gentle? No, not that word... Kind?...anyways she seems a *better* person since being with Adora.” Spinerella had turned Netossa to face her. Adora didn’t let up her guilt trip though.

Netossa’s shoulders hiked up before letting out a deep exasperated sigh. “If EITHER of you breaks anything or things get out of hand like last time I’m banning you for life.”

In a flash Adora was standing, picking up Netossa and spinning her around. “Thank you thank you thank you.” She handed off the flustered Netossa to her wife and was running out the doors excitedly before they could change their minds.

Two weeks

Adora had managed to keep the proposal a secret for months now and although it felt like she was going to literally explode from keeping it to herself, it was better than actually letting Catra in on her plans.

“Hey Catra” she said trying to be casual and knowing she was anything but that. Her heart racing, her palms sweaty, and leaning against the doorframe a little too heavily to look anything but drunk was not a good look on her so when Catra took one glance at her and asked, “you been day drinking princess?” , she figured one more lie couldn’t hurt her.

“Ha good one Catra. I just had a drink…with Glimmer. Drinks with Glimmer at brunch. You know how friends do that? Totally normal brunch with drinks and Glimmer and…”

“Woah calm down. I didn’t ask for your whole life story” Catra cut her off.

“Right. Sorry. Weird day. Anyways do you want to go on a date with me?”

“Um Adora… we are dating. How many drinks did you have?”

“Just one. Or two. It doesn’t matter. I’m getting confused. Let me start over.” Catra chuckled but sat patiently waiting for Adora to continue. The mischievous smirk doing nothing to help Adora from further derailing this train wreck of a plan. “So I just thought we could do like a date night since you’ve been really busy with the shop. It’s been awhile since we did anything really just the two of us and I guess I just miss you.”

Catra got up from where she had been sitting and wrapped her arms around Adora, pressing their foreheads together. “I’m right here dummy.” Adora sighed but didn’t respond further. The tension in her shoulders and jaw slowly lessening in the embrace. A small tinge of guilt flooded Catra at the realization that her girlfriend had to ask for her to be around enough for a date. Sure, she had been busy with the shop and working her ass off but she’d been trying to make time for Adora when she could.

Taking a second to really think about it Catra realized that this could work out well for her proposal plans. She hadn’t picked a date yet but if Adora was wanting to do a fancy date then she could make that work. “A date night sounds great though. I have a lot going on with the shop in the next week, but could we plan for after that? I can take the day off and let Scorpia figure things out.”

Adora smiled so wide it looked painful before angling her head to press their lips together. “It’s a date.”

Five days

“I’m leaving for a bit. I’ll be back soon. Try not to burn the place down.”

"Ooo Wildcat where you going? Top secret mission for the coffee shop? Gosh how cool would that be? You could wear a disguise-"

Catra groaned and pulled Scorpia into the back office leaving a speechless Lonnie to run the shop for a minute. She'd survive. "Look if you tell anyone I'll kill you but…I'm going to propose to Adora this weekend."

She shut her eyes tight and flinched, bracing for the forceful impact of a hug that….didn't happen. That was strange. She peeked one eye open to look at Scorpia who was crying? "That's… just…so…beautiful. I mean obviously I knew you were going to propose at some point but gosh this is exciting." Catra didn't have time to brace for the hug that time and was wrapped so tightly between pincers that she swore she heard a rib pop. Not to mention the tears of joy dripping onto her fur.

"Scorpia please. Can't. Breathe." Catra wheezed and sucked in air as the force that is Scorpia relented.

"I'm so happy for you Wildcat. If you need anything and I mean ANYTHING just let me know. I am here for you one hundred percent."

"Thanks…I-I'm lucky to have you. But for now, I need to go order some flowers from Perfuma."

Crap. With all of Adora's meticulous planning she hadn't thought about getting flowers for the fancy dinner on the boat. And it was less than a week away! She yelled some half incoherent excuse to Huntara and set off to run across town to Perfuma's shop. She could get a workout in by running there and back and hopefully she wouldn't be too upset that Adora was putting in such a last-minute order.

She was barely breathing hard by the time she rounded the last corner before Perfuma's shop and ran directly into someone, knocking them over and falling onto them on the sidewalk. She

was practically straddling the poor person she tackled and could feel her entire face blushing.

"Hey Adora" Catra said with a smirk from underneath her. "At some point I think I have to start blaming myself for being an idiot magnet or something."

She let out a snort before giving her a quick kiss. "Yeah well it's not cause I like you. What are you doing over here anyways?" She swore there was half a second of panic on Catra's face before she went back to smirking and pushing Adora off her.

"Wouldn't you like to know" she said with a wink and a quick peck to Adora's cheek before running away.

"Bye I guess" she muttered to herself as she headed into Perfuma's. That was odd even for Catra.

"Adora! It's so good to see you again. How have you been? Have you been meditating and drinking the tea that I gave you last time? Tell me, how's your aura? No wait. I'm sensing…green? No red. Definitely red."

"Umm not sure about all that but the tea has been great. Thanks again. Anyways, I'm sorry to put in a sort of last-minute order but is there any way I can get a few bouquets for later this week?

"Oh that's no trouble Adora. It wont even be my first last minute order of the day." Perfuma's eye twitched slightly but she continued to smile.

One day

"So….you ready for tomorrow?" Adora asked, her hands in her pockets and drawing circles on the floor with the toe of her shoe.

"Huh? Oh yeah the weekly shipment comes in. Real exciting stuff." Catra rolled her eyes and continued working on the computer in the back office.

Had she forgotten? Was she going to come into work and ruin all of Adora's hard work?

Catra rolled her eyes and gave her a playful shove. "I'm just messing with you princess. No, I didn't forget about the date. You should have seen the look on your face though. Priceless."

Adora sighed before laughing. Okay good. She hadn't forgotten and just wanted to tease her mercilessly about a proposal that she had no idea about. "Ha great joke!" Was she shouting? She didn't mean to be. Keeping secrets was pure torture but it was just one more day.

Today

Catra groaned as she woke up, attempting to force her sleep heavy eyelids to open. Blindly reaching out across the bed she found…nothing. That was strange. Adora didn't work today. Obviously. That's why after months and months of making plans she was finally ready to propose today. That's why she'd taken a full day off for the first time since the shop opened. No working herself ragged. No popping in to check on how things were going. Today was all about Adora and everyone else could fuck right off.

Her fingers traced over the wrinkles in the sheets where Adora had slept. Cold. So she'd been up for a while then. Catra stretched, a few joints popping as stiff limbs protested, before getting up to begin the search for the missing girl. Melog eyed her suspiciously from the foot of the bed but made no attempts to move. The kitchen was empty and a cursory glance over the living room proved it to be empty as well. A small knot of anxiety started to form in Catra's stomach; it wasn't like Adora to sneak out this early in the morning. At least now without leaving a note or a text and she'd already checked her phone and found nothing.

As if on cue, Adora's signature hair poof came bounding up the steps and into the apartment carrying a small white box. "Sorry I thought I'd be back before you woke up but I saw this really cute dog on the way and it was just so cute Catra."

Dogs were gross but at least she was okay. Besides the box was a far more pressing matter. “Watcha got there princess?”

“This? Mmm s’nothin” Adora said with that signature cocky grin that always drove Catra up a wall. And it would have right then if she hadn’t shifted the box to one hand and scooped up Catra like she was a weightless sack of potatoes, hoisting her over her shoulder. There was a scared squeak but who could say where it came from. Probably Melog. The same Melog who was still sleeping in the bedroom and nowhere in sight. Yep. Must have been them.

Adora carried her girlfriend back to the bedroom and threw her not so gently down onto the bed, landing with a loud thud. When Catra finally got situated, pouting with her arms crossed on the bed, Adora got distracted by how good she looked. The pair of short shorts and one of Adora’s shirts turned crop top was practically making her drool. The strip of belly fur exposed between the shirt and shorts that Adora happened to know was the softest and best fur was just begging to be touched. Her long hair had been hastily put up in a very messy ponytail, the sunlight filtering through the curtains casting golden rays on her freckled cheeks, her pouting lips slowly turning up into a lopsided curious grin. It almost made Adora want to propose right then and there... Almost.

“Etheria to Adora. You in there?”

She was still too enamored to respond, still too lost in the beauty that was Catra. She bit her lip and tried to focus back on the task at hand. She offered the box to Catra. “Beautiful food…I mean tiny. Tiny food. For you.”

“Dork” Catra said as she took the box and opened it up revealing an assortment of mini scones, mini croissants, and mini cupcakes.

Adora shrugged and flopped down on the bed, taking a tiny cupcake from the box. “Entrapta recommended the bakery. I

guess they only do tiny food."

Catra shrugged back at her and grabbed a scone, popping the whole thing into her mouth. The way her eyes lit up made Adora genuinely happy. She was just… so overwhelmingly happy to be with Catra and to be loved by her. Sitting there in bed with Catra. Yeah. Everything was perfect.

They spent the morning being lazy in bed, sneaking downstairs for coffee, feeding each other mini desserts, and just catching up on some much-needed rest and relaxation. By mid-afternoon though "relaxation" was becoming too much for Adora. She could only lay in bed for so long unless there were…other activities happening. Sure, there had been some…activities but they were trying to pace themselves. They did have all day anyways.

Catra was just about to go for her another catnap when she felt Adora getting antsy. That girl really could not figure out how to relax. It was always *go go go*. Always pushing herself to help others and never taking a second to take care of herself. It was honorable but entirely frustrating and Catra was going to make sure that Adora relaxed today. She wasn't afraid to play dirty to ensure it too. She shifted from laying next to Adora to draping herself completely over her and nuzzling into her neck, essentially trapping her because she was too damn obsessed with her "magically soft fur" as she once had put it. Adora's hand immediately moving from tapping anxiously on the bed to tracing circles across her exposed midriff. Catra let out a calculated soft purr knowing Adora would try to make her purr louder. Sure enough, a hand shifted up her side to her ear. She leaned into the touch letting the rumbling in her chest amplify to a deafening volume. A perfectly timed nuzzle and mewl into Adora's neck and she was slowly relaxing putty in Catra's hands. Well she would have been if there hadn't been a new deafening loud sound, a stomach growl.

"Catra" Adora whined.

"Uh uh. Nap time."

"You've already had *three* naps Catra."

Hmpf. She wanted to argue more about the importance of sleeping but she was hungry too.

Maybe if she fell asleep again she could- Nope. Another stomach growl and a whine from Adora meant she wasn't going to get to put this off any longer.

"Finnneeeee. I guess we can go to lunch or whatever."

Adora was sitting up and excitedly *shoving*, more forcefully than necessary because of course she didn't know her cyborg strength, Catra off within seconds. She had to really scramble for purchase on the bed to make sure she didn't get thrown off onto to the floor. Any other time she would have been glaring at cursing her out but the sheepish grin and the fact that she was proposing so she had to be *nice* today kept her retort to a simple sticking out of her tongue.

After a very quick no nonsense shower they changed into some nicer clothes for the day. Adora opted for her red dress from Pride Prom since it was comfortable to wear and the necklace that Catra had gotten her for her birthday. She had debated on the white suit she had that clearly Catra liked but decided it would be too risky since she'd be eating twice. Not to mention the dress would give her optimal range of motion for laser tag and this dress had pockets so she could hide the ring in there. Catra picked out her maroon suit pants and a navy blue blouse. She had left a few too many buttons to be "appropriate" unbuttoned and Adora bit her lip as she stared at the soft fur peaking out. Catra rolled her eyes and smirked before walking off to find her shoes. Doing her best to shake the distraction, Adora headed for the kitchen and grabbed a basket from the fridge that Bow and Glimmer had made while they had been napping. Bow's voice had cracked multiple times as he excitedly planned out different foods to put in

the basket. “I thought we could do a picnic in the park. But I mean if that’s not alright we can figure something else out…” Adora rubbed the back of her neck nervously.

“Shut up….I mean it sounds great. You don’t have to get all-” Catra gestured her hands at Adora’s entire body “…you or whatever. I like when you take charge. And not just in the bedroom.” Her wiggling eyebrows and toothy smile made Adora blush and laugh. Right. Confidence. Totally got this.

Adora was starving. Not quite about to die of starvation but if Catra took any longer finding her shoes she might be tempted to eat said shoes. If she just organized her shoes in the shoe rack that Adora had got her or put her clothes away… Her stomach growled again. There was no time for this. Scooping Catra up in one arm and a pair of sandals and the food in the other she carried them out the apartment. “Need. Food. Now.”

“Alright alright! Just put me down already before you drop me or something. And give me my shoes, you weird terminator.”

Adora set her down and started forcing the sandals onto her feet before Catra snatched them away to do it herself. “Okay first of all. They’re *my* shoes. Secondly, terminator?” She took the hand that Adora offered to help her back up and they were finally on their way.

“You’re a cyborg blah blah blah are we going to lunch or not?”

…

The sun felt warm on Catra’s fur as she sprawled out lazily nibbling at food. Adora on the other hand was practically hunched over an enormous mass of food that she had pulled out of the basket and started inhaling. It was impressive, terrifying, and hilarious all in one. “Slow down princess. Cant choke before I get to-” Catra stopped right before saying ‘propose’. Shit. And now Adora was staring at her looking confused, crumbs all over her chin. “-Before I get to whoop your butt in laser tag.” Good save.

“How…how do you know about that?”

“Pfft. Please. You think you’re all sneaky.” The look on Adora’s face was more hurt than she had been expecting. Sure Catra had found out about the conditional lifting of their laser tag ban but Adora shouldn’t be that upset. She grabbed a napkin to wipe the crumbs off her face. “Netossa told me. Well more like she threatened to lock me in a room with Sea Hawk’s mixtape playing on full blast… She’s seriously messed up.” Adora’s furrowed brow relaxed and she went back to eating albeit slower. The reaction seemed…weird but Adora was always weird.

Adora *promised* to Netossa, to Spinerella, to herself that things would not get out of control with laser tag this time.

And she had tried her best to keep that promise.

Like tried really hard.

INCREDIBLY hard.

And she really had started out by being her best self. Not an overly competitive crazed person. Not someone using small children as human shields.

But then Catra had started fighting dirty.

Covering her target with her hand. Trying to sneak in and sweep her leg. Hiding in the rafters.

And well…

“Yeah you better run! You’re banned for life!” Netossa was screaming at them as they ran through the front doors.

Spinerella was there trying to pull her very angry wife back inside. “Good luck on your date dear. Please don’t come back here!”

An overwhelming sense of déjà vu flooded Adora as they ran to hide in the back alley. Leaning against the cool wall. Her hands on Catra's hips. Her flushed face laughing as she caught her breath. The glint of streetlamps reflecting in her mismatch eyes. She was just as beautiful as the last time they had been here and Adora wanted to kiss her just as badly. There was no fear holding her back this time. No indecision as she reached her arm up to the back of Catra's neck and pulled her closer till their lips met. Déjà vu faded as Catra melted into her.

Adora pulled away from the kiss after a few moments. "I can't believe I kicked your butt in there. After all that big talk earlier."

Catra rolled her eyes and smiled. "I let you win princess. I didn't want to listen to you cry and be a sore loser all night."

"Mmhmm whatever you say Catra. What's my prize for winning?"

"Stop hiding in this back alley like a weirdo and you'll find out." Before she could even protest being called a weirdo Catra was grabbing her hand and dragging her to the front where a horse drawn carriage was waiting. The carriage driver spotted them and held the door open patiently. The large white thoroughbred horse was far less patiently stomping a hoof into the pavement.

"No way." Adora had stopped so abruptly that Catra had nearly fallen.

She just barely registered Catra pulling her forward. "Yes way. Now come on." And with that she was now pushing Catra forward and up into the carriage.

Catra had spent *a lot* of time searching for the right carriage service. Not just because it was the most important date of her life or anything so simple like that. No. Because Adora was a ridiculously hopeless horse girl. Because she knew that there was no way Adora would want to sit quietly in the carriage like some lovesick puppy holding hands while they were paraded around the

city. So here Catra was, sitting in the carriage by herself while her beautiful weird horse nerd girlfriend was sitting up next to the carriage driver rattling off question after question about the horse.

"What's their name? How long have you worked here? Is it fun? Do you get to take care of the horses? Can I feed them?"

The driver chuckled. "This here's Swift Wind. He's a new edition to our team. Bit of a troublemaker if I'm being honest. Been known to sneak off and eat apples out of the orchard next to the barns."

Adora turned around, eyes sparkling and a smile of child-like wonder. "This is the best day of my life." Catra just laughed, trying not to think too hard about how amazing Adora looked in the waning evening light or how she needed to propose soon. She fiddled anxiously with the ring in her pocket and enjoyed the view.

So Adora knew that she should be in the back with Catra but she had insisted that she sit up here and not 'annoy her with weird horse love', which secretly she was grateful. Swift Wind was *such* a beautiful horse and she wouldn't have been able to appreciate it him from back in the carriage. She snuck a glance back at Catra who looked bored but in good spirits.

She'd been sitting quietly next to the driver for the last few minutes, just enjoying the ride around the city, when they spoke up. "Now Catra didn't give me a specific destination. Just said that you would want to ride around all night with me."

"Oh…well in that case could you take us down to the marina?"

"The marina huh? Yeah I don't suppose why not. Should be there in just about ten minutes."

"Perfect. I'm just gonna hop in the back but thanks for letting me meet Swifty. He seems really great." Adora did her best to gracefully step over the arch of the carriage and into the seating area but her foot got caught at the last second and she landed face first into Catra's lap.

“Geesh. Buy a girl dinner first Adora.”

Adora blushed and adjusted to a sitting position, smoothing out the wrinkles in her dress before leaning in and kissing Catra’s cheek. “Thank you. This is amazing.”

“Got one more thing here for you princess.” Catra leaned down and grabbed a small container from underneath the seat. “I uh wasn’t sure what you were wearing today but figured this would look good with the two colors you wear: red or white.” She pulled a small white rose corsage from the container and placed it on Adora’s wrist before attaching a matching rose lapel pin to her shirt.

Adora snorted. “I wear more than two colors….I think.” Taking a mental log of her closet it was overwhelmingly red and white… Well she knew what she looked good in at least. “Wait… was that why you were at Perfuma’s the other day?”

“No!...Maybe!” Catra tried to look annoyed but ended up smiling. It was a cute look on her but she’d keep that to herself for now in order to prevent from annoying her further.

She checked to make sure the ring was still in her dress pocket for the millionth time tonight as the carriage stopped at the marina. She wasn’t sure exactly what Sea Hawk’s boat looked like but it seemed a safe bet that it was the one with lights strung up over the stays and spiraling down the mast. She looked closer and noticed Sea Hawk waving enthusiastically on the deck.

“Adora? Why are we here?” Catra asked as they hopped out.

“For dinner silly. Gimme one sec to say goodbye to Swifty.” She gave the horse a quick pat on the neck and whispered to him. “Wish me luck buddy.” Swift Wind neighed and blinked at her. That would have to do.

“Okay so-”

Catra cut her off. “Were you just talking to that horse?”

Adora felt the blush rise on her cheeks. "I…was hoping you didn't hear that. But yes." Catra cackled at her. "But anyways. I thought we could do dinner here. We don't have to go out on the water if you don't want." Adora reached her hand out and Catra took it as they walked down the dock to Sea Hawk.

"Good evening ladies. I'll be your host on this wonderous adventure!" He stared as them for a second before clearing his throat. "Excuse me… right this way. Welcome aboard the Dragon's Daughter Three."

"You… set all this up?...For me?" Catra asked as she gestured around at the boat. The lights. The flowers decorating the mast and boom. The table covered in sushi. Drinks with little umbrellas in them. Adora had gone overboard, a terrible pun she refused to say out loud, with making this date special. It was *so* much. Too much really. Catra just stood there trying to process how Adora could go so far to make a date this memorable.

Adora's warm smile came into view. "Hey Catra." A gently placed hand on her arm grounding her back in the moment. Too damn thoughtful and caring and everything Catra wanted. Had wanted since they met.

Catra blinked a few times to focus her vision. "Hey Adora?" Her words came out barely a whisper.

"Come on. Let's sit down. I'm hungry."

She was still barely able to fathom all of this as Adora led her over to the table. Adora sat down and immediately picked up her chopsticks. Catra prepared for the sushi massacre and watched in utter shock as she deftly picked up a roll on the first try and popped it into her mouth. "Okay who are you and what have you done with my Adora?"

Adora looked up at her, mouth still full of sushi, and then down to her chopsticks before blushing. "Oh um I've been practicing. I

wanted to impress you."

"You practiced eating with chopsticks?"

Adora shrugged. "It was kind of fun. Noodles are still impossible though so no ramen unless you want to wear it on your shirt." She got a faraway look in her eyes and shivered. "So many noodles… everywhere."

"You are…." What word couldn't she put to finish the sentence? Amazing? Beautiful? An idiot? The love of Catra's life? There was so many options. So many words that she wanted to say but couldn't quite figure out how to articulate them. Reaching across the table she grabbed Adora's wrist, the sushi halfway to her mouth falling dramatically back onto the table before falling apart. "I love you."

"I love you too Catra." The smile Adora was giving her flooded her with so much warmth. The way her dark blue eyes reflected in the light, the flowers on her wrist and arranged around her. This was the moment that Catra had been waiting for.

Catra was reaching for the ring in her pocket when Sea Hawk came over. Seriously? Could he not see he was killing the moment? "Sorry to disturb your wonderful evening but I thought I might inquire if we planned to set sail tonight?"

Adora looked at her expectantly. "Totally up to you."

Catra was still scowling at Sea Hawk. "Yeah sure whatever."

"ADVENTU- I mean very well. Prepare to set sail."

By the time Sea Hawk left Catra didn't feel like the timing was right anymore. So she just had to find another perfect moment. They were on a ridiculously romantic date. Couldn't be too hard right?

They had just finished eating when the boat left the dock. Sea Hawk had opted for the electric trolling motor, which was just fine

for Catra. No obnoxious sails to duck under, no loud gas motor stinking up the air. It was just her and Adora… and hopefully a very scarce Sea Hawk.

Adora took her hand again as they walked over to the starboard side to admire the view of the night sky. While Adora may have been admiring the sky, Catra was entirely focused on how beautiful her girlfriend looked. This moment felt right. Maybe not as good as before but damn close. Catra quickly reached for the ring again, glancing back at Sea Hawk to make sure he was still there. She was just starting to kneel when the first firework went off on the shore nearby. She screamed and nearly jumped off the boat in the panic.

"What the fuck was that?" She looked as another rocket lit up, she was just barely able to make out the outline of someone on the shore waving at them. Their enormous pigtails flagging the sides of their head. Entrapta. Of course. Who else would be setting off fireworks *very illegally* in the park in the middle of the night?

Catra was quickly lost in the sight of the impressive display. Explosion after explosion lighting up everything around them. She could hear Adora making cute dumb sounds after each one and grabbed her hand without looking over. The finale was amazing, strobes clouding the sky while pistils and brocades blasted over and over. Willows and waterfalls cascaded down towards them threatening to reach all the way down to the boat. And the colors. She'd never even seen bright pink fireworks before.

Screw all those other moments. Right at the end of the most amazing fireworks she'd ever seen. This was totally her moment. The ring was already in her hand.

She turned to look back at Adora…who was kneeling…ring in her hand. "Catra…will you marry me?"

It took a few seconds for her brain to stop short circuiting to realize what had happened. The elaborate date. Adora planning out laser tag and the boat dinner. Hell, even seeing her at

Perfuma's the week before. This had never just been a date for either of them. They'd both been planning this for months. She felt so stupid for not seeing the signs before.

"Catra…Kind of…getting nervous here-" Adora chuckled nervously, fidgeting in the position looking as if she wanted to stand or move.

"Shut up." Okay. That came out way harsher than she wanted.

Adora had stopped talking, mouth partially opening, looking like she was going to cry any second. Shit shit shit. She could fix this still. Get it together Catra. Quickly digging into her pocket, she pulled the ring out that she had hidden there and got down on one knee in front of Adora. "Marry me."

Adora was just shaking her head vigorously up and down, tears streaming down her face. If Catra was crying too who could say because right now all that mattered was that she kiss Adora. She lunged forward, more of an awkward shamble since they were both down on a knee, and pressed their lips together. It was a terrible kiss since they were both smiling and crying.

It was perfect.

Adora laughed giddily. "Wow"

"Don't ruin it" was all Catra said before she kissed her again. Lost entirely to the moment as if nothing outside of their lips and hands existed.

Another blast of fireworks lit up the sky and Catra pulled away from the kiss laughing. "Okay when you go big you go BIG. Seriously Adora this is amazing."

Adora smiled and pulled her back closer. "Don't ruin it." Catra snorted, leaning forward to kiss her again.

Chapter End Notes

There's gonna be a tiny epilogue but this is pretty much it. You made it! Congrats :)
As always, comments are greatly appreciated. Will gladly fix typos as people point them out too.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

Plans within plans

Chapter Notes

Alright first of all let me say a giant THANK YOU to everyone who's read this and commented and kudo'd. You're all wonderful people and all the encouragement really helped me get through this story. Not to mention reading all the other dope fics out there has gotten me through some stuff.

This epilogue isn't really much but I wanted to leave it on a goofy/not making people cry/ more lighthearted feel.

me: *finishes fanfic*
me: ahh yes. finally free from every waking thought being consumed by this story. I can go back to doing homework and-
my brain: hey you wanted another fanfic idea right? you dont need to do homework right???
aka- I'll be working on something else but probably wont be posting for quite awhile while I get caught up on being a human again :)

The walk home from the marina had been full of quiet giggles and bright smiles as they held hands and enjoyed the feel of the moment. The stress of months of planning had been relieved and the stress of planning for many more months hadn’t yet sunk in. They walked past the front of the coffee shop on the way up to the apartment and Catra noticed a light had been left on inside. She wasn’t about to pay for extra electricity just because some idiot forgot to turn it off when they closed for the night.

“We can just go in through the shop so I can turn off that light.” Her ears flicked forward as she put the key into the lock. She

swore she heard a noise from inside. Faint like a whisper. As she unlocked the door and stepped in the lights turned on.

"SURPRISE!"

Catra jumped as everyone screamed. Adora turned so white with shock she looked like a ghost. Every friend that had apparently helped either one of them with the proposal was there. So that explained why Glimmer had text her several times asking when she'd be home.

……

"Oh my god all of you knew?" Adora exclaimed. It had taken a few moments for the two of them to calm down after the initial surprise and then a swarm of embraces and congratulations overwhelmed them in an entirely different way. Of course, many of their friends had helped one or the other with their plans but it turned out they had all been conspiring in secret to ensure the plan would be a success. From small pieces like Scorpia reassuring Catra that she wouldn't let the shop burn down to Bow overseeing the fireworks production so Entrapta wouldn't blow herself, or anyone else, up. Mermista had a similar role to Bow's when Sea Hawk had attempted to light candles on the boat and managed to light the tablecloth on fire. Every detail had been carefully planned behind the scenes by their overly protective but wonderfully thoughtful friends.

Glimmer laughed and rolled her eyes. "The two of you spent *months* working on your proposals and seriously had no idea you planned for the same day… You two are hopeless you know that right?"

"Pfft please Sparkles. I'm not hopeless" Catra said as she leaned against the wall and studied her nails.

Scorpia cleared her throat before wrapping an arm around her. "Hey Wildcat…uh hate to disagree with you here but you did use the work computer to look up horse carriage rentals for like three

days straight. Not to mention the whole ‘but Adora doesn’t like me the way that I like her conversation’ and you did kind of not so sneakily leave to ask Perfuma for advice.”

“Oh yes. Several times actually” Perfuma agreed.

Catra crossed her arms and huffed, opting to sneak away from the conversation lest be embarrassed more, but Adora grabbed her by the hips and wrapper her arms around her effectively imprisoning her into the conversation. “Traitors. Every last one of you. If you’re smart you’ll stop giving me shit. That and get out of my shop.”

Adora adjust to see around Catra. “We’ll I’m not. Leaving, that is. I am smart. N-never mind.”

Catra let out a small chuckle and kissed Adora’s cheek. “Whatever you say *fiancée.*” Making sure to really emphasize the last word. Adora smiling like a lovestruck dummy in return.

Glimmer rolled her eyes and feigned a gagging sound. “Ugh get a room already.”

“I LITERALLY OWN THIS BUILDING SPARKLES.” Catra didn’t appear to actually be upset, just playing up the angst to get back at Glimmer, but Adora tightened her grip on Catra’s waist…just in case. Both girls stuck their tongues out at each other and glared for a few seconds before breaking down into laughter.

After a few light-hearted jokes about a tenant uprising and a recap of the night, partially told by Entrapta who was missing an eyebrow and covered in soot, everyone said goodbye and left for their respective homes.

Catra took one last look at her shop before taking Adora’s hand and walking up stairs to bed, a dutiful Melog following along behind them.

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